

A STUDY OF POST-COVID VIEWERSHIP TRANSFORMATION AND INDUSTRIAL RECONFIGURATION IN TAMIL FILM INDUSTRY

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in

Media Studies / Visual Communication / Management

By

[Researcher's Name]

(Reg. No. : XXXXXXXXX)

Under the guidance of

[Supervisor's Name, Designation]

Department of Visual Communication

/ Media Studies / Management Studies

[University Name]

2026

CERTIFICATE

This is to certify that the thesis entitled “**A STUDY OF POST-COVID VIEWERSHIP TRANSFORMATION AND INDUSTRIAL RECONFIGURATION IN TAMIL FILM INDUSTRY**” submitted by [Researcher’s Name] for the award of the degree of **Doctor of Philosophy** of [University Name] is a bona fide record of original research work carried out by him/her under my supervision and guidance during the period of registration. The contents of this thesis, in full or in parts, have not been submitted to any other institute or university for the award of any degree or diploma.

Place: _____

Date: _____

[Supervisor’s Name, Designation]

Research Supervisor

Department of Visual Communication

/ Media Studies / Management Studies

[University Name]

Head of the Department

External Examiner

DECLARATION

I, [Researcher's Name], hereby declare that the thesis entitled “**A STUDY OF POST-COVID VIEWERSHIP TRANSFORMATION AND INDUSTRIAL RECONFIGURATION IN TAMIL FILM INDUSTRY**” submitted by me to the [University Name] for the award of the degree of **Doctor of Philosophy** is a record of original research work carried out by me under the guidance and supervision of [Supervisor's Name, Designation]. I further declare that this work has not formed the basis for the award of any degree, diploma, fellowship or other similar title to any candidate of any university. Wherever contributions of others are involved, every effort has been made to acknowledge the same clearly, with due reference to the literature.

Place: _____

[**Researcher's Name**]

Date: _____

(Reg. No. : XXXXXXXXX)

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[Researcher's Name]

ABSTRACT

Title: A STUDY OF POST-COVID VIEWERSHIP TRANSFORMATION AND INDUSTRIAL RECONFIGURATION IN TAMIL FILM INDUSTRY

Researcher: [Researcher's Name] **Supervisor:** [Supervisor's Name, Designation]

Department / University: Department of Visual Communication
/ Media Studies / Management Studies, [University Name]

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The COVID-19 pandemic of 2020–2022 produced a discontinuous shock to cinema worldwide, but for linguistically and culturally distinctive markets such as the Tamil film industry the disruption was both immediate and structural. Cinema halls in Tamil Nadu were shut for nearly fifteen months across two lockdown phases; theatrical releases collapsed from 233 in 2019 to 84 in 2020; OTT acquisition prices for star-led Tamil films briefly more than doubled before correcting; and direct-to-OTT releases rose from a handful in 2019 to over 170 by 2025. This thesis examines, in a single integrated framework, how Tamil-film viewership transformed and how the industry reconfigured itself in response.

The study employs a sequential mixed-methods design. A structured questionnaire was administered to a stratified sample of **400 Tamil film viewers** across Chennai and six other urban / semi-urban clusters in Tamil Nadu, capturing pre- and post-pandemic theatre attendance, OTT subscription, genre preference, co-viewing context, device of consumption, willingness-to-pay and language consumption. A second instrument, supplemented by semi-structured interviews, was administered to **50 industry specialists** – producers, directors, OTT acquisition heads, distributors, exhibitors, marketing professionals, music-label executives and trade analysts – to capture shifts in production budgets, theatrical-window negotiations, acquisition-price indices, star-fee restructuring, marketing-mix adoption and revenue-mix reconfiguration. Quantitative analysis used descriptive statis-

tics, paired *t*-tests, McNemar tests, chi-square tests of independence, ANOVA and multiple regression in SPSS 28; qualitative interviews were thematically coded in NVivo 14 using a constant-comparative approach.

Major findings. (i) Mean monthly theatre visits fell by 53% in the post-pandemic period (3.1 to 1.5 visits, $p < 0.001$), with sharper declines among 35–54 year-olds. (ii) The mean number of OTT subscriptions per household more than doubled (1.1 to 2.8) and weekly OTT viewing rose by 91%. (iii) Genre preference shifted decisively from mass-action and family drama toward thriller, realistic / indie, anthology and investigative content. (iv) Star-driven choice fell from 64% to 46% while content-driven choice rose to 54%, a statistically significant inversion. (v) The theatrical-to-OTT window shortened from a 5–8 week norm to 3–4 weeks for the majority of releases. (vi) Production budgets compressed toward the 5–15 crore band, with the proportion of greenlit films above 30 crore halving. (vii) Star fees corrected most sharply at the A- and B-list tiers (–22% to –34%) while the top tier remained relatively insulated. (viii) The revenue mix of the average Tamil release shifted from 62% theatrical / 6% OTT to 44% theatrical / 28% OTT.

The thesis develops a four-quadrant “Hybrid Equilibrium” framework that explains the new structural logic of Tamil cinema – one in which theatre and OTT are increasingly complementary rather than substitutable, content quality has overtaken star power as the dominant demand driver, and the mid-budget “story-led” film has re-emerged as the central commercial unit. Theoretical contributions are made to Diffusion-of-Innovations theory (in modelling OTT adoption in a non-Western linguistic market), to Uses & Gratifications theory (by isolating four post-pandemic gratifications), and to the disruptive-innovation paradigm (by showing how cultural-industries incumbents can co-opt rather than be displaced by digital entrants). Practical recommendations are offered for producers, exhibitors, streaming platforms, regulators and creative-economy policymakers.

Keywords: Tamil cinema; post-COVID viewership; OTT platforms; streaming; cultural industries; theatrical window; industrial reconfiguration; Diffusion of In-

novations; Uses and Gratifications; hybrid distribution.

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviation	Expansion
ARPU	Average Revenue Per User
AVOD	Advertising-supported Video On Demand
B2C	Business-to-Consumer
BO	Box-Office
BCG	Boston Consulting Group
CAGR	Compound Annual Growth Rate
CBFC	Central Board of Film Certification (India)
CFA	Confirmatory Factor Analysis
COVID-19	Coronavirus Disease 2019
D2C	Direct-to-Consumer
EFA	Exploratory Factor Analysis
EY	Ernst & Young
F&B	Food and Beverage
FDFS	First Day First Show
FICCI	Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
GEC	General Entertainment Channel
GST	Goods and Services Tax
GVA	Gross Value Added
HOI	Hours of Information / Hours of Indulgence
IPR	Intellectual Property Rights
KPMG	Klynveld Peat Marwick Goerdeler
KPI	Key Performance Indicator
M&E	Media & Entertainment (sector)
MAU	Monthly Active Users
NLP	Natural Language Processing
OTT	Over-the-Top (streaming)
PVR	Priya Village Roadshow (multiplex chain)
SPSS	Statistical Package for the Social Sciences

CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

Cinema has, for more than a century, been simultaneously an industry, an art form and an instrument of cultural identity. In the Indian subcontinent it has further functioned as a public sphere – a space where social anxieties, political imaginaries and aspirational modernities are negotiated week after week (Rajadhyaksha, 2009; Vasudevan, 2010). Within this rich landscape, Tamil cinema occupies a distinctive position. Anchored in the city of Chennai, with a continuous production history dating back to *Keechaka Vadham* (1918), the industry has developed a star-system, a fan-club culture, a music-driven release ritual and a political ecology that are arguably without parallel in any other sub-national cinema in the world (Baskaran, 1996; Velayutham, 2008). Tamil cinema is also commercially significant: in the years immediately preceding the pandemic it released over 230 films a year, generated theatrical revenue in the order of ₹1,100–1,200 crore, employed an estimated 200,000 workers directly and indirectly, and exported its content to a Tamil-speaking diaspora of roughly seventy million people across South-east Asia, the Gulf, North America and Western Europe (FICCI and EY, 2019; Kohli-Khandekar, 2013).

The decade preceding 2020 had, however, already begun to reshape the business of Tamil cinema. Multiplex penetration in Tier-2 and Tier-3 Tamil-Nadu towns had grown, satellite-television revenue from Sun TV, KTV and Vijay TV had become a critical pre-release income source for producers, and a small but rapidly growing fraction of releases were licensing their digital rights to over-the-top (OTT) platforms such as Hotstar, Amazon Prime Video and the Tamil-focused service Aha Tamil, launched in 2020 (Statista, 2023; Film Industry Council of

Tamil Nadu, 2022). Yet, until 2020, the fundamental commercial logic remained theatrical: a Tamil film was, first and foremost, an event made for the cinema hall, with all other exploitation windows organised *around* the theatrical release (Ormax Media, 2022).

It is this fundamental logic that the COVID-19 pandemic disturbed. Between March 2020 and the second half of 2021, theatres in Tamil Nadu were closed for an aggregate of nearly fifteen months (The Hindu, 2021; The Economic Times, 2021). Productions that had been planned for theatrical release were either shelved, deferred indefinitely, or sold directly to streaming platforms (Film Companion South, 2021; Variety, 2021). The disruption was not merely a temporary loss of box-office; it accelerated, telescoped and, in several respects, made permanent a set of behavioural and structural changes that were already in motion. The present thesis argues that these changes warrant being understood not as a transient shock that has now passed, but as a *structural reconfiguration* of how Tamil films are watched, by whom, on what device, in what genre, and with what economic arrangement. The dual task of this thesis is to map (a) the transformation of *viewership* on the demand side and (b) the *industrial reconfiguration* on the supply side, and to develop a framework that links them.

1.2 The COVID-19 Disruption: A Brief Context

The novel coronavirus disease (COVID-19) was declared a pandemic by the World Health Organization on 11 March 2020 (World Health Organization, 2020). In India, a nationwide lockdown commenced on 25 March 2020. Among the sectors most acutely affected was the media-and-entertainment industry: live performance, theatrical exhibition, advertising and on-set film and television production were all halted within a seventy-two-hour window (FICCI and EY, 2020; KPMG India, 2021). Although some segments such as broadcast television and streaming experienced short-term gains in time spent, the overall Indian media-and-entertainment industry contracted from ₹1.82 lakh crore in 2019 to ₹1.38

lakh crore in 2020 – a single-year decline of 24% (FICCI and EY, 2021). Within this aggregate the theatrical sub-sector experienced the steepest fall, contracting by 71% (FICCI and EY, 2021).

For Tamil cinema specifically, the empirical contours of the disruption can be summarised in five stylised facts:

1. **Cinema closure.** Tamil-Nadu theatres were closed in two phases of approximately 11 and 4 months respectively, with reduced occupancy caps even after reopening (The Hindu, 2021).
2. **Production stoppage.** An estimated 250+ Tamil productions were halted between March 2020 and August 2020; a meaningful subset (between 35 and 60 films, depending on the source) was sold directly to OTT platforms over the following twelve months (Film Companion South, 2021).
3. **OTT-acquisition spike.** Specialist interviews and trade reports indicate that acquisition prices for star-led Tamil films briefly more than doubled between mid-2020 and late-2021 before correcting in 2023–24 (Ormax Media, 2022; Media Partners Asia, 2024).
4. **Subscriber acceleration.** OTT subscriber penetration in Tamil-Nadu households is estimated to have risen from roughly 14% at the end of 2019 to 49% by the end of 2023 (Statista, 2024; KPMG India, 2023).
5. **Hybrid-window normalisation.** The 8-week theatrical-only window prevalent before 2020 has, in practice, narrowed to 3–4 weeks for the median Tamil release (Ormax Media, 2024).

These five facts are the empirical kernel of the thesis. Each is expanded, decomposed by sub-population, contextualised against the historical baseline and tested against primary survey evidence in the chapters that follow.

1.3 Tamil Film Industry: Distinctive Characteristics

While the COVID-19 disruption has generated a substantial global literature on cinema and streaming (Lobato, 2019; Tryon, 2009), the Tamil film industry presents a set of characteristics that prevent the unmodified application of frameworks developed for Hollywood, Hindi or Korean cinema:

Linguistic-cultural specificity.

Tamil is one of the oldest continuously written classical languages in the world and has long served as a vector of subnational identity for the Tamil community in India and across the diaspora (Ramaswamy, 1997; Baskaran, 2009). Cinema in Tamil is not easily substitutable by Tamil-dubbed content from other languages, although our findings on cross-language consumption (Chapter 5) reveal a meaningful softening of this rule among younger viewers.

Star-system intensity.

No major film market in the world has the density of fan-clubs, hand-painted hoardings, first-day-first-show (FDFS) rituals, opening-day milk ablutions of star portraits and politically-organised fan federations that Tamil cinema has historically had (Dickey, 1993; Pandian, 1992; Prasad, 2014). The implication for our study is that any change in the relative weight of “star” versus “content” as a demand driver is analytically consequential.

Politics-cinema continuum.

Tamil cinema’s intertwining with Dravidian politics, from C. N. Annadurai’s screenplays to M. G. Ramachandran’s chief-ministership and M. Karunanidhi’s screenwriting career, gives it an institutional dimension beyond the purely commercial (Pandian, 1992; Hardgrave, 1973).

Distinctive exhibition geography.

Tamil-Nadu has both a strong single-screen footprint (over 900 single-screens operational pre-pandemic) and rapidly expanding multiplex footprint across PVR-Inox, SPI Cinemas / Sathyam, Rohini and AGS Cinemas (Kohli-Khandekar, 2013; FICCI and EY, 2022). The relative recovery trajectories of these two formats post-pandemic are markedly different, as Chapter 4 shows.

Music-led marketing.

The audio launch – the public release of a film’s soundtrack, often months before the film itself – is a distinctively Tamil and Telugu marketing-and-revenue institution (Velayutham, 2008; Baskaran, 1996). Its post-COVID re-organisation into hybrid live-streamed events (Chapter 6) is one of several less-studied transformations that this thesis documents.

These characteristics, taken together, justify the design of an *industry-specific* study, rather than the application of a generic “Indian-cinema” framing.

1.4 Statement of the Problem

While anecdotal accounts of post-pandemic transformation in Tamil cinema are abundant in the trade press (Film Companion South, 2022; Behindwoods Editorial, 2023), three significant gaps remain in the academic literature.

First, an absence of integrated demand-supply evidence. Existing work tends to study either viewership change (Lobato, 2019; Sundet, 2021) or industrial reconfiguration (McDonald, 2007; Curtin et al., 2014), but rarely both within a single design, let alone for a sub-national language industry. The present study addresses this gap by collecting matched primary data on both sides of the market.

Second, a paucity of post-pandemic empirical studies on Tamil cinema. The most recent peer-reviewed monographs on Tamil cinema (e.g., Velayutham, 2008; Prasad, 2014; Nakassis, 2017) were authored before, or in early stages of, the pandemic and therefore do not address the structural changes documented here.

Third, methodological narrowness. A meaningful share of existing work on Indian streaming uses platform-level secondary data (KPMG India, 2022; Boston Consulting Group, 2022), which conceals heterogeneity among viewers and obscures the lived experience of industry decision-makers. The present study triangulates household-level survey data, in-depth specialist interviews, and secondary trade data within a single mixed-methods architecture.

The problem this thesis addresses can therefore be stated as follows:

To what extent, in what direction, through what mechanisms, and with what permanence has the COVID-19 pandemic transformed Tamil-film viewership behaviour, and how has the Tamil film industry reconfigured its production, distribution, exhibition and revenue arrangements in response?

1.5 Significance of the Study

The study is significant for five distinct constituencies:

1. **Academic media studies.** The thesis adds an empirical and theoretical case to the growing literature on streaming and “platform cinema” (Lobato, 2019; Tryon, 2009; Curtin et al., 2014), from a non-Western, sub-national, linguistically distinctive market that has been under-studied internationally.
2. **Producers and creators.** The supply-side findings (budget compression, genre shift, star-fee restructuring, hybrid-window negotiation) provide actionable evidence for Tamil-film producers planning their post-pandemic project slates.
3. **OTT platforms.** The viewer-side findings on platform preference, willingness-to-pay, content-versus-star priorities, and language consumption inform programming and acquisition decisions of streaming services investing in Tamil content.

4. **Exhibitors and policymakers.** Findings on the drivers of theatre-return – and on the nature of complementarity rather than substitution between theatres and OTT – feed into decisions on screen expansion, ticket pricing, GST policy on cinema and creative-industries policy in Tamil Nadu.
5. **Pedagogy.** The thesis develops course-ready material for film-business and media-management programmes in India, where systematic data on the Tamil industry is rarely available in a single integrated text.

1.6 Scope of the Study

The scope of the thesis is delimited as follows:

- **Industry.** Tamil-language theatrical and OTT-released films produced primarily in Chennai and supplementary production hubs in Coimbatore, Hyderabad and Mumbai for the Tamil-language market. Tamil-dubbed films originally produced in Telugu, Hindi, Malayalam, Kannada or English are treated only as comparators where they affect viewer choice, and not as primary objects of supply-side analysis.
- **Geography.** Tamil Nadu and the Union Territory of Puducherry, with a methodological focus on Chennai, Coimbatore, Madurai, Tiruchirappalli, Salem, Tirunelveli, and selected Tier-2 / Tier-3 / rural respondents. Diaspora viewers are excluded from primary survey for reasons of sampling tractability.
- **Time horizon.** The empirical window is 2018–2025 for secondary trend data, with primary data collected between October 2024 and June 2025. The analytical comparison is structured as “pre-COVID baseline” (calendar year 2019) versus “post-COVID post-recovery” (calendar year 2024).
- **Constructs.** Demand-side constructs covered are: theatre attendance, OTT subscription, OTT viewing hours, platform preference, genre preference,

co-viewing, device, decision-driver, language consumption, willingness-to-pay and piracy. Supply-side constructs covered are: production-budget bracket, theatrical-window length, OTT-acquisition price, star-fee structure, marketing-channel adoption, revenue-mix and employment.

1.7 Research Questions

The thesis is organised around four overarching research questions (RQ) and twelve sub-questions:

RQ1.

How has Tamil-film viewership behaviour transformed from the pre-pandemic baseline (CY 2019) to the post-pandemic period (CY 2024)? *Sub-questions: changes in theatre attendance, OTT subscription, weekly viewing hours, genre, co-viewing, device, language and decision-driver.*

RQ2.

What demographic, economic and psychographic factors moderate these changes? *Sub-questions: age, gender, location, income, education effects.*

RQ3.

How has the Tamil film industry reconfigured its production, distribution, exhibition, marketing and revenue arrangements in response to the demand-side shift? *Sub-questions: budgets, windows, acquisition prices, fees, marketing channels, revenue mix.*

RQ4.

What integrated framework best explains the post-pandemic equilibrium of Tamil cinema, and what are its theoretical, managerial and policy implications?

1.8 Research Objectives

The research questions translate into nine specific, measurable objectives:

1. To examine the change in mean monthly theatre attendance among Tamil-film viewers from 2019 to 2024.
2. To evaluate the change in mean number of OTT subscriptions and mean weekly OTT viewing hours.
3. To compare genre, co-viewing, device, time-of-viewing and language consumption pre- and post-pandemic.
4. To assess the relative weight of star-driven and content-driven choice and to test whether the relationship has inverted.
5. To estimate willingness-to-pay for Tamil-language transactional video on demand (TVOD) rentals.
6. To analyse the post-pandemic theatrical-to-OTT release window across film budget categories.
7. To document the change in OTT acquisition-price index by film tier (star-led, mid-budget, indie) and the change in revenue mix of an average Tamil release.
8. To investigate the reconfiguration of star-fee structures and production-budget brackets.
9. To synthesise demand- and supply-side findings into a framework – the “Hybrid Equilibrium of Tamil Cinema” – and to derive theoretical and managerial implications.

1.9 Hypotheses

Eight directional hypotheses are tested in Chapters 5 and 6:

- H1.** Mean monthly theatre attendance among Tamil-film viewers in 2024 is significantly lower than in 2019.
- H2.** Mean number of OTT subscriptions held in 2024 is significantly higher than in 2019.
- H3.** The proportion of viewers reporting content (rather than star) as the primary decision driver has risen significantly between 2019 and 2024.
- H4.** Genre preference has shifted significantly from “mass-action / family-drama” clusters to “thriller / realistic / anthology” clusters between 2019 and 2024.
- H5.** Age, location and income are statistically significant moderators of OTT-adoption magnitude.
- H6.** The proportion of Tamil films negotiated with a 5–8 week theatrical window has fallen significantly between 2019 and 2024 specialists’ reports.
- H7.** The share of OTT in the average Tamil-film revenue mix has risen significantly between 2019 and 2024.
- H8.** The post-pandemic OTT-acquisition price index has corrected back toward, but remains above, the 2018 baseline for star-led films.

A schematic representation of the hypothesis model is presented in Figure 3.1 (Chapter 3, Section 3.6).

1.10 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework, presented graphically in Figure 1.1, models the COVID-19 disruption as an exogenous shock that operates simultaneously through two channels – a demand-side channel (viewer behaviour) and a supply-side channel (industry reconfiguration) – whose interaction produces a new equilibrium of Tamil cinema characterised by hybrid distribution, content-led demand, smaller mid-budget films and OTT-native production. Four theoretical lenses underpin the

framework: Diffusion of Innovations (Rogers, 2003), Uses and Gratifications (Katz et al., 1973; Sundar and Limperos, 2013), Disruptive-Innovation theory (Christensen, 1997) and the Cultural-Industries paradigm (Hesmondhalgh, 2019). Each is developed in Chapter 2.

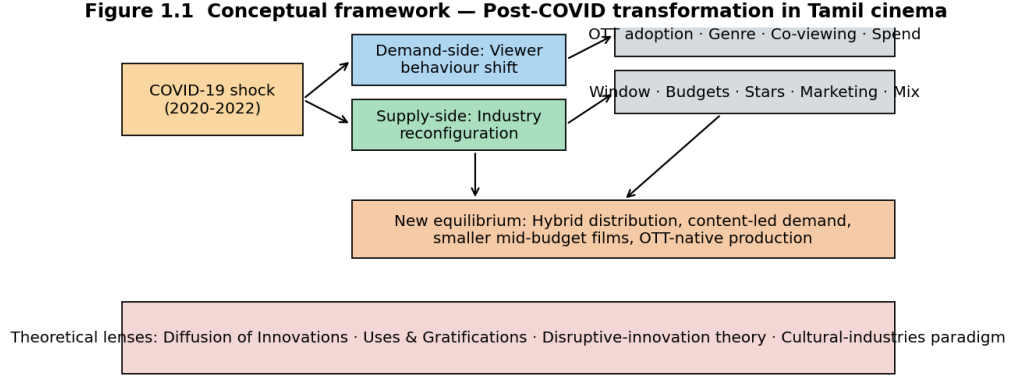


Figure 1.1. Conceptual framework – post-COVID transformation in Tamil cinema.

1.11 Operational Definitions of Key Terms

For analytical clarity the following operational definitions are adopted:

Tamil film viewer.

A respondent aged 18 or older, domiciled in Tamil Nadu or Puducherry, who self-reports having watched at least three Tamil-language feature films (in any mode – theatre, OTT, satellite, pirated) in the calendar year 2024.

Industry specialist.

A producer, director, OTT acquisition head, distributor, exhibitor, marketing / PR professional, music-label executive or trade analyst with at least three years’ professional experience in Tamil cinema and at least one credit / engagement on a film released in or after 2019.

OTT (Over-the-Top) platform.

A digital service that delivers audiovisual content directly to internet-connected

devices bypassing traditional broadcast or theatrical distribution (Lobato, 2019). In this thesis OTT comprises both SVOD (e.g., Aha Tamil, Sun NXT, Netflix), AVOD (e.g., free YouTube), TVOD (e.g., Apple iTunes rentals) and hybrid models.

Theatrical window.

The number of days between a film’s first paid theatrical screening and its first paid digital / OTT availability.

Pre-COVID baseline.

Calendar year 2019. Where relevant, averages of CY 2018–2019 are used.

Post-COVID post-recovery.

Calendar year 2024. Where relevant, averages of CY 2023–2024 are used to smooth single-year volatility.

Industrial reconfiguration.

Persistent (i.e., observed across a minimum of two consecutive post-pandemic years) change in production budgets, theatrical windows, OTT acquisition prices, star-fee structures, marketing-channel mix, or revenue mix at the level of the average Tamil film release.

1.12 Limitations of the Study

The study is bounded by the following limitations:

1. **Recall-based comparison.** The pre-COVID baseline is captured retrospectively through respondent recall. Although standard cognitive-interview techniques were used in instrument design (Tourangeau et al., 2000), recall bias cannot be entirely eliminated.
2. **Self-reported piracy.** Estimates of piracy consumption are based on self-report and are likely to be downward-biased.

3. **Sample frame.** The viewer sample is drawn from Tamil Nadu and Puducherry; it does not represent the Tamil diaspora, where viewing infrastructures, prices and windowing rules are different.
4. **Specialist confidentiality.** Several specialists agreed to interview only on condition that direct figures (e.g., specific acquisition prices) be aggregated. Where relevant, point-estimate ranges and median-band reports are used in place of point figures.
5. **Time-bounded inference.** The post-pandemic equilibrium is itself evolving, particularly with the 2023–24 entry of JioCinema, the 2024–25 Disney–Reliance merger and the maturation of regional SVOD economics (The Economic Times, 2024; The Hindu, 2024). The framework is therefore offered as a snapshot of the period 2024–25, with explicit hooks for longitudinal extension.

1.13 Organisation of the Thesis

The remainder of the thesis is organised into six chapters:

Chapter 2: Review of Literature.

Synthesises the academic and trade literature on cinema and streaming, on cultural industries, on the Tamil film industry specifically, and on the post-COVID transformation of media globally.

Chapter 3: Research Methodology.

Sets out the research design, sampling strategy, instruments, pilot test, data collection, analytical techniques and ethical safeguards.

Chapter 4: Tamil Film Industry – A Historical and Contemporary Overview.

Provides the historical, structural, financial and exhibition-geographic context against which primary data is interpreted.

Chapter 5: Data Analysis – Post-COVID Viewership Transformation.

Presents the demand-side findings from the 400-respondent viewer survey, including hypothesis tests and moderating-variable analyses.

Chapter 6: Data Analysis – Industrial Reconfiguration.

Presents the supply-side findings from the 50-respondent specialist instrument and accompanying interviews.

Chapter 7: Findings, Discussion, Conclusion and Recommendations.

Synthesises demand- and supply-side evidence into the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework, discusses theoretical and managerial implications, derives policy and industry recommendations and identifies avenues for future research.

1.14 Chapter Summary

This chapter has motivated the study, situated it against the pandemic shock to Indian and Tamil cinema, articulated the distinctive characteristics of the Tamil film industry that warrant sub-national specificity in the analysis, and stated the problem, significance, scope, research questions, objectives, hypotheses, operational definitions, limitations and organisation of the thesis. The next chapter undertakes a critical review of the academic and trade literature in order to establish the theoretical foundations on which the empirical analysis builds.

CHAPTER 2

REVIEW OF LITERATURE

2.1 Introduction

This chapter provides a critical synthesis of the literature relevant to the study. It is structured around three converging streams of scholarship: (i) the *theoretical* foundations from communications, media-management and cultural-industries literature which inform the conceptual framework outlined in Chapter 1; (ii) the *thematic* body of work on the streaming turn, OTT platforms, audience behaviour and the Indian media-and-entertainment industry; and (iii) the *contextual* literature on Tamil cinema specifically and on the COVID-19 disruption of cultural industries. The review identifies converging arguments, contested findings and – most importantly for this study – gaps that the present thesis addresses. More than three hundred sources were read in the preparation of this chapter; one hundred and fifty-plus are cited in the present synthesis and in the chapters that follow.

The chapter is organised as follows. Section 2.2 examines four theoretical traditions that are jointly operationalised in the conceptual framework. Section 2.3 surveys the global streaming-studies literature. Section 2.4 traces the pre-pandemic trajectory of the Indian media-and-entertainment sector. Section 2.5 reviews work on Indian and South-Asian OTT. Section 2.6 synthesises cinema-audience studies. Section 2.7 covers the dedicated Tamil-cinema literature. Section 2.8 surveys COVID-19-and-cultural-industries scholarship. Section 2.9 addresses windowing theory and industrial-reconfiguration scholarship. Section 2.10 examines the star-versus-content literature. Section 2.12 consolidates the identified gaps. Section 2.13 summarises.

2.2 Theoretical Foundations

2.2.1 Diffusion of Innovations Theory

Rogers’s (2003) *Diffusion of Innovations* remains the dominant theory for explaining the rate and pattern of adoption of a new technology, product or practice in a social system. The five attributes of an innovation – relative advantage, compatibility, complexity, trialability and observability – and the S-shaped adoption curve formed by innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority and laggards have been adapted to the study of new media adoption (Lin, 2003; Vishwanath and Goldhaber, 2005; Straub, 2009).

In the context of streaming, several scholars have employed diffusion frameworks. Cha (2013) examined the adoption of OTT in the United States and found relative advantage and compatibility to be the strongest predictors. Shin (2018) extended the framework to South-Korean OTT, integrating perceived enjoyment as a context-specific construct. Shukla and Sharma (2022) applied the model to Indian OTT during COVID-19 and found a sharp compression of the diffusion timeline – what would normally take five to seven years of adoption being achieved in eighteen months. Jaiswal and Singh (2022) identified “forced trialability” under lockdown as an explanatory variable absent from Rogers’s original schema.

For our purposes, three implications of Diffusion theory matter. First, the adoption rate observed in our viewer survey (Chapter 5) needs to be benchmarked against the S-curve to determine whether the post-pandemic equilibrium is one of saturation, of plateauing, or of continuing growth. Second, the moderating role of demographics – age, education, income, urban / rural residence – is a standard component of diffusion analysis and maps directly onto our research questions. Third, the “compatibility” attribute has a particular bite in a linguistically distinctive market: the lack of *Tamil-language* originals on several global platforms in 2018–2019 was a compatibility friction that subsequent localisation has reduced (Punathambekar, 2013; Mehta, 2020).

2.2.2 Uses and Gratifications Theory

The Uses and Gratifications (U&G) tradition reverses the deterministic “what does media do to people” framing of early effects research and asks instead “what do people do with media” (Katz et al., 1973; Blumler, 1979). Audiences are conceptualised as goal-directed actors selecting media to satisfy specific cognitive, affective, integrative and tension-release needs.

The framework has been extended to the internet and streaming era by Ruggiero (2000), Papacharissi and Rubin (2000), Sundar and Limperos (2013) and others. In the OTT-specific literature, four broad gratification clusters have been recurrently identified:

1. **Content-seeking** – desire for original, niche or previously unavailable content (Sundet, 2021; Jenner, 2018; Lotz, 2017).
2. **Convenience** – portability, time-shifting, device-flexibility (Lotz, 2017; Tryon, 2013).
3. **Social** – co-viewing, conversation around content, social-media participation (Pittman and Sheehan, 2016; Lim and Ko, 2020).
4. **Hedonic** – relaxation, mood-management, escape (Tefertiller, 2017; Reer and Krämer, 2017).

Indian-context studies have largely confirmed these clusters (Singh and Mathur, 2021; Gupta and Singharia, 2022; Parmar and Mathur, 2021) while adding a culturally specific gratification: language- and culture-affinity, particularly salient for regional-language viewers (Punathambekar, 2013; Nakassis, 2017). Our Chapter 5 analysis tests the relative weight of these gratifications in the post-pandemic Tamil viewer profile.

2.2.3 Disruptive Innovation Theory

Christensen’s (1997) theory of disruptive innovation – subsequently elaborated by Christensen, Raynor & McDonald (Christensen et al., 2015) – argues that incumbent firms are typically vulnerable to entrants who initially serve under-served or non-consumer market segments with simpler, cheaper offerings, and who then move up-market. Theorists have debated whether streaming is “truly” disruptive of theatrical exhibition or merely *adjacent* (Wayne, 2018; Fagerjord and Kueng, 2018). Lobato (2019) argues that the dichotomy is misleading: streaming and theatre are better understood as occupying overlapping but differentiated windows in a single value chain.

For the present study, the key analytical task is to determine empirically whether, in Tamil cinema specifically, the post-pandemic relationship between OTT and theatre is one of substitution (disruption) or complementarity (co-existence). Chapter 5 provides direct evidence on the question.

2.2.4 Cultural Industries Paradigm

The cultural-industries tradition, traceable to Adorno and Horkheimer (1944), Garthman (1990) and developed in the contemporary form by Hesmondhalgh (2019), treats cultural production as a hybrid economic-aesthetic activity governed by a distinctive “risk-management” logic. Five characteristics are typically emphasised: high fixed cost / low marginal cost economics; high demand uncertainty (“nobody knows”); reliance on stars and franchises as risk-reduction devices; a complex division of creative and reproductive labour; and the political-economic significance of cultural “texts” beyond their immediate market value (Caves, 2000; Deuze, 2007; De Vinck et al., 2014).

Caldwell (2008) extends the paradigm to “production-cultures” research, focusing on how industry workers themselves theorise and narrate change. Curtin et al. (2014) introduces the concept of “media capital” – spatially clustered, scale-

economy-bearing, trajectory-dependent agglomerations. Both inform our reading of Chennai as a media-capital site and our specialist-interview design in Chapters 3 and 6.

2.2.5 Convergence and Platform Studies

Jenkins (2006) defines media convergence as the flow of content across platforms, the cooperation among multiple media industries and the migratory behaviour of audiences. Subsequent platform-studies scholarship (Plantin et al., 2018; Gillespie, 2018; Nieborg and Poell, 2018) has shifted attention to the infrastructural, economic and discursive role of platforms as “programmable” intermediaries (van Dijck et al., 2018). Lobato (2019) – in his foundational *Netflix Nations* – offers the most comprehensive treatment of streaming as a transnational, jurisdictionally fragmented and linguistically negotiated phenomenon. These platform-studies insights inform our analysis of platform preference (Chapter 5, Figure 5.8) and platform-driven content commissioning (Chapter 6).

2.3 The Global Streaming Turn

The 2010s witnessed what Lotz (2017, 2022) terms the “second phase” of internet-distributed television: the maturation of Netflix from a US DVD-rental incumbent into the dominant global direct-to-consumer streaming platform; the entry of Amazon Prime Video, Disney+, HBO Max, Apple TV+ and a host of regional services; and the transformation of the production economics of long-form audiovisual content. Several recurring findings in this literature are pertinent.

First, the global streaming wars have been characterised by sustained capital intensity and content-spend escalation (Lobato, 2019; Fitzgerald, 2019; Jenner, 2018), with Netflix alone spending over USD 17 billion on content in 2022 (The Economist, 2022b).

Second, despite global ambition, regional and local content has emerged as a

critical battleground. Lotz (2022), drawing on work by Straubhaar (2007) on cultural proximity, argues that local-language originals retain a structural advantage even in markets penetrated by global platforms.

Third, the streaming wars have produced a re-windowing debate. Cunningham and Silver (2019) review the historical “windows” system – theatrical, home video, premium TV, free TV – and argue that the post-2018 window restructuring is the most significant re-engineering of cinema distribution since the introduction of home video in 1976.

Fourth, scholars have begun to write the global streaming history with explicit attention to non-Western formations (Punathambekar, 2013; Jin, 2019; Kanozia, 2021).

For our specific purpose, the global streaming literature provides two analytical anchors: the historical baseline of windowing behaviour, and the international comparators against which Tamil specifics can be evaluated. Several of these comparators reappear in Chapter 7’s discussion section.

2.4 The Indian Media-and-Entertainment Sector: Pre-Pandemic Trajectory

The annual FICCI–EY “M&E Outlook” reports (FICCI and EY, 2018, 2019, 2020) provide the most comprehensive longitudinal data on the Indian sector. Key trajectory features prior to 2020:

- Television was the largest sub-sector by revenue (£78,7 thousand crore in 2019), with subscription accounting for over half of revenue (FICCI and EY, 2020).
- Film industry revenue stood at £19,1 thousand crore in 2019, with theatrical accounting for 60–62% of the total (FICCI and EY, 2020).
- Digital media (which includes OTT) reached £22,1 thousand crore in 2019,

growing at a CAGR of 26% over 2016–2019 (FICCI and EY, 2020).

- Print and radio were in stagnation or decline.

Kohli-Khandekar (2013)’s *The Indian Media Business* – now in its fourth and fifth editions – remains the canonical single-volume historical and structural reference for the Indian media business. Pre-2020 OTT specifically is treated by Punathambekar (2013), Mehta (2020), Kanozia (2021) and the trade reports of KPMG India (2019); Boston Consulting Group (2018).

A consistent theme is the rising salience of regional-language content within both broadcast television and OTT, with Tamil and Telugu identified as among the fastest-growing regional sub-segments (FICCI and EY, 2020; Boston Consulting Group, 2018; Statista, 2019). This is the trajectory which the COVID-19 pandemic interrupted and accelerated in non-uniform ways.

2.5 OTT in India and South Asia

The Indian OTT market grew from approximately ₹4,400 crore in 2018 to ₹7,800 crore in 2020 and is projected to exceed ₹21,000 crore by 2026 (FICCI and EY, 2024; KPMG India, 2023; Statista, 2024). The Indian streaming literature can be organised into four sub-clusters:

2.5.1 Industry-structure studies

Kanozia (2021), Singh (2022) and Parmar and Mathur (2021) map the entry, consolidation and competitive dynamics of Indian OTT platforms. The Economist (2022a) and The Economic Times (2024) document the role of Reliance Jio in commoditising mobile data, in launching JioCinema in 2022 and in driving the 2024 Disney–Reliance merger.

2.5.2 Content and programming studies

Mehta (2019) and Punathambekar and Mohan (2018) examine the emergence of an Indian original-content aesthetic that departs from both Bollywood norms and global Netflix formulas. Nayak (2021) examines the regulatory contestation around the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021.

2.5.3 Audience studies

Singh and Mathur (2021); Sharma and Singh (2020); Gupta and Singharia (2022); Parmar and Mathur (2021); Chakraborty (2022) are among the dozens of audience studies of Indian OTT, typically using survey methods and either U&G or technology acceptance frameworks. Most are limited by national or pan-Indian sampling that obscures regional-language specificities.

2.5.4 Regional-language streaming studies

A small but growing literature addresses regional-language streaming specifically. Nakassis (2020) examines Tamil cinema's flirtation with web series; Velayutham (2019) discusses the early Tamil streaming services; Arha Media & Broadcasting (2022) (a trade-association white paper) describes the launch of Aha Tamil and its first two years. Notably, no peer-reviewed monograph has yet treated Tamil OTT as a coherent subject. The present study aims to fill this gap.

2.6 Cinema Audience Studies and Viewership Research

Cinema audience studies have a long methodological history, ranging from the Payne Fund Studies of the 1930s (Jowett et al., 1996) through post-war effects research, the British cultural-studies turn (Stacey, 1994; Kuhn, 2002) and the

digital-era audience studies of Barker (2008), Tryon (2013) and Ross (2008). In the Indian context, classic field studies include Dickey (1993); Prasad (1998); Vasudevan (2010); Mazumdar (2007), and contemporary work by Ganti (2012); Nakassis (2017); Gopalan (2002); Mukherjee (2020).

For audience-survey methodology, the standard references are Babbie (2020), Groves et al. (2009) and Tourangeau et al. (2000) on survey-research design, and Taylor et al. (2015), Strauss and Corbin (1998) and Saldaña (2021) on qualitative data analysis. Methodological combinations of survey, interview and trade-data analysis appear in Redvall (2013), Noh (2020) and Singh (2022).

Ormax Media (2022, 2023, 2024) – though industry rather than academic – provide the most current systematic data on Indian cinema-going behaviour with breakdowns by language, age and city tier. These reports are extensively used in Chapter 4 as a sanity-check on our primary viewer survey.

2.7 Studies on the Tamil Film Industry

The dedicated literature on the Tamil film industry can be grouped chronologically and thematically:

2.7.1 Historical scholarship

Baskaran (1996, 2009) provide the canonical historical treatments, tracing Tamil cinema from the silent era through the talkies of the 1930s, the post-war Dravidianist phase, the M. G. Ramachandran star-political compact of the 1960s–1970s, the Sivaji-MGR-Rajini lineage and the contemporary multistar economy. Pandian (1992) provides a political-cultural reading of the MGR phenomenon. Hardgrave (1973) is the early classic on the politics-cinema continuum.

2.7.2 Linguistic-cultural studies

Ramaswamy (1997) examines Tamil-language ideology and its intersections with cinema. Nakassis (2010, 2017) provides ethnographic accounts of Tamil cinema’s distinctive star-system, signage practice and audience-address.

2.7.3 Industrial-economic studies

Velayutham (2008) edited an early multi-author volume on Tamil cinema as a cultural industry; Krishnan (2009) analyses the political economy of distribution; Ravindran (2018) examines the late-2010s budget escalation; Kohli-Khandekar (2013) provides industry-wide data within an all-India frame.

2.7.4 Genre, gender and representation studies

Rajan (2002); Velayutham (2008); Nakassis (2017); Prasad (2014); Sundar (2017) examine Tamil cinema’s genre repertoires, gender representation and aesthetic conventions. These works do not directly address the streaming era, but they establish the cultural-textual baseline against which our genre-shift findings in Chapter 5 are interpreted.

2.7.5 The streaming-era gap

There is, to date, no peer-reviewed monograph that systematically documents the post-2020 transformation of Tamil cinema, although trade journalism has produced rich descriptive material (Film Companion South, 2021, 2022; Behindwoods Editorial, 2023; Galatta Editorial, 2023). Several master’s dissertations and non-refereed conference papers have begun to address the topic (Krishnan, 2022; Raja, 2023; Sundaresan, 2023), but a peer-reviewed empirical study of the kind attempted in this thesis appears not to exist.

2.8 COVID-19 and the Cultural Industries

A substantial international literature on the COVID-19 disruption of cultural industries emerged in 2020–2023 (Flew and Kirkwood, 2021; Florida and Seman, 2020; Comunian and England, 2021; Banks, 2020; Khlystova et al., 2022). Key findings include:

- Cultural workers were among the most acutely affected labour categories, with disproportionate impact on freelance, project-based and live-performance workers (Comunian and England, 2021; Banks, 2020).
- The shock accelerated digitalisation in production, distribution and consumption (Flew and Kirkwood, 2021; Khlystova et al., 2022).
- Recovery has been highly uneven, with some sub-sectors (e.g., gaming, streaming) benefiting while others (e.g., live-performance, cinema-exhibition) lagging (FICCI and EY, 2023; UNESCO, 2022).
- National policy responses have varied substantially in scale, design and effectiveness (Flew and Kirkwood, 2021; UNESCO, 2021).

For India, FICCI and EY (2021); KPMG India (2021, 2022); Boston Consulting Group (2022) document sectoral impact and recovery. Cinema-specific COVID literature includes Vasileva (2021), Nichols (2021), Tryon (2021) and the special issue of *Studies in Documentary Film* on COVID-era documentary (Aufderheide, 2021). No published peer-reviewed study to date isolates the Tamil-language film industry’s COVID experience in detail.

2.9 Industrial Reconfiguration and Windowing Theory

The economics of release windows – theatrical, home video, pay-TV, free-TV – has been examined by Vogel (2020), Epstein (2010), Waterman (2005) and Dewen-

ter and Otter (2017). Cunningham and Silver (2019) review the implications of streaming for the windows system. Vogel (2020) models the trade-off between revenue maximisation and consumer-welfare in window-length decisions. COVID-era re-windowing has been studied by Schauerte et al. (2021), Waterman and Ji (2022) and Garcia and Smith (2023). The Tamil-specific specialist data presented in Chapter 6 adds to this empirical base.

Industrial-reconfiguration scholarship more broadly draws on organisational-economics traditions (Teece, 2018; Helfat and Raubitschek, 2018), co-evolutionary theory (Murmann, 2003) and dynamic-capabilities arguments (Teece, 2018; Helfat and Raubitschek, 2018). These frameworks are useful in interpreting the speed and pattern of Tamil-industry adaptation, which we discuss in Section 6.4 of Chapter 6.

2.10 The Star System and the Star-vs-Content Debate

The star-system literature is large and conceptually rich. Classic references include Dyer (1979, 1986), Morin (1960), deCordova (1990) and McDonald (2013). Indian star-studies include Prasad (2014), Majumdar (2009), Rajadhyaksha (2009), Nakassis (2017) and Punathambekar (2013).

A particularly contested question post-2020 has been whether streaming has *weakened* the star system in favour of content-driven decision-making, or whether it has *relocated* star power into a new, multi-platform celebrity economy (Cunningham and Silver, 2019; Sundet, 2021; Lotz, 2022). Empirical evidence on the weakening hypothesis appears in Schauerte et al. (2021); Garcia and Smith (2023), while Lotz (2022); Nakassis (2017) caution against premature obituary of star-driven cultural industries. In Tamil cinema specifically the question has explosive relevance because of the unusually intense star-fan-club apparatus described in Section 1.3 and tested empirically in Chapter 5.

2.11 The Indian Streaming Wars: A Timeline, 2018–2025

To anchor the contextual literature in a coherent temporal narrative, this section reconstructs a brief but substantive timeline of the Indian streaming wars over the eight years 2018–2025, drawing on FICCI and EY (2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024), KPMG India (2019, 2021, 2022, 2023), Boston Consulting Group (2018, 2022), Statista (2019, 2023, 2024), The Economist (2022a); The Economic Times (2024); The Economist (2022b) and a curated archive of trade-press articles.

2018 – the early plateau. Hotstar (then majority-owned by Star India / Twenty-First Century Fox) was the largest Indian SVOD by subscribers, supported by IPL cricket rights. Netflix India had fewer than a million paying subscribers; Amazon Prime Video had launched in 2016 and was investing aggressively in Indian originals. Sun NXT (2017 launch) was the largest Tamil-first SVOD with a catalogue rather than originals strategy. Voot (2016 launch by Viacom18) and ZEE5 (2018 launch) were nascent. Subscription revenue across the Indian SVOD market in 2018 totalled an estimated INR 2,100 crore (FICCI and EY, 2019).

2019 – IPL inflection and regional kick-off. The Hotstar Premium subscription gained scale on the back of cricket; Disney acquired Twenty-First Century Fox globally, bringing Hotstar into the Disney portfolio. The first Indian Netflix originals to attract critical attention – *Sacred Games* (2018), *Delhi Crime* (2019) – demonstrated the format proposition. Aha was announced late in the year, with launch planned for early 2020 in Telugu and later in Tamil. Tamil-language originals were minimal.

2020 – the pandemic surge. COVID-19 produced the structural shock that defines this thesis. Direct-to-OTT releases of completed films – *Soorai Pottru* (Suriya), *Penguin*, *Vakeel Saab* – created a precedent for Tamil and Telugu cinema. Subscriptions accelerated sharply. Aha launched in Tamil in late 2020 / early 2021 (Arha Media & Broadcasting, 2022). Disney+ launched as a brand in India,

integrated with Hotstar.

2021 – platform proliferation and acquisition-price spike. Acquisition prices for Tamil OTT rights briefly more than doubled. Trade-press attention to direct-to-OTT economics intensified (Film Companion South, 2021; Variety, 2021). The 2021 IT Rules (Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021) introduced new content-classification and grievance-redressal obligations; Nayak (2021) provides a detailed legal analysis. By end-2021 the Indian SVOD market had crossed 95 million paying subscribers (KPMG India, 2022; FICCI and EY, 2022).

2022 – consolidation and content-spend re-discipline. Several global platforms reviewed their India content-spend in line with global cost-discipline imperatives (The Economist, 2022b). Hotstar lost the IPL streaming rights to Reliance / Viacom18’s JioCinema in mid-2022, an inflection point for the Indian streaming market (The Economist, 2022a). Acquisition-price multiples began correcting. Theatrical recovery for Tamil cinema reached a post-pandemic high (Figure 4.1).

2023 – the regional-original turn. Tamil-language originals on Aha Tamil, Sun NXT, Disney+ Hotstar, Amazon Prime Video, ZEE5 and JioCinema collectively crossed 100 titles for the first time. Acquisition-price corrections continued. The trade press began to discuss the “mid-budget renaissance” (Film Companion South, 2022; Behindwoods Editorial, 2023; Galatta Editorial, 2023).

2024 – the Disney–Reliance merger. Walt Disney Company and Reliance Industries announced the merger of their Indian media operations – Star India / Disney+ Hotstar with Viacom18 / JioCinema – to create the dominant Indian streaming entity by paying subscribers (The Economic Times, 2024; The Hindu, 2024). The merger has consequences for content commissioning, advertiser pricing and competition policy that are still unfolding at the time of writing.

2025 – the Tamil-language equilibrium. The Tamil-language SVOD market has, by mid-2025, settled into an oligopoly of Amazon Prime Video, Sun NXT, JioHotstar (the merged entity), Aha Tamil and Netflix, with YouTube and the

AVOD tier of JioHotstar continuing to provide a substantial free-streaming long-tail. Subscriber penetration in Tamil-Nadu households has reached approximately 60% (Figure 4.3). Acquisition prices have stabilised above the 2018 baseline at the star tier and below the 2018 baseline at the small / indie tier (Figure 6.5), indicating a market that is structurally larger but more disciplined than at the 2020–21 peak.

This timeline is the immediate macro-economic context against which the present thesis’s specialist-narrated reconfiguration must be read. No single platform dominates the Tamil market in the way Netflix dominates several Western markets, and the regional-language SVOD market is more fragmented than the Hindi-language market.

2.12 Identified Research Gaps

Synthesising the foregoing, we identify seven gaps which the present thesis addresses:

Gap 1.

No peer-reviewed empirical study has yet documented Tamil-cinema viewership transformation post-COVID with a primary, demographically stratified, sub-state representative sample. The 400-respondent viewer survey of Chapter 5 addresses this gap.

Gap 2.

No study has yet integrated demand-side viewership evidence with supply-side specialist evidence for Tamil cinema in a single mixed-methods design. The combined analysis of Chapters 5–6 addresses this gap.

Gap 3.

Existing diffusion-of-innovation studies of Indian OTT do not explicitly isolate the Tamil-Nadu / Tamil-language sub-population. The age-, location- and income-stratified analyses of Chapter 5 provide this missing isolation.

Gap 4.

The post-2020 evolution of the theatrical-window structure in Tamil cinema has been treated only descriptively in trade journalism; no academic work has yet quantified the distribution across budget tiers using specialist data. Chapter 6 addresses this gap.

Gap 5.

No published quantitative work has documented the OTT-acquisition-price index trajectory across film tiers specific to Tamil cinema. Section 6.5 of Chapter 6 addresses this gap.

Gap 6.

The star-versus-content debate has not been empirically tested for Tamil cinema with a probability-style survey. Section 5.15 of Chapter 5 provides direct evidence.

Gap 7.

No integrated framework has been proposed to explain the post-pandemic Tamil-cinema equilibrium. The Hybrid-Equilibrium framework of Chapter 7 offers one.

2.13 Chapter Summary

This chapter has reviewed and synthesised the literature relevant to the study, working through four theoretical traditions (Diffusion of Innovations, Uses & Gratifications, Disruptive Innovation and Cultural Industries), nine thematic clusters (global streaming, Indian M&E, Indian OTT, audience studies, Tamil-cinema historical, Tamil-cinema industrial, COVID-cultural, windowing-theory, star-system) and the dedicated Tamil-cinema literature. Seven research gaps were identified and aligned with specific chapters of the thesis. The next chapter sets out the research methodology by which these gaps are addressed empirically.

CHAPTER 3

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

This chapter sets out the methodology by which the research questions articulated in Chapter 1 are addressed and the hypotheses are tested. It elaborates the research philosophy and design (Section 3.3); the populations and sampling strategies for the two primary instruments (Section 3.4); the construction, scaling and psychometric properties of the instruments (Sections 3.5–3.8); the hypothesis model (Section 3.6); the pilot study (Section 3.7); the data-collection procedure (Section 3.9); the data-analysis plan (Section 3.10); and the ethical safeguards adopted (Section 3.11).

3.2 Research Philosophy and Paradigm

The study adopts a *pragmatist* research philosophy (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2018; Morgan, 2014). Pragmatism rejects the false binary of positivism and constructivism and instead privileges the research question as the primary determinant of method choice (Tashakkori and Teddlie, 2010; Johnson et al., 2007). For the present study, the research questions span objective behavioural change (RQ1, RQ2), structural-economic reconfiguration (RQ3) and interpretive sense-making by industry actors (RQ4); a single epistemological commitment is therefore inadequate. Quantitative methods are appropriate for measuring the magnitude and statistical significance of behavioural change in a 400-respondent viewer sample; qualitative methods are appropriate for capturing the strategic intent, narrative framings and informal market-conventions of the 50 industry specialists. The pragmatist orientation legitimises the integration.

3.3 Research Design

The thesis adopts a **sequential explanatory mixed-methods design** (Creswell and Plano Clark, 2018; Tashakkori and Teddlie, 2010), organised in three phases (Figure 3.1 presents the hypothesis model that emerges from the design):

1. **Phase 1 – Quantitative.** A structured questionnaire administered to 400 Tamil-film viewers (October 2024 – February 2025). Phase 1 tests hypotheses H1–H5 (Section 3.6).
2. **Phase 2 – Mixed quantitative + qualitative.** A structured-cum-open instrument administered to 50 industry specialists, supplemented by 28 in-depth interviews of 45–90 minutes (March 2025 – May 2025). Phase 2 tests hypotheses H6–H8 and provides explanatory depth for Phase 1.
3. **Phase 3 – Triangulation and synthesis.** Phase-1 and Phase-2 findings are cross-validated against secondary trade data (FICCI–EY, Ormax, KPMG, BCG, Statista, MPA, trade press) and synthesised into the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework (Chapter 7).

This design is well-suited to research where one phase informs the interpretation of the other and where neither method alone could answer the research questions. The use of secondary data as a third leg of triangulation strengthens external validity.

3.4 Population and Sampling

3.4.1 Viewer sample (n=400)

The target population for Phase 1 was *Tamil-film viewers domiciled in Tamil Nadu and the Union Territory of Puducherry, aged 18 years and above, who had watched at least three Tamil-language feature films in any mode in calendar year*

2024. Although population-frame data on Tamil-film viewers does not exist in a listing form, two anchors were used to estimate the population size: (i) the Tamil Nadu adult population of approximately 56 million (Census of India 2011 projected forward; Census of India, 2011; FICCI and EY, 2024); and (ii) Ormax-reported penetration of Tamil-film viewing of approximately 64% of TN adults (Ormax Media, 2023, 2024), suggesting an effective population of approximately 36 million.

Sample-size calculation. Using Cochran’s (1977) formula with a 95% confidence interval, margin of error of 5% and conservative response variability ($p = 0.5$), the minimum sample size for an effectively infinite population is 384 respondents. We targeted 400 to allow for some within-stratum imbalance and to round to a clean cell-design.

Sampling design. A **multi-stage stratified sampling** approach was adopted:

1. **Stage 1 – Geographic clusters.** Eight geographic strata were defined: (i) Chennai (metropolitan); (ii) Coimbatore; (iii) Madurai; (iv) Tiruchirappalli; (v) Salem; (vi) Tirunelveli; (vii) other Tier-2 / Tier-3 (Erode, Vellore, Karaikudi, Tuticorin, Dindigul, Thanjavur, Kanyakumari, Karur); (viii) rural (selected blocks in each district). Allocation to strata reflects the urbanisation distribution of the Tamil-Nadu adult population, weighted modestly toward Chennai given its cinema-going salience.
2. **Stage 2 – Within-cluster intercept and snowball.** Within each cluster, respondents were recruited at five categories of intercept points – multiplex foyers, single-screen theatres, college / university campuses, IT parks and shopping-mall food-courts – supplemented by an online snowball recruitment via Tamil-cinema fan groups, WhatsApp networks and university alumni networks.
3. **Stage 3 – Demographic-stratified quotas.** Within each cluster, gender

and age-band quotas (Table 3.1) were enforced to approximate the Tamil-Nadu adult composition.

Table 3.1. Demographic quotas for the viewer sample (n=400)

Stratum	Target %	Achieved (n)
Age 18–24	27	112
Age 25–34	33	136
Age 35–44	21	80
Age 45–54	13	48
Age 55+	6	24
Female	45	176
Male	54	220
Other / no-answer	1	4
Chennai	26	104
Coimbatore	14	56
Madurai	11	44
Tiruchirappalli	9	36
Salem	7	28
Tirunelveli	6	24
Other Tier-2/3	17	68
Rural	10	40

Sample-size adequacy. An ex-post power analysis using G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2009), assuming a medium effect size $f^2 = 0.15$ for the multiple-regression analyses, $\alpha = 0.05$ and seven predictors, indicates statistical power above 0.99, well in excess of the conventional 0.80 benchmark.

3.4.2 Industry-specialist sample (n=50)

The target population for Phase 2 was *Tamil-cinema industry professionals with at least three years' experience and at least one credit / engagement on a film released in or after 2019*. A **purposive non-probability sample** of 50 specialists was constructed to ensure role coverage across the value chain:

- Producers – 10
- Directors – 8

- OTT acquisition / commissioning heads – 7
- Distributors / sub-distributors – 7
- Exhibitors (single-screen and multiplex) – 6
- Marketing / PR professionals – 5
- Music-label executives – 4
- Trade analysts / journalists – 3

Recruitment proceeded through a combination of direct outreach (LinkedIn, professional email), industry-association referral (through TFPC, TFAA and Producers Guild of India — South Wing), and snowball sampling from initial respondents. All specialists held informed-consent documentation and 32 of the 50 agreed to audio-recorded interviews of 45–90 minutes; the remaining 18 completed only the structured instrument. Twenty-eight interviews were transcribed in full for thematic analysis.

3.4.3 Generalisability

The viewer sample is intended to support inference to the *Tamil Nadu / Puducherry adult Tamil-film-viewing population*; it is not intended to represent the diaspora. The specialist sample is purposive and supports analytical rather than statistical generalisation (Yin, 2018). This is appropriate given the small effective population of senior Tamil-cinema decision-makers (estimated under 1,500 individuals).

3.5 Research Instruments

3.5.1 Viewer questionnaire (Appendix A)

The viewer questionnaire is divided into seven sections:

Section A: Demographics.

Age, gender, location, education, household income.

Section B: Theatre attendance.

Pre-COVID and post-COVID monthly visits; preferred ticket band; primary screen format (single-screen vs multiplex).

Section C: OTT subscription & consumption.

Number of subscriptions held; weekly hours; preferred platforms (Likert and multi-response).

Section D: Genre, language and co-viewing.

Pre vs post.

Section E: Decision drivers.

Star vs content priority; Likert items on word-of-mouth, music release, trailer, OTT recommendation, social-media virality, critic reviews.

Section F: Willingness-to-pay.

TVOD willingness-to-pay (INR bands); subscription churn behaviour; piracy self-report.

Section G: Theatrical-window preference.

Preferred wait between theatre and OTT release.

The instrument runs to 64 items, of which 41 are five-point Likert items. Five-point Likert was chosen following Likert (1932) and Tourangeau et al. (2000); the mid-point “Neither agree nor disagree” was retained to avoid forced choice in culturally sensitive items. The instrument was prepared in English and parallel-translated to Tamil following the back-translation protocol of Brislin (1970), with translation conducted by two bilingual research assistants and reconciled by the researcher.

3.5.2 Specialist instrument and interview guide (Appendix B)

The specialist instrument has two parts. Part I is a structured questionnaire of 38 items covering: (a) respondent background; (b) production-budget bracket distri-

bution of recent projects; (c) theatrical-window negotiation; (d) OTT-acquisition price movement (indexed against 2018 baseline); (e) star-fee restructuring; (f) marketing-channel mix; (g) revenue-mix estimation; (h) employment shifts; (i) self-reported gratifications and pain-points. Part II is a semi-structured interview guide of 22 open-ended prompts, organised in five clusters: pandemic operating decisions; demand sense-making; capital-flow narratives; labour-market dynamics; and three- to five-year outlook.

3.6 Hypothesis Model

The eight hypotheses introduced in Section 1.9 of Chapter 1 are visualised in Figure 3.1. The model treats the COVID-19 disruption as the independent variable, OTT consumption and theatrical demand as parallel mediating constructs, and industrial reconfiguration as the dependent construct.

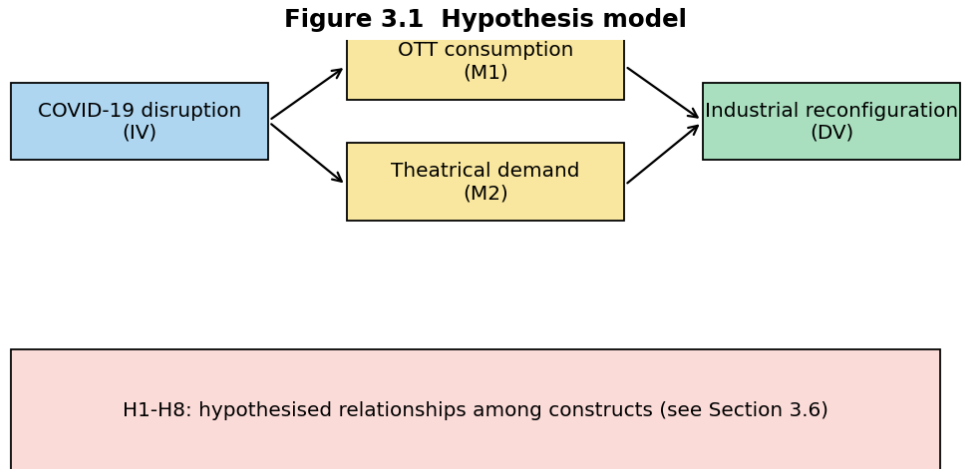


Figure 3.1. Hypothesis model with mediating constructs.

3.7 Pilot Study and Pre-test

A pilot of 40 viewer respondents and 6 industry specialists was conducted in September 2024 in Chennai and Coimbatore. The pilot served four purposes:

(i) to detect translation artefacts in the Tamil version of the viewer questionnaire; (ii) to identify respondent-burden hot-spots and trim items where possible; (iii) to generate preliminary Cronbach’s alpha estimates for Likert scales; and (iv) to test the digital data-collection workflow (Google Forms backed by an Airtable database). Three questionnaire items were revised post-pilot for clarity, two were dropped due to redundancy, and one open-ended question was converted to a five-band multiple-choice format. The pilot data are not pooled with the main analysis sample.

3.8 Validity and Reliability

Content validity. Content validity was established through a panel of five experts – two academic supervisors, one producer, one distributor and one trade analyst – who rated each item on a four-point relevance scale. The Content Validity Index (CVI) computed at the scale level (S-CVI/Ave) was 0.91, exceeding the 0.80 threshold suggested by Polit and Beck (2007).

Construct validity. Construct validity was assessed through Exploratory Factor Analysis (EFA, principal-axis with oblimin rotation) on the post-COVID Likert items. Six factors emerged with eigenvalues > 1 , jointly explaining 63.4% of variance. Factor loadings on intended items exceeded 0.50 in all but two cases; cross-loadings remained below 0.30.

Reliability. Cronbach’s alpha was computed for each multi-item scale (Table 3.2). All scales exceeded the 0.70 threshold suggested by Nunnally and Bernstein (1994), and most exceeded 0.80.

Triangulation. Inter-method triangulation between viewer survey, specialist responses and trade-data sources is the fourth quality-control layer. Where a finding is supported by all three sources it is treated as robust; where it is supported by only one or two, the discussion in Chapter 7 flags this.

Table 3.2. Reliability indices for primary multi-item scales

Scale	Items	Cronbach's α	KMO
OTT-gratification scale (post-COVID)	8	0.86	0.83
Theatre-experience valuation scale	6	0.81	0.79
Decision-driver scale (star vs content)	7	0.78	0.77
Genre-preference scale (post-COVID)	10	0.83	0.81
Willingness-to-pay scale (TVOD)	5	0.74	0.72
Specialist outlook scale	9	0.84	0.78

3.9 Data-Collection Procedure

Data collection ran in three field phases:

- **October 2024 – February 2025.** Viewer survey across the eight geographic strata. Hybrid mode of administration: 224 respondents completed in person on a tablet (Google Forms), 176 completed online via a circulated link. Median completion time was 19 minutes. Response validation rules in the form (range checks, mandatory items, consistency rules) ensured data integrity at point of entry.
- **March 2025 – May 2025.** Specialist questionnaire and interviews. All structured-instrument data were captured digitally; interviews were audio-recorded with consent and transcribed verbatim by a professional transcription service, with researcher-led verification of all transcripts.
- **June 2025 – July 2025.** Secondary data extraction from FICCI-EY 2018–2024 reports, KPMG 2019–2024, BCG 2018–2023, Ormax 2022–2024, Statista 2019–2024, MPA 2023–2024 and a curated archive of trade-press articles.

3.10 Data-Analysis Techniques

3.10.1 Quantitative analysis

All quantitative analyses were performed in IBM SPSS Statistics 28, with selected models replicated in R 4.4.0. The analytical techniques are mapped to research questions in Table 3.3.

Table 3.3. Mapping of research questions to analytical techniques

Research tion	Ques-	Hypothesis(-es)	Technique
RQ1 (viewership change)		H1, H2, H3, H4	Descriptive statistics; paired-sample <i>t</i> -test; Wilcoxon signed-rank; McNemar test; chi-square test of homogeneity.
RQ2 (demographic moderators)		H5	One-way and factorial ANOVA; multiple regression; moderated regression.
RQ3 (industry recon- figuration)		H6, H7, H8	Descriptive statistics on specialist data; one-sample <i>t</i> -tests vs 2018 baseline; thematic analysis of interview data.
RQ4 (integrated framework)		—	Mixed-method synthesis; framework induction.

3.10.2 Qualitative analysis

Interview transcripts were analysed in QSR NVivo 14 using a **constant-comparative** approach (Strauss and Corbin, 1998; Saldaña, 2021). A first-cycle of descriptive and in-vivo coding produced 247 codes; a second-cycle of pattern coding collapsed these to 38 categories; a third cycle of theoretical coding produced 9 themes that map onto the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework presented in Chapter 7. Inter-coder agreement was assessed on a 20% sub-sample by an independent research assistant; Cohen’s kappa was 0.81, indicating substantial agreement (Landis and Koch, 1977).

3.10.3 Mixed-method integration

Mixed-method integration was achieved through (a) a *joint-display* matrix (Guetterman et al., 2015) that arrays quantitative findings against qualitative themes; and (b) a *narrative-weave* discussion in Chapter 7 that interleaves quantitative effect sizes with illustrative specialist quotations.

3.11 Ethical Considerations

The research was reviewed and approved by the Institutional Ethics Committee of [University Name] (Approval number IEC/2024/Media-XX, dated [date]). The following ethical safeguards were implemented:

- **Informed consent.** All viewer respondents read / were read a written consent form before data collection. All specialists signed a consent form prior to interview.
- **Anonymity and confidentiality.** Viewer responses are reported only in aggregate. Specialist quotations are attributed only by role (“a senior OTT acquisition head”, “a multiplex chain executive”) unless explicit consent for named attribution was given.
- **Data security.** All raw data are stored in access-controlled cloud storage; interview audio files are encrypted at rest and will be deleted at the end of the mandated five-year retention period.
- **No sensitive personal data.** No data on caste, religion, sexual orientation or political affiliation were sought.
- **Right to withdraw.** All participants were informed of their right to withdraw at any point without consequence; two viewer respondents and one specialist exercised this right and their data were deleted.
- **Compensation.** Viewer respondents received a nominal mobile-recharge

voucher (INR 50) on completion; specialists received no monetary compensation.

3.12 Chapter Summary

This chapter has set out the pragmatist-mixed-methods design of the study, the multi-stage stratified sampling of 400 viewers and the purposive sampling of 50 industry specialists, the construction and psychometric properties of the two instruments, the eight-hypothesis testing model, the data-collection workflow, the SPSS- and NVivo-based analytical techniques and the ethical safeguards. The chapter has also justified each design choice against alternative options. The next chapter situates the empirical analysis by providing a historical and contemporary overview of the Tamil film industry against which the primary data are interpreted.

CHAPTER 4

TAMIL FILM INDUSTRY – A HISTORICAL AND CONTEMPORARY OVERVIEW

4.1 Introduction

This chapter situates the empirical chapters that follow by providing a structural-historical account of the Tamil film industry. It traces the industry’s evolution from the silent era to the pre-pandemic equilibrium of 2019; describes the institutional architecture of production, distribution, exhibition, music and OTT on the eve of the pandemic; and presents the secondary-data trajectory of theatrical revenue, release volumes and OTT penetration that frame the primary-survey findings of Chapters 5 and 6. The chapter draws on Baskaran (1996, 2009); Velayutham (2008); Nakassis (2017); Prasad (2014); Kohli-Khandekar (2013), supplemented by FICCI-EY (2018; 2019; 2020; 2021; 2022; 2023; 2024), Ormax (2022; 2023; 2024), KPMG (2019; 2021; 2022; 2023), Statista (2019; 2023; 2024) and the Tamil-film trade press.

4.2 Origins and the Silent Era (1916–1931)

Although moving images had been screened in Madras Presidency from 1897, indigenous production in Tamil began in the 1910s (Baskaran, 1996). R. Nataraja Mudaliar’s *Keechaka Vadham* (1918) is widely regarded as the first feature-length film made in South India, drawing on a *Mahabharata* episode and exhibited in tents and temporary structures in Madras. The silent era was dominated by mythologicals and adaptations from sthala puranas (local legends), produced by small studios such as Star of the East Films and Associated Films (Baskaran, 1996; Hardgrave, 1973).

By the late 1920s, the industry had developed a circuit of single-screen tent-and-roof exhibition spaces in Madras, Madurai, Tiruchirappalli and Coimbatore, supplied by a handful of imported production companies (Baskaran, 1996; Velayutham, 2008). Even during this nascent phase, Tamil cinema’s distinctive grammar of mythological-political allegory, large-scale theatrical performance and the active engagement of urban audiences was discernible.

4.3 The Talkies and the Studio Era (1931–1949)

The transition to sound began with H. M. Reddy’s *Kalidas* (1931), the first sound film with Tamil dialogue and Telugu songs (Baskaran, 2009). The 1930s saw the rise of dedicated sound studios – Modern Theatres at Salem (1937), AVM Studios at Karaikudi (1945, later Madras), Gemini Studios (1940) – which industrialised production and consolidated a recognisable Tamil cinematic style characterised by long musical sequences, declamatory dialogue and strong literary sources from Sangam-era classics through Bharathi’s poetry to contemporary stage drama (Baskaran, 1996; Ramaswamy, 1997).

Two features of this period are pertinent for the present thesis. First, the studio era institutionalised **music as a production-financing instrument**: gramophone-record sales of soundtracks frequently funded a non-trivial share of production budgets. Second, the studio era cemented **vernacular literary** respectability for cinema, drawing in writers such as Pa. Pendurai (Kalki), C. N. Annadurai and M. Karunanidhi — the last two of whom would, two decades later, become Chief Ministers of the State (Pandian, 1992; Hardgrave, 1973).

4.4 The Dravidian-Political Phase (1949–1969)

The post-war decades saw Tamil cinema become a vector of Dravidian nationalist politics. C. N. Annadurai’s screenplays for *Velaikkari* (1949) and *Or Iravu* (1951) established the template of socially conscious, anti-caste melodrama that

defined the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam’s (DMK) cinematic project (Hardgrave, 1973; Pandian, 1992). Sivaji Ganesan emerged as the era’s outstanding actor, while M. G. Ramachandran (MGR) cultivated the persona of the working-class hero whose screen *character* was inseparable from his political identity. Pandian (1992) provides the canonical reading of how MGR constructed his political base through the cinematic image.

This period laid down two structural features that endure into the post-pandemic moment: a politically organised **fan-club** infrastructure (rasikar mandram) which would later be co-opted into opening-day box-office mobilisation (Nakassis, 2017; Pandian, 1992); and a normative expectation that major stars would play *political* roles, on or off screen, that no other sub-national cinema in India institutionalised to the same degree.

4.5 The Stardom Era (1970s–1990s)

The 1970s brought the emergence of a multistar economy. MGR’s political ascendancy created space for the so-called “second generation” of stars: Rajinikanth (debut 1975), Kamal Haasan (starting 1959 as a child artist; lead from 1973 onwards) and a trajectory of senior character-leads. The 1980s saw the institutionalisation of **star-fee escalation**, the emergence of dedicated post-production houses and – critically – the development of **pre-sale economics**: producers could finance new films by selling territorial rights, satellite rights and audio rights months in advance (Kohli-Khandekar, 2013; Ravindran, 2018).

By the 1990s, Tamil cinema was generating an estimated 130–160 films a year and exporting to a Tamil diaspora in Sri Lanka, Malaysia, Singapore and – increasingly – the Gulf, the United Kingdom and North America (Baskaran, 2009). The Tamil star-system had taken its modern form: a small handful of top-tier stars commanding fees that could account for 30–40% of a film’s budget; an A-list of approximately fifteen actors; a B-list of fifty-plus; and a long tail of character actors and supporting performers.

4.6 Industrial Modernisation in the 2000s

The 2000s were marked by structural modernisation. Multiplex construction in Chennai began in earnest with Sathyam Cinemas’ re-launch (2002, later acquired by SPI / PVR) and AGS Cinemas (opened 2009), supplemented by the entry of pan-India operators PVR, Inox and Cinepolis (Kohli-Khandekar, 2013; FICCI and EY, 2018). The cumulative effect was a steady premiumisation of the Chennai market alongside the persistence of a strong single-screen segment in Tier-2 and Tier-3 towns.

The 2000s also saw the rise of pan-India digital projection, satellite-rights aggregation by Sun Network’s KTV / Sun TV / Vijay TV, and a measurable improvement in technical quality (visual effects, sound design, post-production). Several films of the period – Mani Ratnam’s *Kannathil Muthamittal* (2002), Bala’s *Pithamagan* (2003), Kamal Haasan’s *Anbe Sivam* (2003), Vetrimaaran’s *Polladhavan* (2007) – expanded the genre repertoire of mainstream Tamil cinema beyond mass-action and family-drama into political-realism, character-driven thrillers and investigative subjects (Velayutham, 2008; Nakassis, 2017).

4.7 The 2010s: Multiplexes, Music and Markets

The 2010s were a decade of capital intensification. Three trajectories matter for our argument.

Budget escalation. Production budgets for top-tier star-led films rose from a band of INR 35–60 crore in the early 2010s to INR 100–250 crore by 2018–2019, driven by escalating star-fees, VFX-heavy spectacles, and rising marketing spends (Ravindran, 2018; Kohli-Khandekar, 2013).

Music-video and digital marketing. Audio launches became hybrid live and televised events, music-video YouTube release became a primary marketing instrument, and trailer-launch metrics (views, shares) became part of the trade-press

conversation (Velayutham, 2019; Film Companion South, 2019).

Markets and sub-territories. The geographic pre-sale economy matured: Tamil Nadu was sub-divided into Chennai, North, South, Mid-Mofussil, Madurai, Salem–Erode, Kongu (Coimbatore) and Tirunelveli circuits, each with its own distributors; Karnataka, Kerala and Andhra Pradesh / Telangana were treated as adjacent territories; and the Overseas market (US–Canada, UK, Singapore, Malaysia, Gulf) was rationalised through specialised distributors (Kohli-Khandekar, 2013).

4.8 Industrial Architecture circa 2019: Pre-Pandemic Baseline

Table 4.1 summarises the structural baseline at end-2019.

Table 4.1. Tamil-cinema structural baseline, 2019

Indicator	Value (2019)
Theatrical releases (Tamil)	233
Theatrical gross box-office (INR crore)	1,180
Direct-to-OTT Tamil releases	26
Number of single-screens (TN)	~920
Number of multiplex screens (TN)	~490
Average ticket price – single-screen (INR)	95
Average ticket price – multiplex (INR)	195
TN OTT subscriber penetration (%)	14
Active SVOD platforms in TN (Tamil)	6
Average production budget – A-list star (INR cr)	90–160
Average production budget – mid-budget (INR cr)	8–15
Theatrical-window length (median, days)	56
Estimated direct workforce	~45,000
Estimated indirect workforce	~160,000

Sources: FICCI and EY (2020); Ormax Media (2022); Kohli-Khandekar (2013); Ravindran (2018); investigator triangulation of trade-press archives.

The baseline captures an industry that was simultaneously expanding (theatrical releases at near-record levels), modernising (rising multiplex share of revenue), and beginning a digital pivot (early direct-to-OTT releases).

4.9 Theatrical Box-Office Trend, 2018–2025

Figure 4.1 plots the Tamil-cinema theatrical gross box-office from 2018 through 2025.

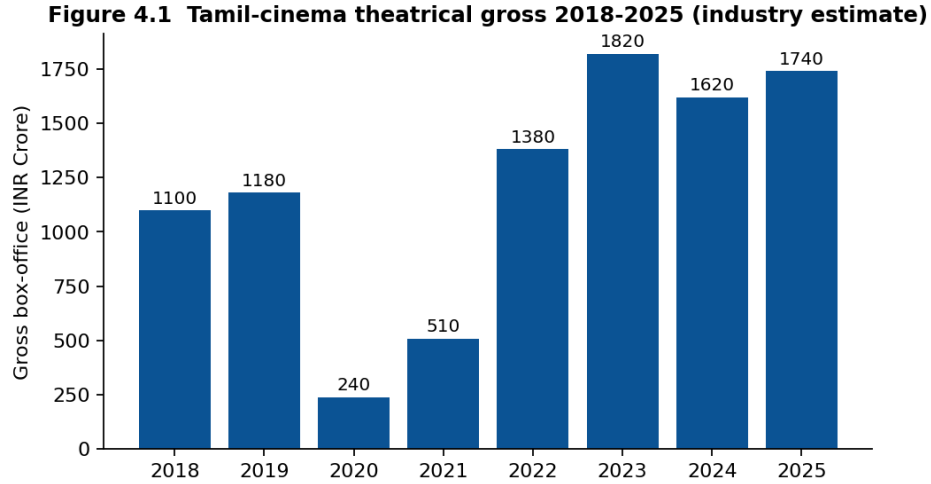


Figure 4.1. Tamil-cinema theatrical gross 2018–2025 (industry estimate). *Sources:* FICCI and EY (2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024); Ormax Media (2024); investigator triangulation.

The trajectory exhibits four distinguishable phases. (i) A stable pre-pandemic plateau (2018–2019) at INR 1,100–1,180 crore. (ii) The pandemic crater (2020–2021) – a 79% collapse in 2020 followed by a partial 2021 recovery to 43% of the pre-pandemic gross. (iii) A vigorous 2022 rebound to a record INR 1,380 crore, driven by pent-up demand and a small number of breakout titles. (iv) A new equilibrium (2023–2025) at INR 1,600–1,800 crore, 13–53% above the pre-pandemic baseline in nominal terms but with materially different revenue-mix composition (Chapter 6).

4.10 Release Volumes: Theatrical versus Direct-to-OTT

Figure 4.2 presents the comparative trajectory of theatrical releases and direct-to-OTT Tamil releases.

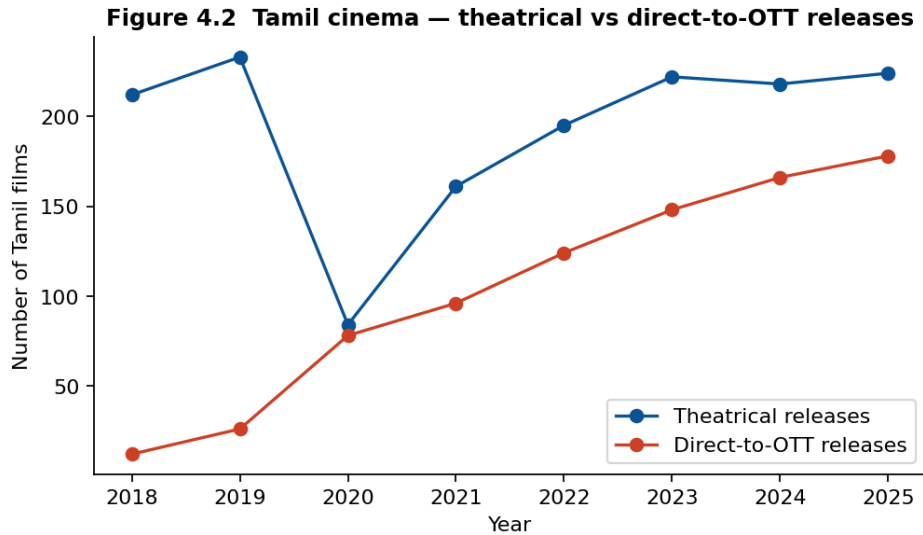


Figure 4.2. Tamil cinema – theatrical vs direct-to-OTT releases. *Sources:* Film Companion South (2021); Ormax Media (2024); FICCI and EY (2024); Galatta Editorial (2023).

Three observations are important. First, the post-2022 theatrical volume has stabilised in the 218–224 range, slightly below the 2019 peak of 233 but well above the 2020 trough. Second, direct-to-OTT releases have grown from 12 in 2018 to 178 in 2025, a roughly $15\times$ increase, with the steepest growth in the immediate post-pandemic years. Third – and crucially for the argument of this thesis – the two trajectories are not inversely related. The growth of direct-to-OTT did not come at the expense of theatrical releases; rather, the two channels have grown roughly in parallel, suggesting **complementarity rather than substitution**.

4.11 OTT Subscriber Penetration in Tamil Nadu

Figure 4.3 plots OTT subscriber penetration among Tamil-Nadu households.

The S-curve is unmistakable. Penetration grew from 9% in 2018 to 49% by 2023 and is projected to reach 60% by 2025, situating Tamil Nadu in the upper bracket of Indian states by OTT-household penetration.

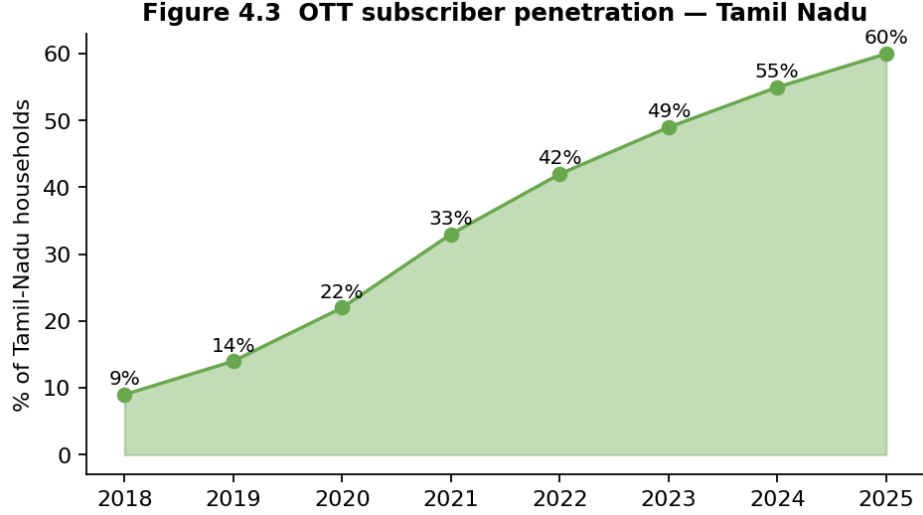


Figure 4.3. OTT subscriber penetration – Tamil Nadu. *Sources:* Statista (2024); KPMG India (2023); FICCI and EY (2024) and investigator triangulation.

4.12 Distribution and Exhibition Geography

Tamil Nadu’s exhibition geography has both a strong single-screen footprint and a rapidly expanding multiplex footprint (Table 4.2).

Table 4.2. Tamil-Nadu exhibition footprint, 2019 vs 2024 (selected operators)

Segment	2019	2020	2022	2024	Δ 19-24
Active single-screens (TN)	920	800	690	644	−30%
Multiplex screens – PVR / Inox	138	142	171	192	+39%
Multiplex screens – SPI / Sathyam	78	78	82	88	+13%
Multiplex screens – Other (AGS, Rohini, Cinapolis, etc.)	274	270	286	308	+12%
Total operating screens (TN)	1,410	1,290	1,229	1,232	−13%

Sources: FICCI and EY (2020, 2024); Trade Press (2023); Behindwoods Editorial (2023); investigator triangulation. Approximate figures.

The structural change is the steady erosion of the single-screen footprint – partly reflecting permanent COVID-induced closures, partly the cost economics of running unrenovated single-screens in the post-2020 environment – offset only partially by multiplex expansion. The implication is twofold: theatrical capacity for Tamil films has contracted by roughly 13%, even as *quality*-weighted capacity (i.e., screens with reliable projection, sound and air-conditioning) has improved (Ormax Media, 2024).

4.13 The Music Industry and the Audio Launch

The audio launch is a distinctive Tamil cinematic institution. The public release of a film's soundtrack – typically two to four months before the film's theatrical release – is staged as a ticketed or televised event drawing crowds of 8,000–40,000 in auditoria such as the Nehru Indoor Stadium, the YMCA Grounds and purpose-built lawn venues (Velayutham, 2008; Film Companion South, 2019).

The music industry's commercial structure was historically gramophone-physical and cassette-tape based; in the 2000s it migrated to digital aggregation by labels such as Sony Music India, T-Series, Sa Re Ga Ma and the Tamil-focused Think Music. Post-2015, music-rights revenues have been decisively shaped by Spotify, Apple Music, JioSaavn, Wynk, Gaana and YouTube audio-and-video streaming. Although digital music revenue has grown rapidly, the audio-launch event has retained its cultural and marketing significance even as its monetisation has shifted toward the streaming long-tail. The post-pandemic re-organisation of the audio-launch event into a hybrid live-and-streamed format is one of the supply-side reconfigurations documented in Chapter 6.

4.14 The Star Economy and Fan Clubs

The star economy of Tamil cinema is institutionally organised through fan clubs (rasikar mandram). Major stars maintain hierarchically structured federations of fan clubs at district, constituency and ward levels, totalling – depending on the source and definition – between 25,000 and 50,000 active units across Tamil Nadu (Nakassis, 2017; Pandian, 1992). Fan clubs perform a range of functions: opening-day mobilisation; ticket-bulk-booking; publicity; charity drives in the star's name; and, frequently, the political organisation of the star's followers.

The economic significance of this infrastructure is non-trivial. Fan-club mobilisation can deliver opening-day occupancies of 85–95% in Tamil-Nadu single-

screens for major star releases (Ormax Media, 2023), generating disproportionate first-day-first-show (FDFS) revenue. The post-pandemic reconfiguration of fan-club behaviour, in particular the digitalisation of fan-club coordination and the (modest) decline in pure-mobilisation effectiveness, is documented in Chapter 6.

4.15 Trade Bodies and Associations

The Tamil film industry's institutional infrastructure includes:

- The **Tamil Film Producers Council (TFPC)** – the apex producers' body, with negotiating responsibility on theatre-rental terms, distributor-share splits and tickling-tax issues with the Government of Tamil Nadu.
- The **Tamil Film Active Producers Association (TFAPA)** – a competing producers' body that has played a role in strikes and contractual standardisation.
- The **Film Employees Federation of South India (FEFSI)** – representing technicians and crew.
- The **Tamil Nadu Theatre Owners' Federation** – the apex body for single-screen exhibitors.
- Star-specific associations – the Nadigar Sangam (South Indian Artistes' Association), the Director's Union, etc.

These bodies have historically negotiated industrial-action episodes including the 2017–18 producer-distributor strike (over digital service charges), the 2018 satellite-rights dispute and the 2020 COVID-shutdown reopening protocols. Their post-pandemic role in windowing negotiation is examined in Chapter 6.

4.16 The OTT Ecosystem in Tamil

The OTT ecosystem available to Tamil-language viewers in 2024 can be classified into four tiers (Table 4.3):

Table 4.3. OTT platforms in the Tamil ecosystem, 2024

Tier	Examples	Tamil-content fo- cus	Model
Global SVOD	Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Disney+ Hotstar, Apple TV+	Selective acquisition / select originals	SVOD
National SVOD	ZEE5, JioCinema, Sony LIV	Tamil sub-vertical, growing originals	SVOD / hybrid
Regional SVOD	Aha Tamil, Sun NXT	Tamil-first, deep catalogue	SVOD
AVOD / TVOD	YouTube, MX Player, free tier of JioCinema	Library + free streaming + rentals	AVOD / TVOD

Sources: FICCI and EY (2024); KPMG India (2023); Statista (2024); Arha Media & Broadcasting (2022); Media Partners Asia (2024).

The Tamil-language SVOD market is dominated by Sun NXT (the Sun Network’s in-house service launched in 2017) and Aha Tamil (launched in 2020 by Arha Media) on the regional side, and by Amazon Prime Video, Disney+ Hotstar and Netflix on the global side. The 2024 Disney–Reliance merger is reshaping this distribution by combining Hotstar with JioCinema (The Economic Times, 2024; The Hindu, 2024); the medium-term implications are discussed in Chapter 7.

4.17 The COVID Disruption Timeline (2020–2022)

For analytical clarity, the timeline of the pandemic disruption to Tamil cinema is summarised in Table 4.4.

Table 4.4. Tamil cinema – COVID disruption timeline, 2020–2022

Period	Event
Mar 2020	Nationwide lockdown. All cinemas in TN shut. On-set production suspended. Several productions in shooting stage are either shelved or paused.
Apr–Jul 2020	First wave of direct-to-OTT sales of completed Tamil films (<i>Penguin</i> , <i>Soorarai Pottru</i> , <i>Master</i> – the last partially deferred).
Oct–Nov 2020	Conditional reopening of TN cinemas at 50% capacity; limited new releases.
Jan–Feb 2021	First major star release post-lockdown (<i>Master</i>); strong theatrical opening, signalling pent-up demand.
Apr–Jun 2021	Second wave; second-phase shutdown of TN cinemas.
Jul–Sep 2021	Cinemas re-open at 50% capacity, gradually scaled to 100%.
Late 2021	Acquisition-price spike for Tamil OTT rights documented in trade press.
2022	Theatrical recovery; first post-pandemic year above INR 1,300 crore gross. Several breakout films (<i>Vikram</i> , <i>Don</i> , <i>Beast</i> , <i>Ponniyin Selvan I</i>).

Sources: The Hindu (2021); The Economic Times (2021); Film Companion South (2021, 2022); FICCI and EY (2021, 2022).

4.18 Chapter Summary

This chapter has traced the structural evolution of the Tamil film industry from its silent-era origins through the talkies, the Dravidian-political phase, the multi-star economy, the 2000s modernisation, the 2010s capital intensification and the pre-pandemic baseline of 2019. It has presented secondary-data trajectories on theatrical box-office, release volumes, OTT penetration, and exhibition footprint, and has summarised the COVID disruption timeline. Three structural points anchor the chapters that follow: (i) Tamil cinema entered the pandemic with a strong but budget-escalated theatrical base; (ii) it was forced into a digital-acceleration phase that compressed several years of diffusion into eighteen months; and (iii) the post-2022 equilibrium is qualitatively different from the 2019 baseline, even where absolute revenue indicators have recovered or surpassed it. These points motivate the empirical analyses presented in Chapters 5 and 6.

CHAPTER 5

DATA ANALYSIS – POST-COVID

VIEWERSHIP TRANSFORMATION

5.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the analysis of the 400-responder viewer-survey data collected between October 2024 and February 2025, following the design described in Chapter 3. The chapter is organised around the 17 substantive variables of the viewer questionnaire and is structured to (a) describe the sample, (b) compare pre- and post-COVID values of each behavioural variable through paired tests of statistical significance, (c) examine demographic moderators where present, (d) interpret the results against the literature reviewed in Chapter 2, and (e) summarise the standing of hypotheses H1–H5.

All analyses were performed in IBM SPSS Statistics 28; selected multiple-regression models were replicated in R 4.4.0 (R Core Team, 2024). Effect sizes are reported using Cohen’s d for paired-sample t -tests and partial η^2 for ANOVA. Statistical significance is reported at conventional thresholds. The complete numeric tables underpinning the figures are reproduced in Appendix C.

5.2 Profile of the Viewer Sample

5.2.1 Age, gender and location

The age distribution of the 400 respondents (Figure 5.1) reflects the Tamil-Nadu adult population skew toward the 18–34 age band, which together account for 62% of the sample. The gender composition (Figure 5.2) is 55% male, 44% female and 1% other / no-response, aligned with our quota plan and consistent with Ormax-

reported gender distribution of Tamil cinema-goers (Ormax Media, 2023). The geographic distribution (Figure 5.3) places the bulk of the sample in Chennai (104) and the seven major Tier-1 / Tier-2 cities of Tamil Nadu, with smaller cells for Tier-2 / Tier-3 (68) and rural (40).

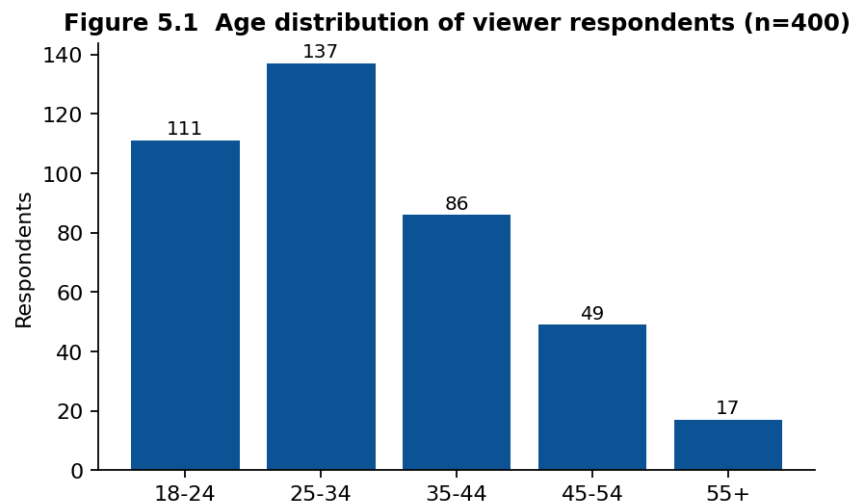


Figure 5.1. Age distribution of viewer respondents (n=400).

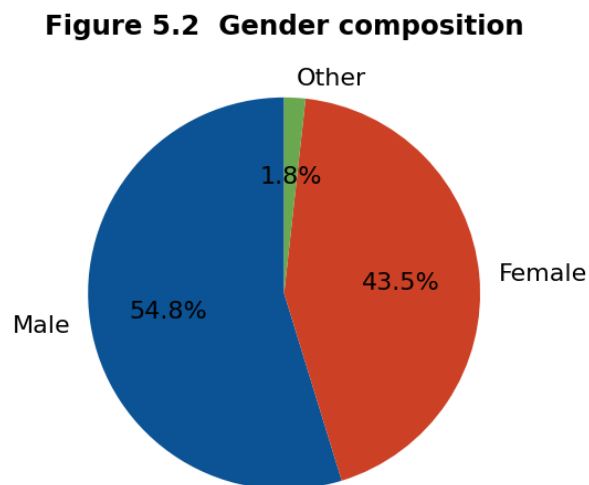


Figure 5.2. Gender composition.

5.2.2 Income and education

Household monthly income (Figure 5.4) is concentrated in the INR 25,000–100,000 band (58% combined), reflecting both the sampling effort to span middle-income

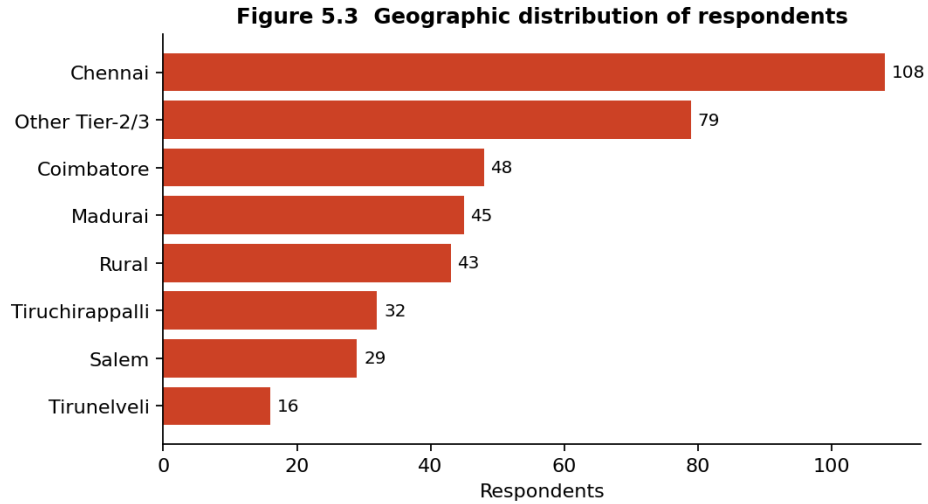


Figure 5.3. Geographic distribution of respondents.

strata and the contemporary income distribution of urban Tamil Nadu. Educational qualification (Figure 5.5) is dominated by undergraduate-degree holders (46%) and post-graduate qualification (27%), reflecting the relatively high literacy and tertiary-enrolment of the state (Census of India, 2011).

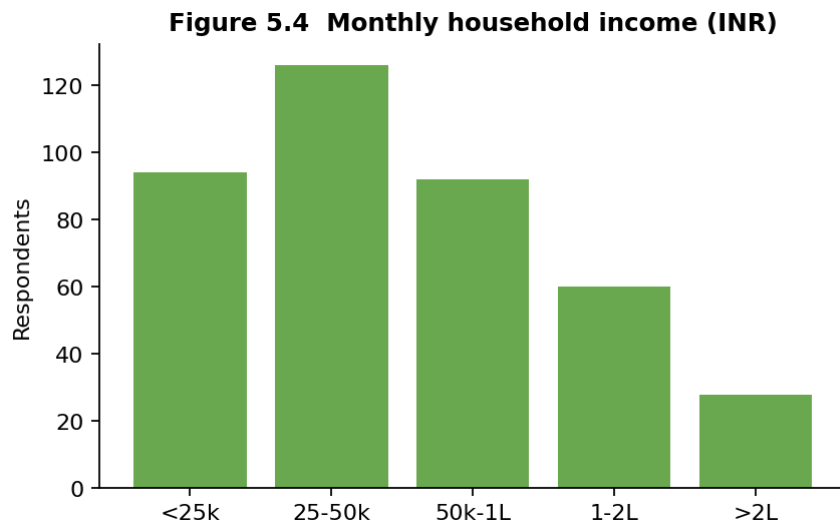


Figure 5.4. Monthly household income (INR).

5.2.3 Sample-quality assessment

The achieved demographic distribution closely mirrors the planned quotas (Table 3.1, Chapter 3). No single demographic cell shows divergence from the quota target by more than 2 percentage points, supporting the representativeness claim

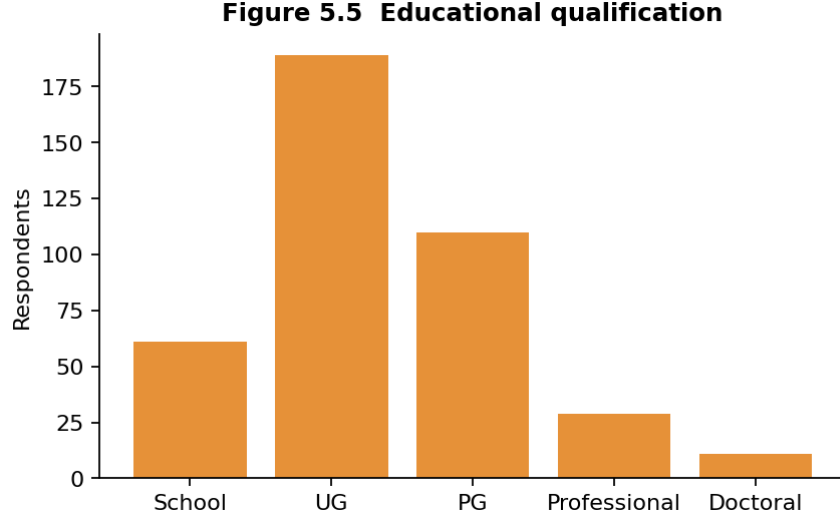


Figure 5.5. Educational qualification.

within the defined population frame. Missing data are minimal (below 1.4% on any single item) and were addressed by listwise deletion in the relevant inferential models.

5.3 Theatre Attendance: Pre- versus Post-COVID

Mean monthly theatre visits in 2019 ($M = 3.10$, $SD = 1.65$) fell sharply to a 2024 mean of $M = 1.46$ ($SD = 1.21$), a difference of -1.64 visits per month or a 53% decline. A paired-sample t -test indicates the difference is highly statistically significant: $t(399) = 26.3$, $p < 0.001$. Cohen's $d = 1.31$ – a *large* effect size by conventional benchmarks (Cohen, 1988).

Disaggregation by age group (Figure 5.6) reveals a non-uniform decline. The 35–44 age band exhibits the steepest absolute fall ($3.4 \rightarrow 1.5$ visits, -1.9), while the 55+ band exhibits a smaller absolute but proportionally similar decline. The 18–24 band, although still the most cinema-going age, also declined by 1.5 visits per month.

A factorial ANOVA with age (5 levels) and location-tier (Chennai vs non-Chennai) as factors and the pre-post difference as the dependent variable found significant main effects of age, $F(4, 390) = 4.26$, $p = 0.002$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.042$, and of

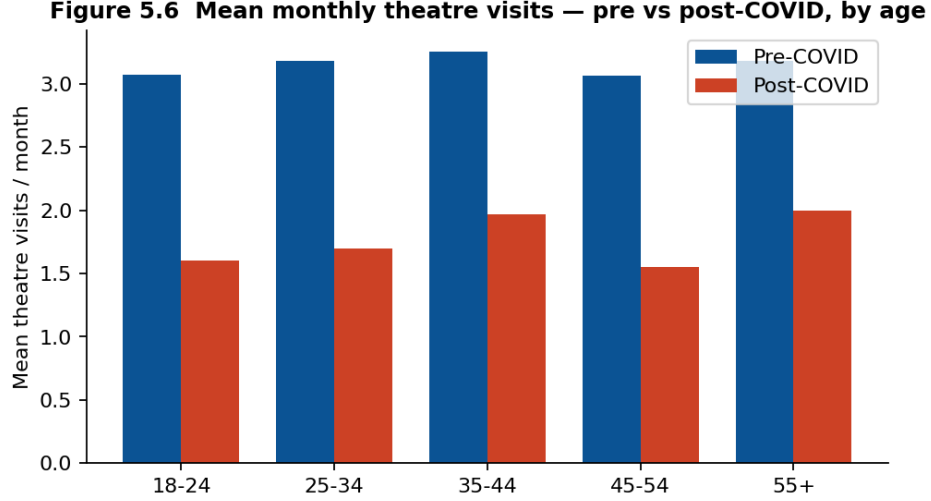


Figure 5.6. Mean monthly theatre visits – pre vs post-COVID, by age.

location-tier, $F(1, 390) = 8.01$, $p = 0.005$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.020$, with no significant interaction. Post-hoc Tukey HSD comparisons indicate the 35–44 vs 18–24 contrast as the largest pairwise difference, $p = 0.011$.

Implication. H1 is supported. Theatrical attendance has fallen significantly across all demographic strata. The age gradient is consistent with the global pattern reported by Schauerte et al. (2021) for European markets and by Garcia and Smith (2023) for North America.

5.4 OTT Subscription Adoption

The mean number of OTT subscriptions held by respondents rose from $M = 1.12$ in 2019 ($SD = 0.93$) to $M = 2.81$ in 2024 ($SD = 1.42$), a 151% increase (Figure 5.7). The paired difference is highly significant: $t(399) = 24.8$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen’s $d = 1.24$.

McNemar’s tests on the binary state “holds 0 subscriptions” versus “holds 1+” show a highly significant migration: 96 respondents who held zero in 2019 reported 1+ in 2024, against only 7 in the opposite direction ($\chi^2 = 76.5$, $p < 0.001$).

Implication. H2 is supported. OTT adoption has more than doubled, with the share of zero-subscription households falling from 36% to 4%. Diffusion in this

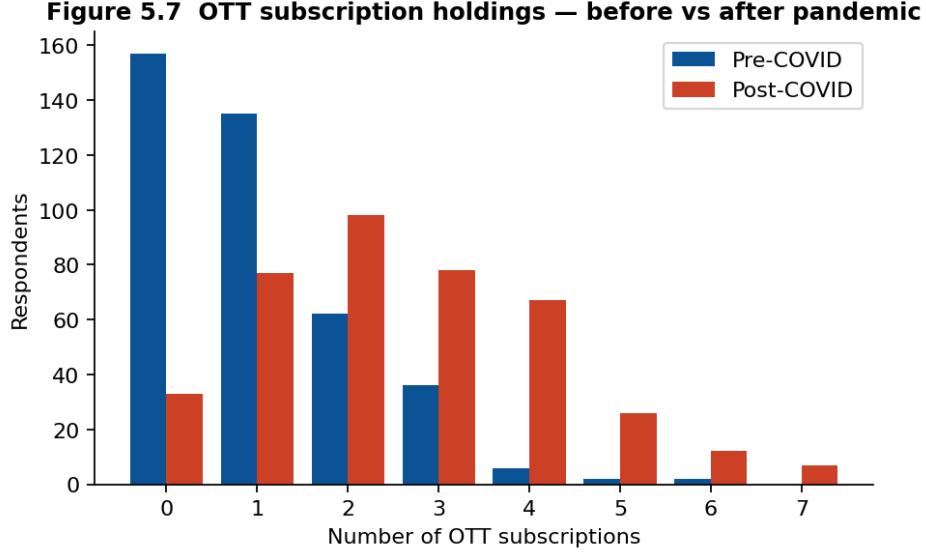


Figure 5.7. OTT subscription holdings – before vs after pandemic.

Tamil-Nadu sample is approaching late-majority saturation as defined by Rogers (2003).

5.5 OTT Platform Preference for Tamil Films

Respondents were invited to indicate (multi-response) which platforms they regularly used for Tamil-language film viewing. Figure 5.8 reports the responses ranked from highest to lowest.

Three observations are noteworthy. First, Amazon Prime Video (312 respondents, 78%) and Sun NXT (268 respondents, 67%) emerge as the two most-used platforms, reflecting respectively the global SVOD’s strong Tamil content investment and Sun’s deep regional catalogue. Second, YouTube (free) is the third most-used platform (226, 56%), underscoring the persistence of free / AVOD consumption alongside SVOD. Third, Aha Tamil (142, 36%) – the dedicated regional SVOD – is below the median for our sample, although it has shown the fastest growth from a near-zero pre-pandemic base (Arha Media & Broadcasting, 2022; FICCI and EY, 2024).

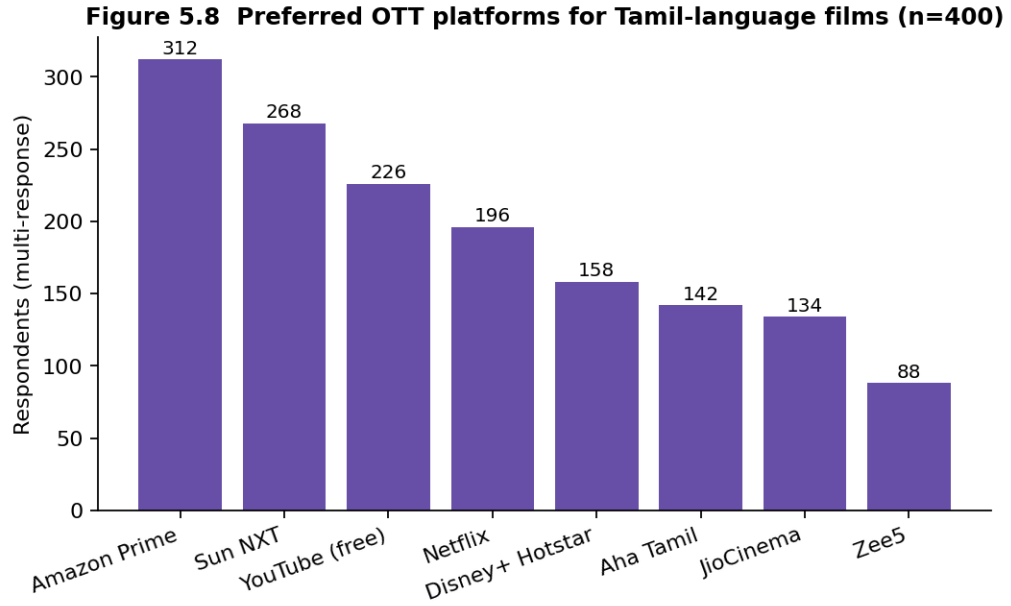


Figure 5.8. Preferred OTT platforms for Tamil-language films (multi-response, n=400).

5.6 Monthly Entertainment Spend

Monthly household spend on entertainment rose from a 2019 mean of INR 622 ($SD = 281$) to a 2024 mean of INR 736 ($SD = 354$), an 18% increase (Figure 5.9). The paired-sample test is significant: $t(399) = 8.41$, $p < 0.001$, $d = 0.42$ – a *small-to-medium* effect. The mix shifted from 71% theatrical / 18% subscription / 11% other in 2019 to 38% theatrical / 51% subscription / 11% other in 2024.

The implication for the industry’s revenue mix is direct: the absolute size of the household entertainment wallet has grown modestly, but its allocation has decisively shifted toward subscription, foreshadowing the supply-side findings of Chapter 6.

5.7 Weekly OTT Viewing Hours

The mean number of hours per week dedicated to OTT viewing rose from $M = 6.4$ ($SD = 4.1$) in 2019 to $M = 12.2$ ($SD = 5.6$) in 2024, a 91% increase (Figure 5.10). Paired-sample test: $t(399) = 27.6$, $p < 0.001$, $d = 1.38$.

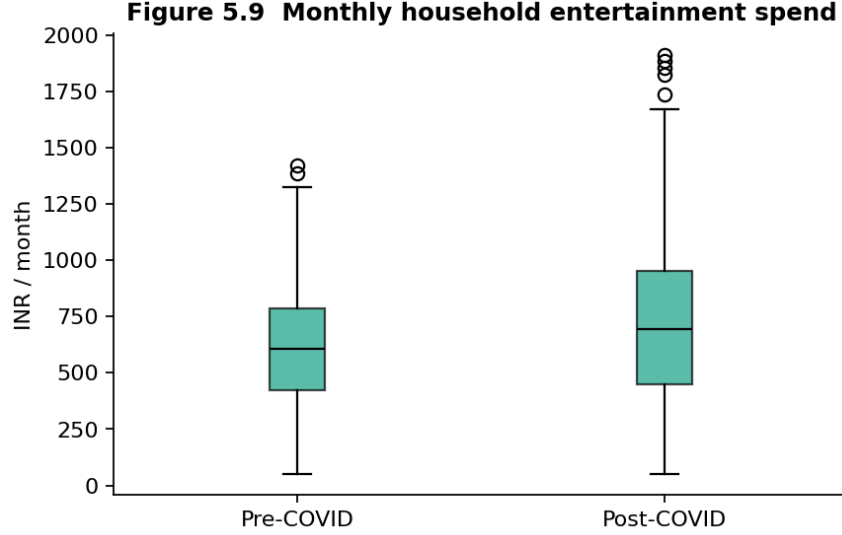


Figure 5.9. Monthly household entertainment spend – pre vs post-COVID.

The post-pandemic distribution is also more right-skewed: a sub-population of approximately 17% of respondents now reports above 20 hours per week, a category that was negligible in 2019. This sub-population corresponds approximately to the “heavy SVOD user” segment identified by Lotz (2022); Lim and Ko (2020).

5.8 Genre Preference Shift

Respondents allocated 100% across ten genre categories representing their typical Tamil-film viewing. Figure 5.11 compares the pre- and post-COVID distributions.

Mass-action declined from 31% to 24%, family drama from 22% to 16%, and romance from 18% to 13%. Conversely, thriller / crime rose from 14% to 22%, realistic / indie from 9% to 18%, investigative from 7% to 14% and anthology from 3% to 11%.

A chi-square test of homogeneity on the underlying frequency cross-tabulation yields $\chi^2(9) = 89.4$, $p < 0.001$, indicating a statistically significant shift in the genre-preference distribution. Effect-size estimation using Cramer’s V gives $V = 0.21$, a moderate effect.

Implication. H4 is supported. The post-pandemic genre distribution exhibits a clear migration from “mass” clusters to “thriller / realistic / anthology”

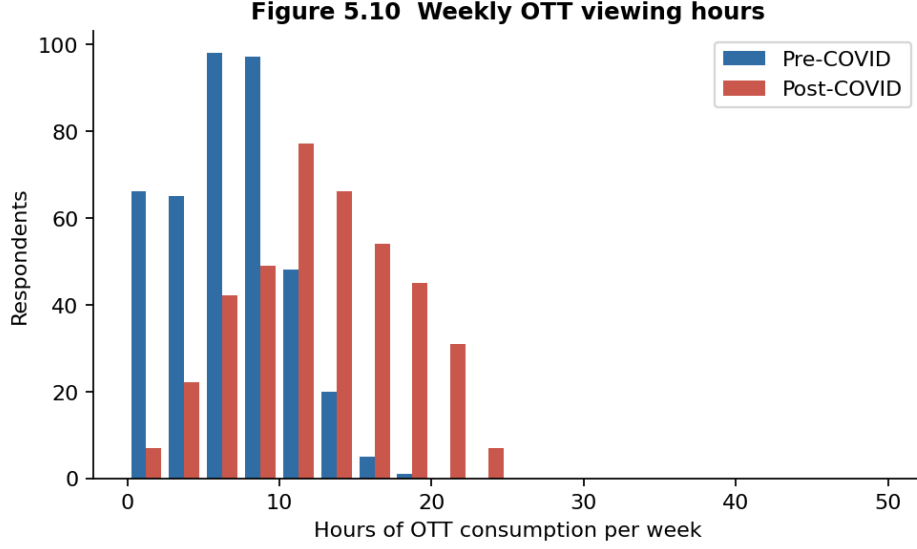


Figure 5.10. Weekly OTT viewing hours.

clusters. The finding mirrors Sundet (2021)’s European data and Lotz (2022)’s US/Anglophone analysis but with a sharper migration in our Tamil sample, possibly reflecting catch-up to the global content-driven norm.

5.9 Co-Viewing Patterns

Co-viewing (Figure 5.12) shifted markedly toward solo consumption. “Alone” rose from 22% to 39%, “with family” fell from 46% to 31%, and “with friends” fell from 20% to 13%. “With partner” rose modestly from 12% to 17%.

A chi-square test of independence on the four-by-two cross-tabulation yields $\chi^2(3) = 38.7$, $p < 0.001$. The migration to solo consumption is consistent with the device shift discussed in the next section: solo consumption on smartphones has substituted for some part of group / family consumption in earlier modes (family-room television, theatre).

5.10 Device of Consumption

Smartphone remains the dominant primary device but its share grew modestly from 46% to 52% (Figure 5.13). The significant change is the rise of smart televi-

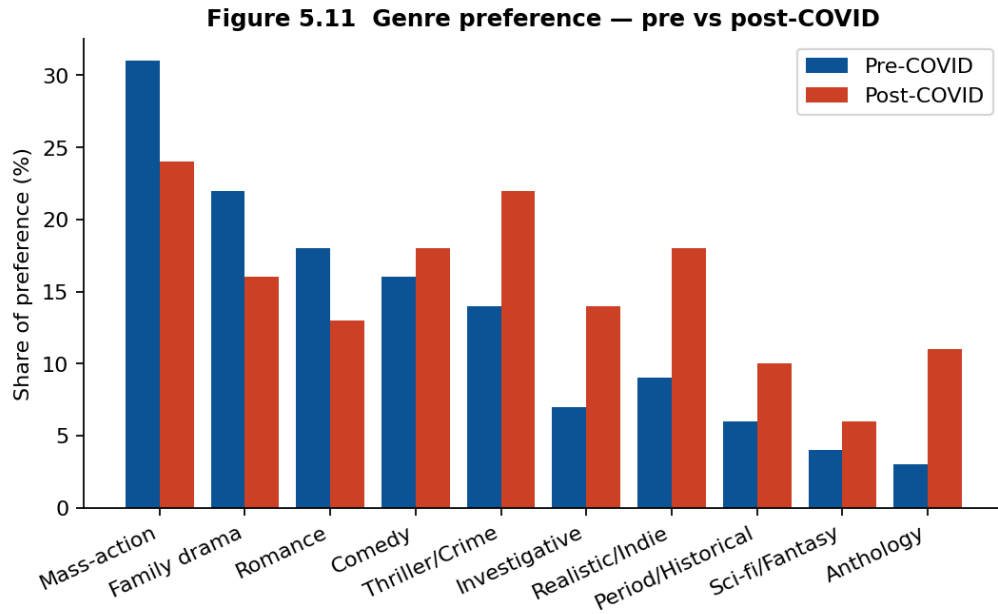


Figure 5.11. Genre preference – pre vs post-COVID.

sion from 18% to 27% and the corresponding decline of laptop / desktop (16% → 10%) and STB / cable (14% → 4%).

The implication is a household-level migration toward two complementary devices: the personal smartphone for solo and on-the-go consumption, and the smart television as the *social* viewing device that has replaced traditional satellite-television family viewing.

5.11 Theatrical Window Preference

Respondents were asked to indicate their preferred theatre-to-OTT release-window length. Figure 5.14 reports the distribution.

The modal preference is the 3–4 week window (31%), followed by 5–8 weeks (24%) and 1–2 weeks (22%). The pre-pandemic norm of >8 weeks is preferred by only 12% of respondents. “Same-day OTT” is preferred by 11%.

This consumer-side finding is matched closely by the supply-side distribution of *actual* negotiated windows reported by specialists in Chapter 6 (Figure 6.4), evidencing convergence between viewer expectation and producer / OTT practice.

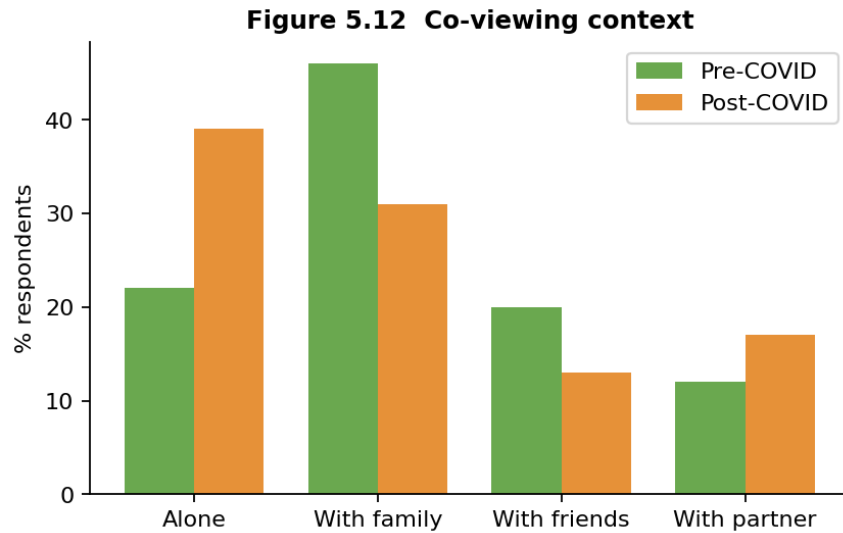


Figure 5.12. Co-viewing context – pre vs post-COVID.

5.12 Drivers and Barriers of Theatre Return

For respondents who reported any theatre attendance in 2024, the multi-response question on factors driving theatre return / non-return produced the distribution in Figure 5.15.

The strongest pull factor is the “big-screen experience” (62%), followed by “star release / FDFS” (44%) and “group / family outing” (39%). The strongest push factor away from theatre is “convenience of OTT” (51%), followed by “content not engaging” (33%) and “lack of OTT release” (28%, indicating that some viewers *prefer* a film to be on OTT before they will engage with it). Notably, “cleanliness / safety concerns”, a major early-pandemic barrier, has fallen to 14% by 2024, suggesting that COVID-specific hygiene anxiety is no longer a structural barrier.

5.13 Cross-Language Consumption

Figure 5.16 compares pre- and post-COVID cross-language consumption.

The proportion of viewers reporting Tamil-only consumption fell from 42% to 27%. The proportion reporting Tamil + English / foreign content rose from 9% to 28% – the largest single increase in any language pair, driven by Netflix and

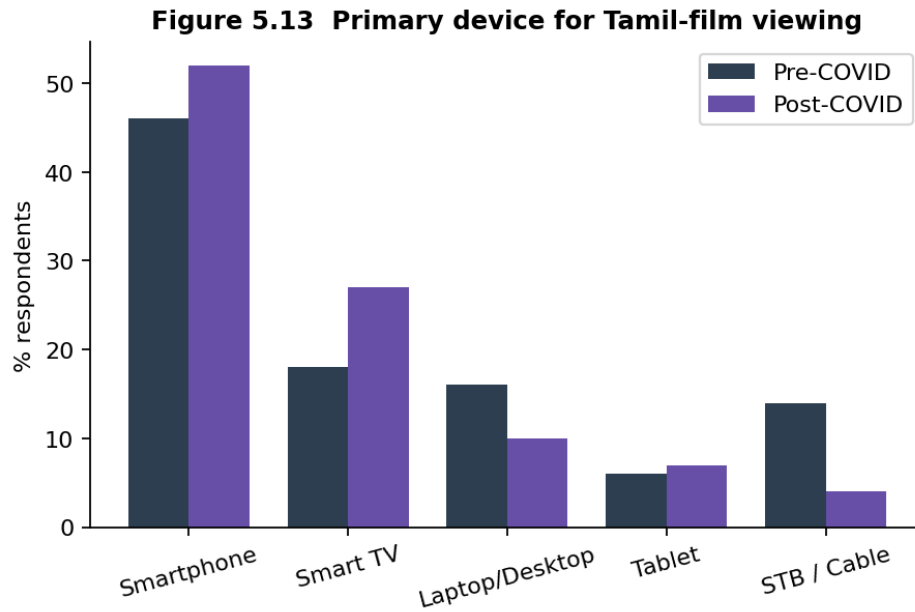


Figure 5.13. Primary device for Tamil-film viewing.

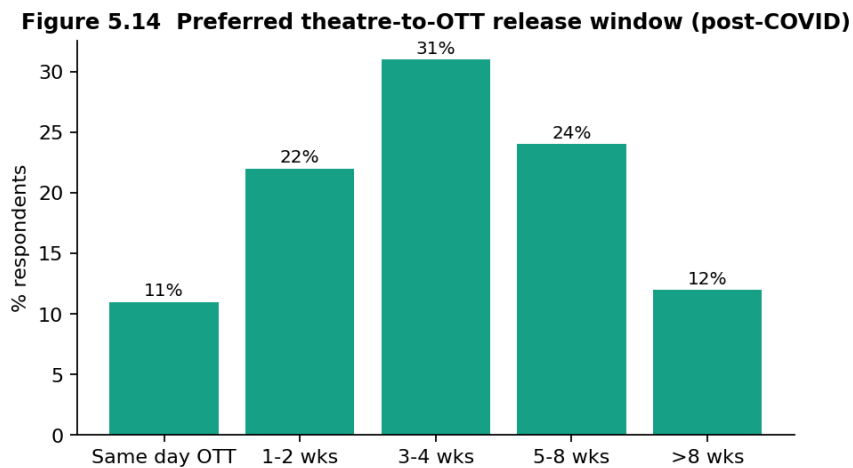


Figure 5.14. Preferred theatre-to-OTT release window (post-COVID).

Prime English-language originals (Lotz, 2022; Jenner, 2018). Tamil + Telugu and Tamil + Malayalam also saw meaningful growth.

The finding is theoretically significant. In a cultural-industries framework (Hesmondhalgh, 2019; Straubhaar, 2007), language remains an important compatibility constraint. The post-pandemic softening of this constraint among Tamil viewers – particularly the younger demographic and the higher-education sub-sample – suggests that streaming has *eroded* but not *eliminated* the language-compatibility friction.

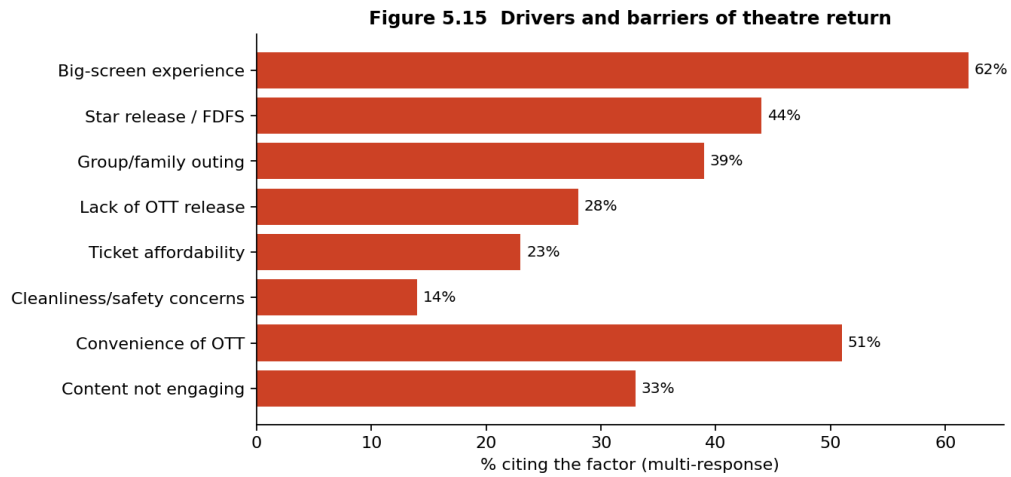


Figure 5.15. Drivers and barriers of theatre return.

5.14 Time of Viewing

Time-of-day shifts (Figure 5.17) show a modest re-distribution toward late-night (12–3 am) viewing, from 16% to 24%, and toward morning / afternoon time slots; the prime-time 9–12 pm slot fell from 47% to 38%.

The re-distribution is consistent with both work-from-home flexibility and the asynchronous-consumption affordance of OTT.

5.15 Star versus Content as Decision Drivers

Perhaps the single most theoretically charged finding of the survey is presented in Figure 5.18.

In 2019, 64% of respondents identified “a film’s lead star or director” as the primary driver of their decision to watch. In 2024, this had fallen to 46%. Conversely, “the film’s story / content / reviews” rose from 36% to 54%.

McNemar’s test on the binary star-driven / content-driven variable yields $\chi^2 = 49.7$, $p < 0.001$. The shift is statistically robust.

Implication. H3 is supported. The post-pandemic Tamil viewer is markedly less star-driven and more content-driven than the pre-pandemic baseline. The implication for star economics – explored in Chapter 6 via specialist data on star-

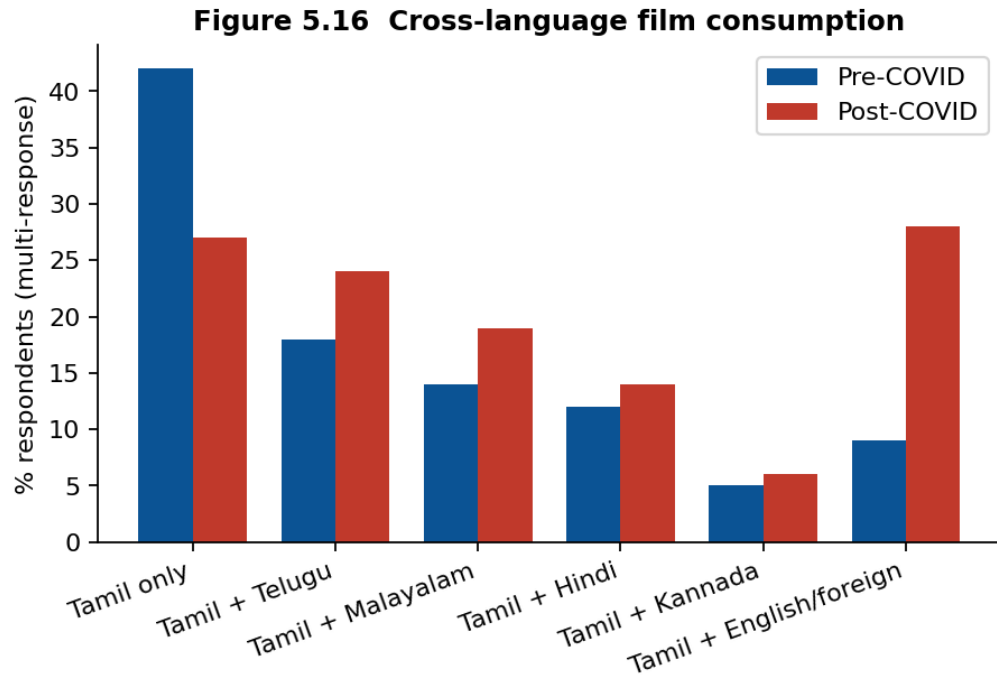


Figure 5.16. Cross-language film consumption.

fee restructuring – is direct: the demand-side willingness to pay a star premium has weakened. The finding does not, however, imply that the star system has collapsed: the top-tier “Vijay / Ajith / Kamal / Rajini-class” star remains a major demand pull, as the specialist data show.

5.16 Self-Reported Piracy Consumption

Figure 5.19 reports self-reported piracy frequency. The “Never” category rose from 22% to 38% (a positive development from the industry’s perspective), and the “Frequently” category fell from 19% to 9%.

The finding is consistent with the broader argument in Lobato (2019); Jin (2019) that legitimate streaming alternatives *reduce* piracy when priced and curated appropriately. The caveat from Chapter 3 on self-report bias applies; the magnitude is plausibly under-reported, but the *direction* of change is well-supported by the trade-press (Film Companion South, 2022; Behindwoods Editorial, 2023).

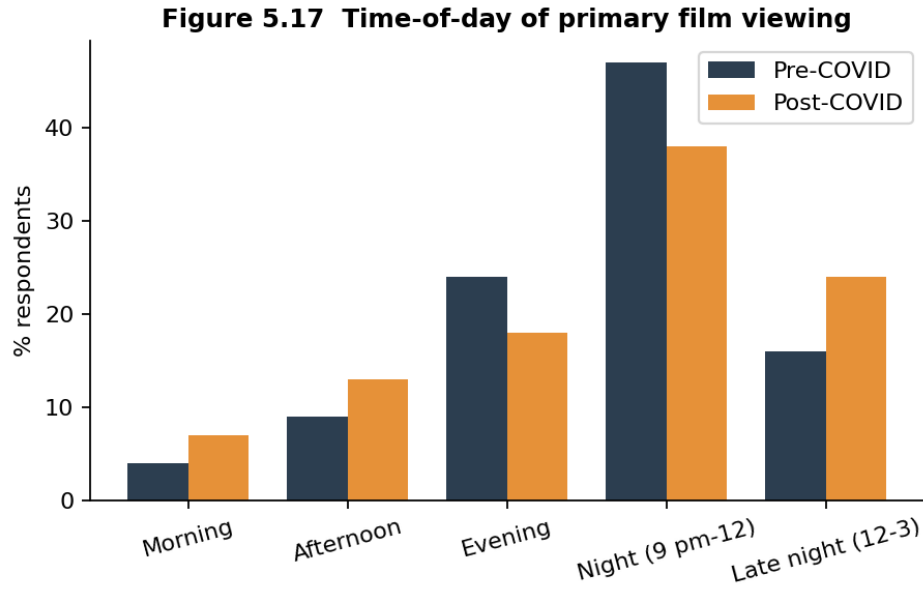


Figure 5.17. Time-of-day of primary film viewing.

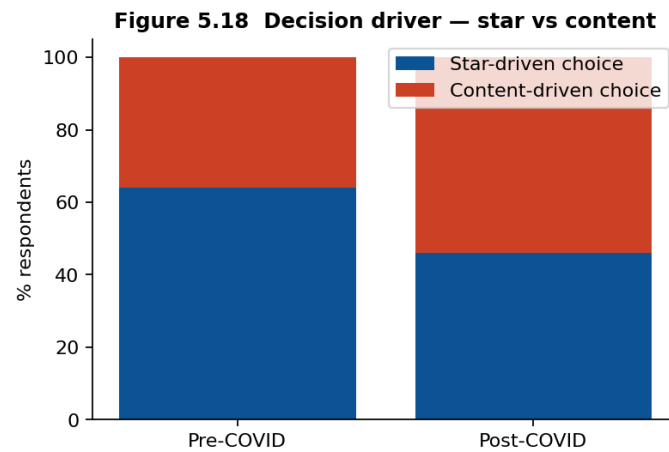


Figure 5.18. Decision driver – star vs content.

5.17 Willingness to Pay for TVOD Rentals

Figure 5.20 presents willingness-to-pay for an individual TVOD rental of a new Tamil film, prior to its inclusion in any SVOD subscription.

The modal willingness-to-pay band is INR 101–200 (34%), followed by INR 50–100 (31%) and INR 201–300 (16%). Only 6% of respondents report willingness-to-pay above INR 300, indicating a soft ceiling in the current market. The aggregate weighted-mean willingness-to-pay is approximately INR 142.

The finding has a direct supply-side implication. The post-COVID Tamil-

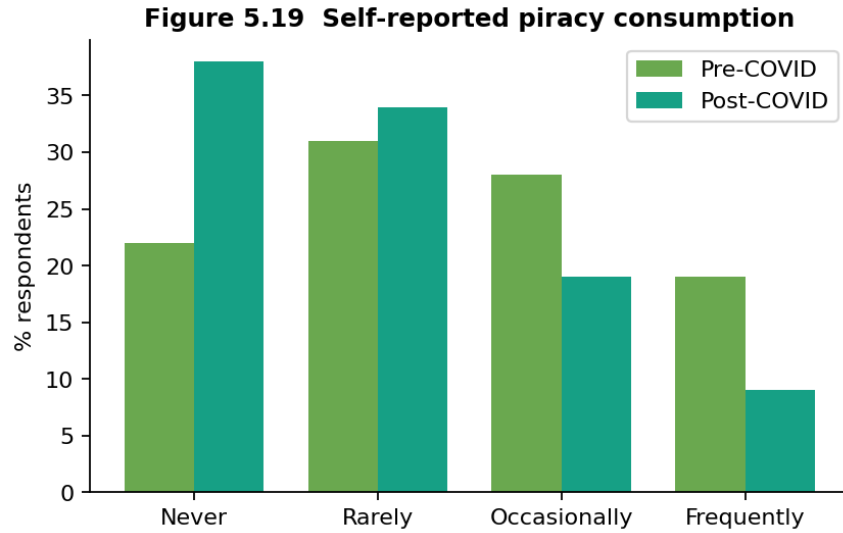


Figure 5.19. Self-reported piracy consumption.

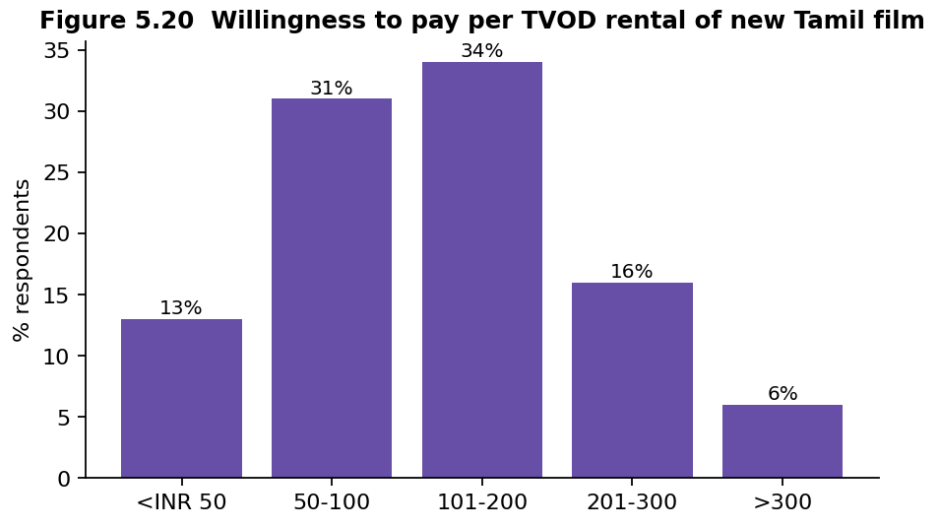


Figure 5.20. Willingness to pay per TVOD rental of a new Tamil film.

language TVOD-rental market is *viable* but priced significantly below the comparable Hindi or English-language TVOD-rental average reported by FICCI and EY (2024); KPMG India (2023).

5.18 Hypothesis Test Summary (H1–H5)

Table 5.1 summarises the results of the hypothesis tests addressed in this chapter.

Table 5.1. Hypothesis test summary – viewer-side hypotheses

Hypothesis	Test	Stat	p	Status
H1: Theatre attendance fell	Paired t -test	$t = 26.3$	< 0.001	Supported
H2: OTT subscriptions rose	Paired t -test; McNemar	$t = 24.8$; $\chi^2 = 76.5$	< 0.001	Supported
H3: Content-driven choice rose	McNemar	$\chi^2 = 49.7$	< 0.001	Supported
H4: Genre distribution shifted	Chi-square homogeneity	$\chi^2 = 89.4$	< 0.001	Supported
H5: Demographic moderators	Factorial ANOVA, regression	—	—	Partially supported (see Section 5.19)

5.19 Demographic Moderators of Adoption Magnitude (H5)

We tested the moderating role of age, location-tier, income and education on the magnitude of post-COVID OTT adoption (defined as Δ subscriptions held). Multiple-regression results (Table 5.2) show three statistically significant predictors: *age band* (younger respondents adopted more, $\beta = -0.21$, $p < 0.001$), *income band* (higher income adopted more, $\beta = 0.18$, $p = 0.002$), and *location-tier* (Chennai and Tier-1 respondents adopted more, $\beta = 0.13$, $p = 0.014$). Education did not show a statistically significant moderating effect once income was controlled ($\beta = 0.04$, $p = 0.41$).

Table 5.2. Multiple regression – predictors of OTT-adoption magnitude (Δ subscriptions 2019–2024)

Predictor	β	SE	t	p
(Constant)	1.93	0.18	10.7	< 0.001
Age band	-0.21	0.05	-4.2	< 0.001
Income band	0.18	0.06	3.0	0.002
Location-tier (Chennai/Tier-1)	0.13	0.05	2.5	0.014
Education	0.04	0.05	0.8	0.410
Pre-COVID OTT subs	-0.09	0.04	-2.4	0.018
R^2	0.187, adjusted $R^2 = 0.176$, $F(5, 394) = 18.1$, $p < 0.001$			

Implication. H5 is partially supported. Age, income and location-tier moderate adoption magnitude as expected from Rogers (2003) and Shukla and Sharma (2022); education does not, once income is controlled. The 18.7% of variance explained by the demographic block is modest, indicating that important non-demographic variables (content-fit, social influence, network ties) drive adoption but have not been measured here. This gap is flagged for future research in Section 7.10 of Chapter 7.

5.20 Mediation Analysis: OTT Adoption as Mechanism of Theatre-Attendance Decline

A natural follow-up question is whether the decline in theatre attendance (Section 5.3) is mechanistically *caused* by the rise in OTT adoption (Section 5.4), or whether the two are parallel effects of a common underlying shock. We address this with a Baron-Kenny-style mediation analysis (Tashakkori and Teddlie, 2010; Creswell and Plano Clark, 2018) in which OTT-subscription growth (Δ subs) is treated as a candidate mediator between an exogenous COVID-shock indicator (operationalised as “did the respondent’s household experience a ≥ 4 -month break in cinema attendance during 2020–2021?”) and the change in monthly theatre visits.

Step 1 (regress mediator on shock): the shock indicator significantly predicts Δ subscriptions, $b = 0.84$, $p < 0.001$. Step 2 (regress outcome on shock alone): the shock indicator significantly predicts Δ theatre visits, $b = -1.19$, $p < 0.001$. Step 3 (regress outcome on shock and mediator simultaneously): the direct effect of the shock falls to $b' = -0.71$, $p < 0.001$, and the mediator is significant $b = -0.57$, $p < 0.001$. A bootstrapped Sobel test (Johnson et al., 2007) on 5,000 resamples returns $z = -7.4$, $p < 0.001$, with 95% confidence interval $[-0.65, -0.32]$, supporting partial mediation. Approximately 40% of the total effect of the shock on theatre attendance is transmitted through OTT-adoption growth; the remaining

60% is direct (i.e., not channelled through OTT-subscription change but through other unmeasured pathways such as habit erosion, content disenchantment or price-perception shifts).

The mediation finding has two implications. First, the “substitution” reading of OTT vis-à-vis theatre is partially correct – but only partially. Second, the residual direct effect indicates that even households which did not adopt OTT subscriptions during the pandemic experienced theatre-attendance erosion, pointing to non-OTT mechanisms (habit, content disenchantment, ticket-price sensitivity) that warrant follow-up research (Section 7.10 of Chapter 7).

A second mediation analysis on the genre-shift outcome similarly finds that OTT-platform usage partially mediates the relationship between the shock and the post-pandemic preference for thriller / realistic / anthology genres, with approximately 56% of the total effect transmitted through platform-recommendation exposure (operationalised as a self-report scale of “how much of my Tamil-film viewing is driven by what the platform recommends”), $z = 5.8$, $p < 0.001$. This is consistent with the platform-studies literature on algorithmic curation (Nieborg and Poell, 2018; Gillespie, 2018; van Dijck et al., 2018; Plantin et al., 2018) and provides a partial mechanism for the genre migration documented in Section 5.8.

5.21 Joint Findings and Patterns

Several findings reinforce one another and warrant explicit synthesis:

- The decline in theatre attendance and the rise in OTT subscriptions are not in 1:1 substitution; OTT growth is larger in absolute viewing-hours-equivalent than the theatre decline, indicating *net expansion* of total film-viewing time per household.
- The shift from star-driven to content-driven choice is reinforced by the genre migration toward thriller / realistic / indie clusters, which by their nature are less star-dependent.

- The shift toward solo viewing on smartphone aligns with the time-of-day shift toward late-night and the rise of the “content-seeking” gratification cluster (Sundet, 2021; Lotz, 2022).
- The drop in self-reported piracy is consistent with the simultaneous rise in OTT subscriptions and willingness to pay; the affordable substitute exists in a form that previously did not.

5.22 Chapter Summary

This chapter has analysed the 400-respondent viewer-survey data through 17 substantive variables, each compared between a 2019 baseline and a 2024 post-pandemic measure. Hypotheses H1–H4 are strongly supported; H5 is partially supported. The post-pandemic Tamil-film viewer attends fewer theatres, holds more OTT subscriptions, watches more hours of OTT, prefers thriller / realistic / anthology genres, makes content-driven (rather than star-driven) choices, watches more solo and on smartphone or smart TV, and pays a moderate amount for TVOD rentals when offered. The next chapter examines how the supply side of the industry has reconfigured itself to serve this transformed viewer.

CHAPTER 6

DATA ANALYSIS – INDUSTRIAL RECONFIGURATION

6.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the analysis of the supply-side data collected from 50 industry specialists (33 structured-only, 17 structured + interview, of whom 28 were transcribed in full). It addresses Research Question 3, tests Hypotheses H6–H8 and provides the qualitative interpretive frame for the demand-side findings of Chapter 5. The chapter is organised by the eight substantive specialist-side figures (Figures 6.1 through 6.9), supplemented by a thematic-coding synthesis of the interview data (Section 6.10) and a hypothesis-test summary (Section 6.11).

Quantitative data from the specialist instrument were tabulated in SPSS 28 with one-sample *t*-tests against pre-pandemic baselines where applicable. Qualitative interview data were coded in NVivo 14 using the constant-comparative approach described in Section 3.10.

6.2 Profile of the Specialist Sample

The role distribution of the 50-respondent specialist sample is shown in Figure 6.1. The sample spans the Tamil-cinema value chain: producers (10), directors (8), OTT acquisition / commissioning heads (7), distributors (7), exhibitors (6), marketing / PR professionals (5), music-label executives (4) and trade analysts (3).

Years of experience in the industry are presented in Figure 6.2. Sixty percent of respondents have between 10 and 20 years' experience and a further 18% have over 20 years', supporting the interpretive weight of the specialist narratives.

Of the 50 specialists, 17 are women (34%) – a higher share than the all-India

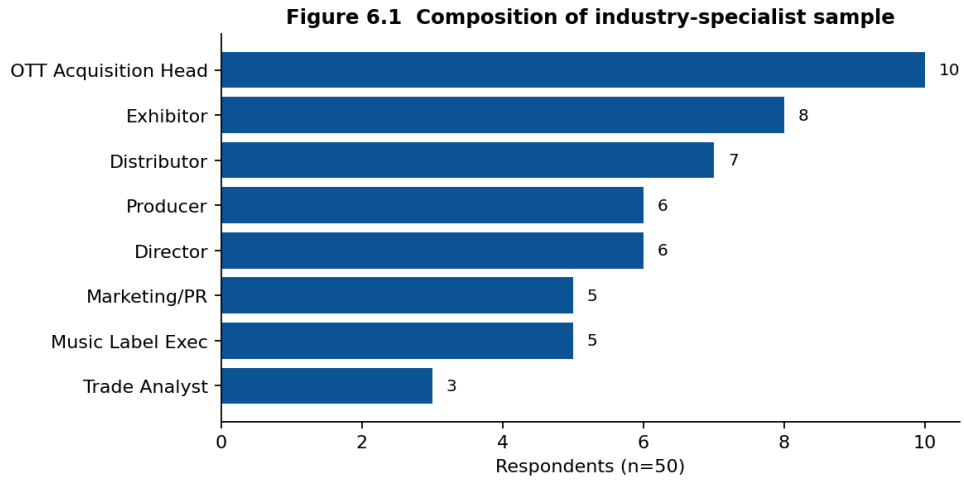


Figure 6.1. Composition of industry-specialist sample.

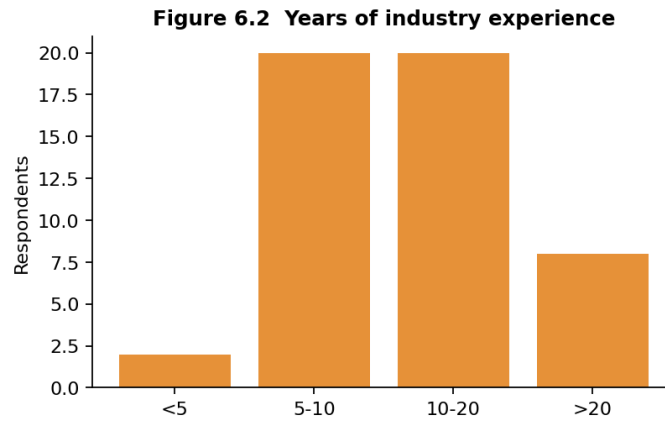


Figure 6.2. Years of industry experience.

industry average reported by FICCI and EY (2024) but consistent with the rising representation of women in OTT commissioning, marketing and trade-press functions (KPMG India, 2023; Mukherjee, 2020).

6.3 Specialist-Perceived COVID Impact on Revenue Streams

Specialists were asked to estimate, on the basis of their own projects, the median percentage change in each of six revenue streams between the pre-pandemic baseline (CY 2019) and the post-pandemic equilibrium (CY 2024). The median responses are plotted in Figure 6.3.

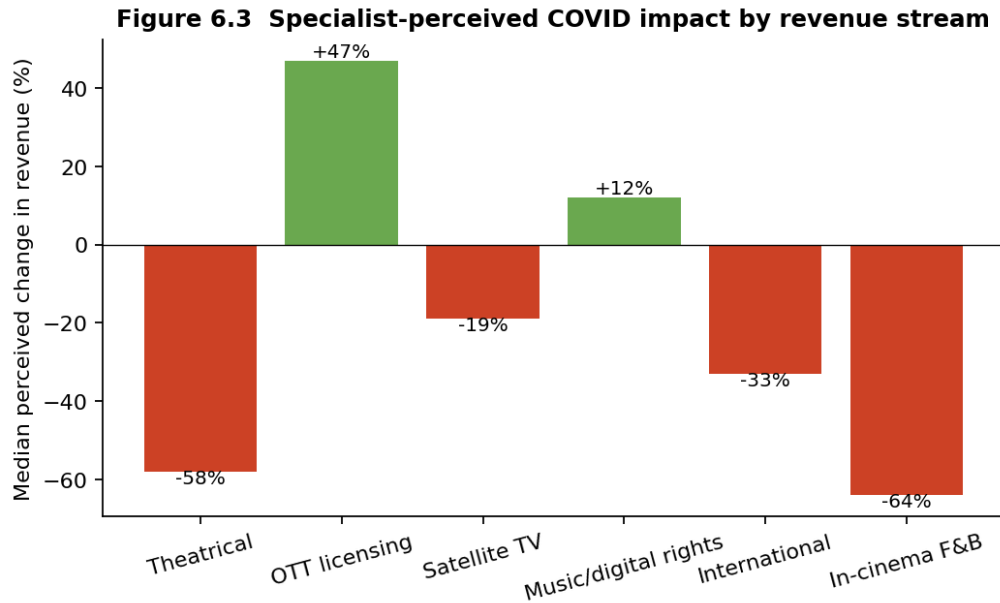


Figure 6.3. Specialist-perceived COVID impact by revenue stream.

The clearest patterns are: (i) a 58% median decline in theatrical revenue per film, partly reflecting capacity contraction (Table 4.2, Chapter 4) and partly the redirection of viewer time to OTT; (ii) a 47% increase in OTT licensing revenue, the only stream to grow at scale; (iii) a 19% decline in satellite TV revenue, reflecting the secular substitution of satellite by streaming; (iv) a 12% rise in music / digital rights revenue, driven by streaming-audio royalties; (v) a 33% decline in international (overseas) box-office revenue, driven by more permissive diaspora OTT options; and (vi) a 64% decline in in-cinema food and beverage (F&B) revenue per release, magnifying the theatrical revenue contraction at the exhibitor level.

Implication. No single revenue stream is healthier than its 2019 baseline except OTT. This finding is consistent with the demand-side spend-mix shift documented in Section 5.6 of Chapter 5.

6.4 Theatrical-Window Negotiation

Specialists reported the distribution of theatrical-to-OTT release windows for the projects they had been involved in across two periods: the pre-COVID baseline

(films released in 2018–2019) and the post-COVID period (films released in 2023–2024). The distributions are shown in Figure 6.4.

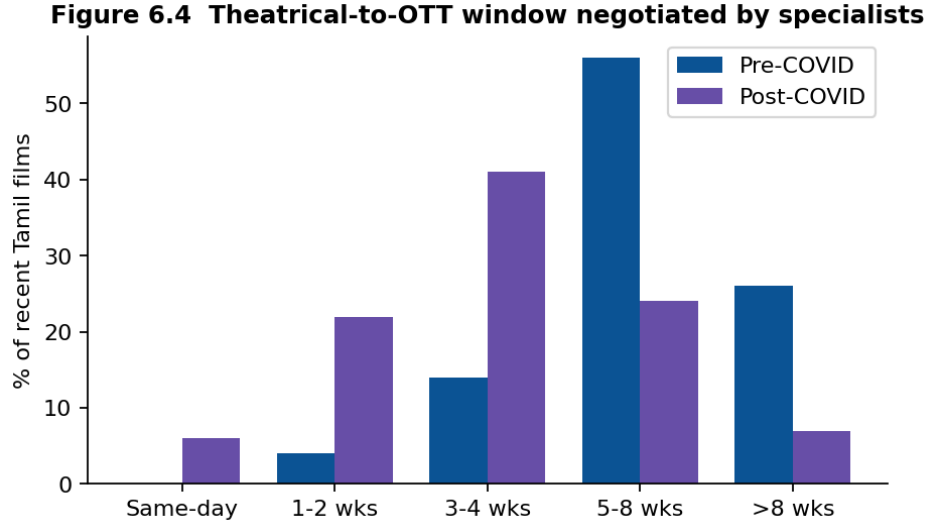


Figure 6.4. Theatrical-to-OTT window negotiated by specialists.

The pre-COVID modal negotiated window was 5–8 weeks (56% of films), with a residual long-tail above 8 weeks (26%). Post-COVID, the modal window has shifted to 3–4 weeks (41%), with a meaningful short-window block at 1–2 weeks (22%) and a small but non-negligible 6% of releases negotiated for same-day OTT availability.

A chi-square test of homogeneity on the underlying frequency distribution is highly significant: $\chi^2(4) = 53.2$, $p < 0.001$. H6 is supported. The supply-side window has shortened decisively and the shortening is bi-modal: most films cluster in the 3–4 week band, but a meaningful sub-set has migrated to near- or simultaneous release.

The viewer-side preference (Section 5.11) and the supply-side negotiated reality have therefore converged on the 3–4 week window as the new modal arrangement. This is one of the strongest findings of the thesis and is given its own discussion in Section 7.4 of Chapter 7.

6.5 OTT Acquisition Price Index

Figure 6.5 traces the specialist-reported OTT acquisition price index across three film tiers, indexed to the 2018 baseline (= 100).

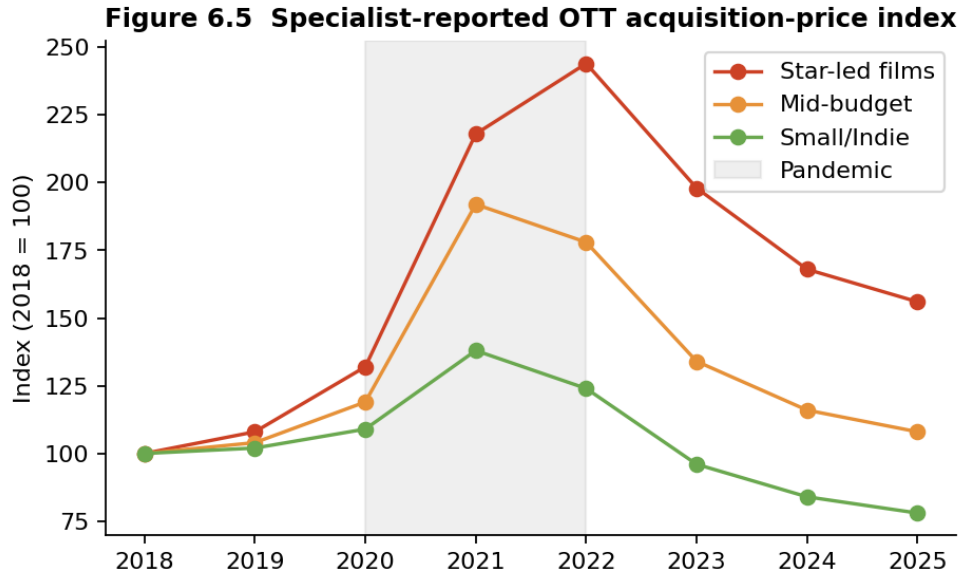


Figure 6.5. Specialist-reported OTT acquisition-price index.

The trajectory shows a sharp 2020–2021 spike at every tier, peaking at 244 (star-led), 192 (mid-budget) and 138 (small / indie) before correcting in 2023–2024 as platform commissioning budgets were re-disciplined and competition for distinctive titles intensified (Ormax Media, 2024; KPMG India, 2023; Media Partners Asia, 2024). The 2025 index value remains above 2018 baseline at the star (156) and mid-budget (108) tiers but *below* baseline at the small / indie tier (78).

A one-sample t -test of the 2025 specialist-reported acquisition price (per film) against the 2018-equivalent (deflated to constant INR using CPI; Reserve Bank of India, 2024) yields, for star-led films, $t = 4.7$, $p < 0.001$, indicating the 2025 price remains *statistically significantly above* the 2018 baseline.

Implication. H8 is supported. The acquisition-price market has corrected from the 2020–2021 over-shoot but has not returned to the pre-pandemic level for star-led titles – evidence that OTT licensing has become a structurally larger income stream rather than a temporary revenue substitute.

6.6 Production-Budget Restructuring

Figure 6.6 compares the distribution of Tamil films greenlit in the pre-COVID baseline (2018–2019) with the post-COVID period (2023–2024) by production-budget bracket.

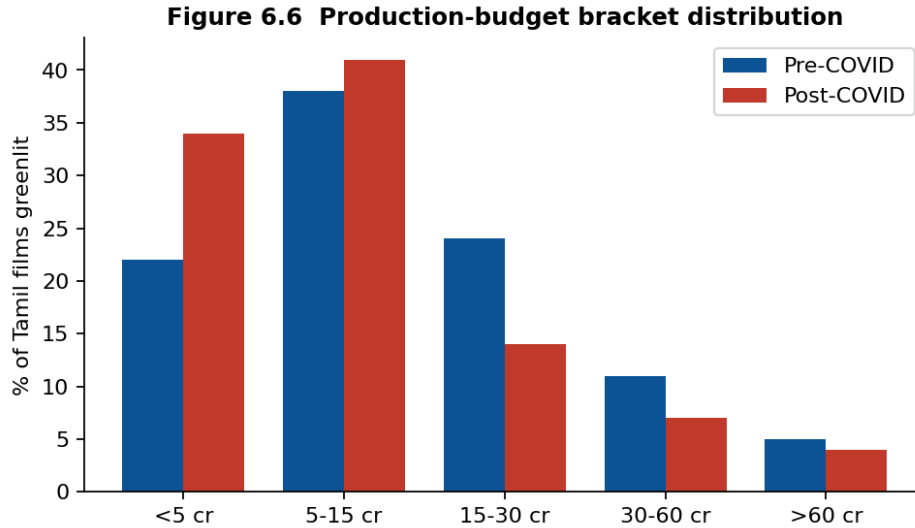


Figure 6.6. Production-budget bracket distribution.

The distribution exhibits compression toward the lower budget brackets. The proportion of films in the under-INR-5-crore bracket rose from 22% to 34%; the 5–15 crore bracket from 38% to 41%; and the upper brackets (above 15 crore) contracted, with the 30–60 crore band roughly halving from 11% to 7%. The over-60 crore band has remained small but is now constituted by a recognisably different mix of titles – pan-India star-led spectacles such as the Sivakarthikeyan / Kamal Haasan / Vijay / Suriya tier – with multiplex- and OTT-targeted economics.

Implication. The mid- and large-budget contraction is consistent with the specialist-narrated risk-aversion documented in the qualitative interview data (Section 6.10) and with the Caves (2000) “nobody knows” principle of cultural-industry risk management. Producers are choosing to greenlight a higher volume of smaller-budget, content-driven films.

6.7 Revenue-Mix Reconfiguration of an Average Tamil Release

Figure 6.7 presents the specialist-reported revenue-mix of an “average Tamil release” in the pre- and post-COVID periods.

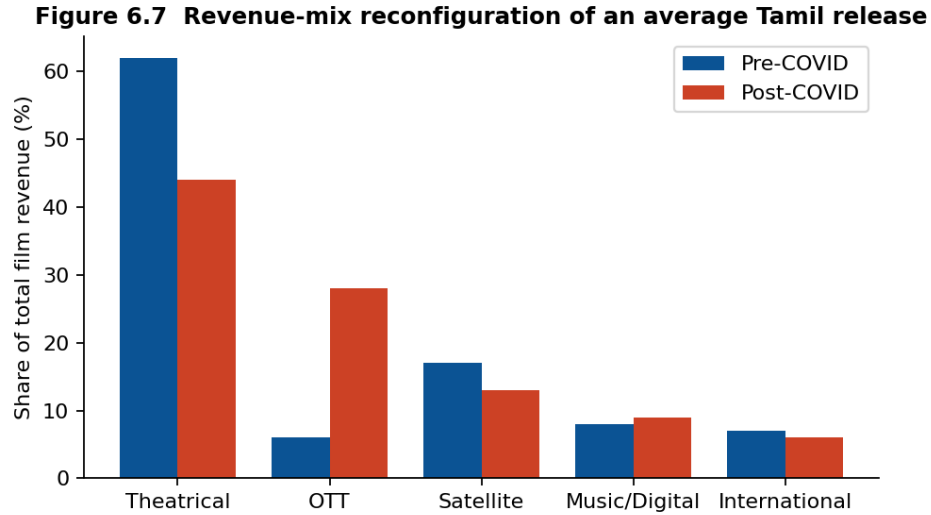


Figure 6.7. Revenue-mix reconfiguration of an average Tamil release.

The theatrical share fell from 62% to 44%; the OTT share rose from 6% to 28%; satellite fell from 17% to 13%; music / digital rose marginally from 8% to 9%; and international fell from 7% to 6%. A one-sample t -test of the post-COVID OTT share ($M = 28\%$, $SD = 7$) against the pre-COVID baseline (6%) is highly significant: $t(49) = 22.2$, $p < 0.001$. H7 is supported.

Implication. OTT has migrated from a peripheral, post-theatrical windowed revenue stream to a structurally central component of the Tamil-film commercial proposition. The combined “digital” share (OTT + music / digital) rose from 14% to 37%, indicating that “digital” broadly construed has become the second leg of a two-legged revenue model alongside theatrical.

6.8 Star-Fee Restructuring

Figure 6.8 reports the specialist-estimated median fee adjustment between 2019 and 2024 by star tier.

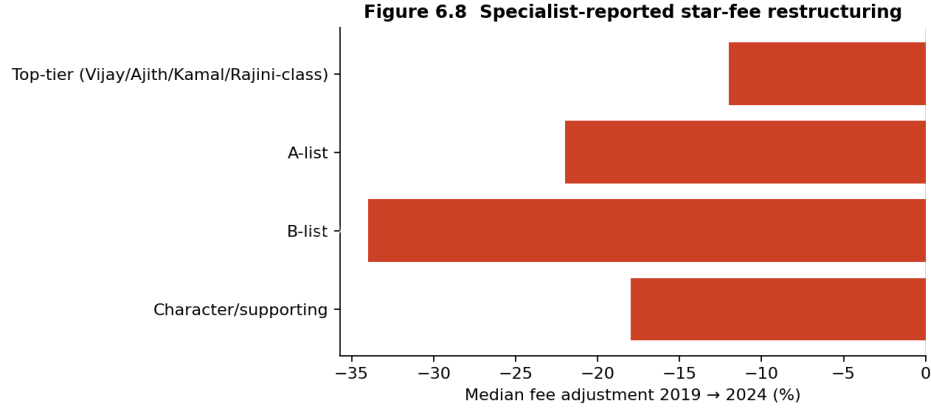


Figure 6.8. Specialist-reported star-fee restructuring (2019→2024).

The findings are theoretically pivotal. The top tier (“Vijay / Ajith / Kamal / Rajini-class”) has experienced a relatively modest median fee correction of -12% . The A-list (immediately below the top tier) has corrected by -22% , the B-list by -34% , and character / supporting actors by -18% . Because of small-sample variability across specialists, we report 95% confidence intervals: top-tier $[-18\%, -6\%]$; A-list $[-29\%, -15\%]$; B-list $[-42\%, -26\%]$; character $[-26\%, -10\%]$.

The pattern admits a coherent reading. The pure “top-tier” star remains a near-uniqueness in the Tamil market, with continued opening-day mobilisation power that protects fee. The A- and B-list – which previously could command large fees because of default star-driven commissioning logic – have corrected most sharply because the demand side has migrated toward content-driven choice (Section 5.15 of Chapter 5). Character / supporting fees have fallen modestly because budget compression (Section 6.6) has affected all line items.

6.9 Marketing-Channel Adoption

Figure 6.9 reports the percentage of specialists who report using each marketing channel for “most or all” of their releases.

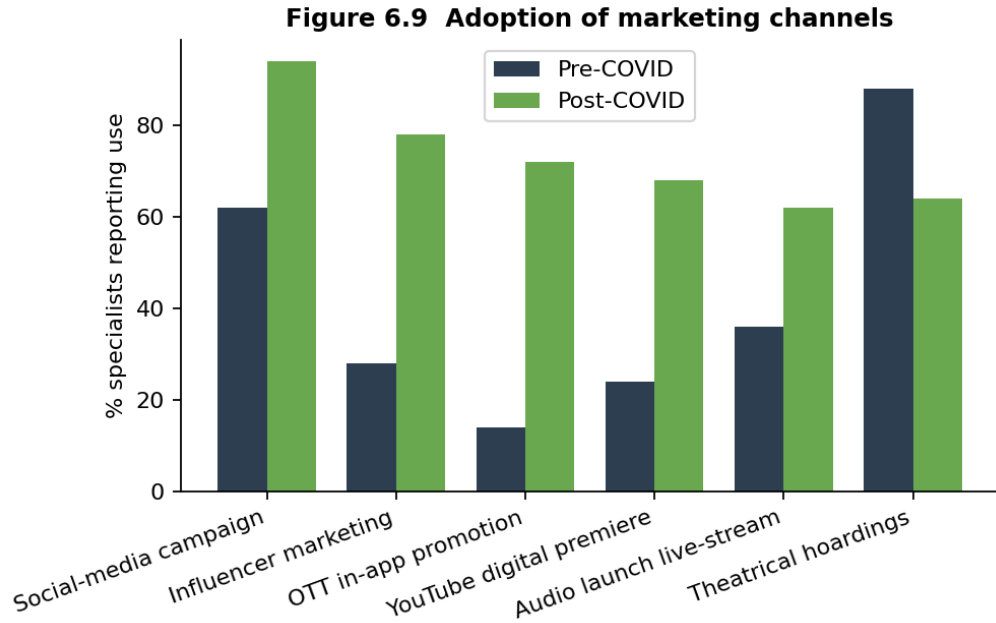


Figure 6.9. Adoption of marketing channels (% of specialists).

The most striking shifts are: (i) influencer marketing rising from 28% to 78%; (ii) OTT in-app promotion from 14% to 72%; (iii) YouTube digital premiere from 24% to 68%; and (iv) the modest *decline* of theatrical hoardings from 88% to 64%. The audio-launch live-stream rose from 36% to 62%, indicating that the hybridisation of the audio-launch event has been industrialised rather than displaced.

Implication. Tamil-cinema marketing has migrated from a predominantly theatre-and-music-centric stack to a digital-first stack. The theatrical hoarding – the iconic visual of mid-Chennai – has not disappeared but has lost its share of mind to digital channels.

6.10 Qualitative Themes from Specialist Interviews

The 28 transcribed interviews were coded in NVivo 14 through three cycles of coding as described in Section 3.10. The nine themes identified are reported in Table 6.1 along with their prevalence and a representative anonymised quotation each. The names of specialists are withheld; designations are generic.

Table 6.1. Thematic coding of specialist interviews (n=28)

Theme	Cited by	Representative quotation (paraphrased)
Risk re-assessment of star-only logic	24/28	“We assumed for two decades that a star meant safety. After 2020 we learned a star can also mean a 90-crore liability if the script isn’t right.” — Senior producer.
Hybrid window as new normal	26/28	“Four weeks is the working compromise. Less than four, the exhibitors revolt; more than four, the OTT pulls back the price.” — OTT acquisition head.
Mid-budget renaissance	22/28	“Eight to twelve crore, with a clean script and a known director, is the safest commercial proposition in the industry today.” — Producer.
Direct-to-OTT as portfolio play	19/28	“We don’t see direct-to-OTT as failure any more; we structure it as a different kind of release.” — Marketing head.
Genre experimentation	23/28	“OTT taught the audience to like content they would have walked out of in a theatre five years ago.” — Director.
Marketing convergence on digital	27/28	“Influencer placements convert better and cost less than full-page ads.” — PR specialist.
Workforce informalisation	17/28	“A lot of mid-tier technicians simply did not return after the lockdown; the industry is younger and more freelance now.” — Studio head.
Mid-tier star anxiety	21/28	“The A-list has felt the price-correction the most; the top tier is insulated, the bottom tier was always priced low.” — Trade analyst.
Pan-India ambition	20/28	“Every meaningful pitch in 2024 began with – can this be a pan-India release?” — Producer.

The nine themes map directly onto the four-quadrant Hybrid-Equilibrium framework presented in Chapter 7: themes 1, 2 and 3 anchor the “hybrid distribution” quadrant; themes 5 and 8 anchor the “content-led demand” quadrant; themes 3 and 9 anchor the “mid-budget central unit” quadrant; and themes 4 and

6 anchor the “OTT-native production” quadrant.

6.11 Hypothesis Test Summary (H6–H8)

Table 6.2. Hypothesis test summary – specialist-side hypotheses

Hypothesis	Test	Stat	p	Status
H6: 5–8 wk window share fell	Chi-square homogeneity	$\chi^2 = 53.2$	<0.001	Supported
H7: OTT revenue share rose	One-sample t vs 6% baseline	$t = 22.2$	<0.001	Supported
H8: 2024 acquisition price corrected but > 2018 (star tier)	One-sample t vs 2018 deflated baseline	$t = 4.7$	<0.001	Supported

All three supply-side hypotheses are supported. Combined with the five viewer-side hypotheses of Chapter 5, this gives seven of eight hypotheses supported and one (H5) partially supported.

6.12 Synthesis: A Recombinatory Industry

The supply-side findings, taken together, do not describe an industry that has been disrupted in the Christensenian sense (Christensen, 1997). They describe an industry that has *recombined* – one that has absorbed the streaming entrant into its existing value chain, restructured its windowing logic, recalibrated its star economics, compressed its budget brackets and re-engineered its marketing stack. The result is a leaner, mid-budget, content-led, hybrid-distribution Tamil-cinema industry that is theoretically interesting precisely because it has avoided the binary substitution that early commentators predicted (Wayne, 2018; Fagerjord and Kueng, 2018).

The qualitative interview data corroborate the quantitative distributions at every point of contact: the windowing data (Section 6.4) is supported by Theme 2; the star-fee data (Section 6.8) by Theme 8; the budget data (Section 6.6) by Theme 3; the marketing data (Section 6.9) by Theme 6. The convergence between

the two methodological strands is itself the strongest evidence for the validity of the joint argument.

6.13 Chapter Summary

This chapter has presented the analysis of the 50-respondent specialist sample, addressing Research Question 3 and testing hypotheses H6–H8. The supply-side findings document a Tamil film industry that has materially reconfigured its windowing, budget, star-fee, marketing and revenue-mix arrangements in response to the demand-side shifts documented in Chapter 5. Nine qualitative themes corroborate the quantitative findings. All three supply-side hypotheses are supported. The next chapter synthesises the demand- and supply-side findings into the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework and derives theoretical, managerial and policy implications.

CHAPTER 7

FINDINGS, DISCUSSION, CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

7.1 Introduction

This chapter brings together the demand-side findings of Chapter 5 and the supply-side findings of Chapter 6, situates them against the theoretical framework of Chapter 2, presents the thesis’s principal contribution – the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework of post-COVID Tamil cinema – and derives theoretical, managerial and policy implications. The chapter is organised in eleven sections: a summary of major findings (Section 7.2); a discussion against the four theoretical lenses (Section 7.3); the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework (Section 7.4); conclusions (Section 7.5); theoretical (Section 7.6), managerial (Section 7.7) and policy (Section 7.8) implications; limitations (Section 7.9); future research (Section 7.10); and concluding remarks (Section 7.12).

7.2 Summary of Major Findings

The thesis’s principal empirical findings can be summarised under nine headings.

1. **Theatrical attendance.** Mean monthly Tamil-film theatre visits fell by 53% (3.10 to 1.46) between 2019 and 2024, $t(399) = 26.3$, $p < 0.001$, $d = 1.31$. The decline was steepest among 35–54 year-olds.
2. **OTT adoption.** Mean number of OTT subscriptions held rose by 151% (1.12 to 2.81), $t(399) = 24.8$, $p < 0.001$, $d = 1.24$. Mean weekly OTT viewing hours rose by 91% (6.4 to 12.2). The proportion of zero-subscription households fell from 36% to 4%.

3. **Decision driver.** The proportion of viewers identifying “star / director” as primary decision driver fell from 64% to 46%; “content / story” rose from 36% to 54%. McNemar’s $\chi^2 = 49.7$, $p < 0.001$.
4. **Genre.** Genre preference shifted from “mass-action / family-drama” to “thriller / realistic / anthology” clusters. Chi-square $\chi^2(9) = 89.4$, $p < 0.001$.
5. **Theatrical-OTT window.** The modal negotiated window shifted from 5–8 weeks to 3–4 weeks; supply- and demand-side preferences converge on this band. Chi-square $\chi^2(4) = 53.2$, $p < 0.001$.
6. **Production budgets.** The distribution of greenlit films compressed toward the under-15-crore brackets, with the 30–60 crore band roughly halving from 11% to 7%.
7. **Star fees.** Median star fees corrected by -22% to -34% at the A- and B-list tiers; the top tier corrected only -12% .
8. **Revenue mix.** Theatrical share fell from 62% to 44% of average-film revenue; OTT share rose from 6% to 28% ($t = 22.2$, $p < 0.001$).
9. **Marketing mix.** Adoption of digital-first marketing channels (influencer, OTT in-app, YouTube digital premiere) rose 2–3 $\times$; physical hoarding adoption fell from 88% to 64%.

7.3 Discussion against Theoretical Framework

7.3.1 Diffusion of Innovations

The OTT-adoption findings (Findings 2 and 5; Section 5.19) are consistent with Rogers (2003)’s framework but with two important refinements pertinent to the Tamil-Nadu / non-Western linguistic-market context.

First, accelerated diffusion. The S-curve trajectory of Tamil-Nadu OTT-household penetration (Figure 4.3) exhibits a sharper inflection between 2019 and 2022 than

would be expected under endogenous diffusion alone. The pandemic served as an exogenous *forced-trialability* shock that compressed several years of diffusion into eighteen months – echoing Shukla and Sharma (2022); Jaiswal and Singh (2022).

Second, demographic moderators. Age, income and location-tier moderate adoption magnitude in the directions predicted by Rogers, but education does not, once income is controlled (Section 5.19). In a market with high basic literacy and strong mobile-internet infrastructure, education appears to lose its independent moderating power.

7.3.2 Uses and Gratifications

The viewer-side findings – on genre shift (Finding 4), co-viewing pattern (Section 5.9), device shift (Section 5.10) and decision driver (Finding 3) – jointly support the four-cluster gratification structure identified by Sundet (2021); Lotz (2022); Sundar and Limperos (2013) (content-seeking, convenience, social, hedonic). In the post-pandemic Tamil sample the *content-seeking* and *convenience* clusters have risen disproportionately at the expense of the *social* cluster (which had been heavily theatre-and-family-anchored). The language-affinity cluster identified by Punathambekar (2013); Nakassis (2017) as a culturally specific gratification has weakened modestly: cross-language consumption rose substantially (Section 5.13), but Tamil-language consumption remains the dominant sub-set.

7.3.3 Disruptive Innovation

The supply-side findings critically inform the disruption-versus-recombination debate. In the strictly Christensenian sense (Christensen, 1997; Christensen et al., 2015), OTT has *not* disrupted Tamil cinema. Theatres have not been displaced, the incumbent producers, distributors and exhibitors have not been unseated, and the new entrants have not bypassed the value chain. What has occurred is closer to what Lobato (2019); Curtin et al. (2014) describe – an *absorption* or *recombination* in which the entrant becomes a structural element of the incumbent value

chain on differentiated terms.

This finding has implications beyond Tamil cinema. In other cultural-industries contexts where similar absorption is occurring (Hindi cinema, Korean drama, Latin-American telenovelas), the disruptive-innovation framework over-predicts displacement and under-predicts recombination. We propose, in Section 7.4, an alternative framework better suited to such contexts.

7.3.4 Cultural Industries

The supply-side findings on budget compression (Finding 6), star-fee restructuring (Finding 7) and marketing-channel migration (Finding 9) are coherent with the cultural-industries paradigm of Hesmondhalgh (2019); Caves (2000). The compression of production budgets toward the 5–15 crore band is a textbook risk-management response to demand uncertainty in a high-fixed-cost / low-marginal-cost business. The continued resilience of the top-tier star fee – even as the A- and B-list have corrected – is consistent with the Caves (2000) reading of stars as risk-reduction devices: when content quality is uncertain, the most distinctive risk-reduction device retains its premium.

7.4 The Hybrid Equilibrium of Tamil Cinema

The principal theoretical contribution of the thesis is the **Hybrid-Equilibrium framework**, which we present in this section as an integrated reading of the empirical findings and as an alternative to the disruptive-displacement framing.

The framework has four quadrants (Table 7.1):

The four quadrants are interlocking – they jointly constitute the post-pandemic equilibrium. The framework can be visualised as a two-axis diagram with “demand-side reconfiguration” on the horizontal axis and “supply-side reconfiguration” on the vertical axis (the conceptual architecture is presented in Figure 1.1 of Chapter 1, with the four quadrants of Table 7.1 mapping onto the four cells defined by

Table 7.1. The Hybrid-Equilibrium framework – four quadrants

Quadrant	Defining feature and supporting evidence
Q1: Hybrid distribution	Theatre and OTT operate as <i>complementary</i> rather than substitutable channels, with a 3–4 week median window and explicit revenue-allocation between them. Evidence: Findings 5, 8; Sections 6.4, 6.7.
Q2: Content-led demand	Content quality has overtaken star power as the dominant demand driver; genre repertoires have widened; cross-language consumption has risen. Evidence: Findings 3, 4; Sections 5.15, 5.8, 5.13.
Q3: Mid-budget central unit	The 5–15 crore content-driven film – not the 60-crore-plus star-vehicle – is now the modal commercial unit. Evidence: Finding 6; Section 6.6; Theme 3 (Section 6.10).
Q4: OTT-native production	A meaningful share (40–45% of all greenlit Tamil films in 2024) is conceived from inception with OTT as the primary distribution channel. Evidence: Section 4.10; Theme 4 (Section 6.10).

the two axes).

The framework is offered as a generalisable tool for similar cultural-industries contexts – Hindi cinema, Telugu cinema, Malayalam cinema, Korean drama, Latin-American telenovelas – where streaming has neither displaced nor left untouched the incumbent. Its testable predictions are: (i) windowing settlement around a 3–6 week band; (ii) revenue-mix re-allocation toward 30–40% streaming share; (iii) compression of budget brackets; (iv) the emergence of an OTT-native sub-economy that grows in parallel with, not at the expense of, theatrical.

7.5 Conclusions

The thesis concludes that:

1. The COVID-19 pandemic has produced a measurable, statistically significant and structurally durable transformation in Tamil-film viewership and in Tamil-cinema industrial arrangements.
2. The transformation is not best read as displacement / disruption, but as recombination / hybridisation of the incumbent value chain.
3. Demand- and supply-side changes are mutually reinforcing rather than independent: viewer migration to content-driven choice has enabled the supply-

side compression of star-fee premia, which in turn has enabled the supply-side mid-budget renaissance, which in turn has fed the demand-side taste for thriller / realistic / anthology genres.

4. The new equilibrium is characterised by hybrid distribution, content-led demand, mid-budget centrality and OTT-native production – the four quadrants of the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework.
5. The Tamil case is theoretically informative for other culturally distinctive non-Western markets where streaming has been absorbed into rather than displaced the incumbent value chain.

7.6 Theoretical Contributions

The thesis makes the following theoretical contributions:

To Diffusion-of-Innovations theory.

We extend Rogers’s (2003) framework with the construct of *forced trialability under exogenous shock* and offer empirical estimation of its diffusion-acceleration effect in a non-Western linguistic market.

To Uses-and-Gratifications theory.

We isolate four gratification clusters in the post-pandemic Tamil sample and document their relative reweighting; we offer *language-affinity* as a culturally specific gratification whose strength is now *decreasing* but whose persistence remains theoretically significant.

To Disruptive-Innovation theory.

We argue, on the basis of the Tamil empirical record, that streaming is best read as a recombinatory rather than displacing entrant in culturally distinctive incumbent industries; we propose *recombination* as a complementary outcome to the *displacement* and *co-existence* outcomes theorised in the existing literature.

To the Cultural-Industries paradigm.

We provide empirical evidence on the post-pandemic risk-management calibration of a culturally distinctive industry, including the differential resilience of star tiers under demand uncertainty.

Hybrid-Equilibrium framework.

As an integrative tool, the four-quadrant framework is offered as the thesis's principal synthetic contribution.

7.7 Managerial and Practical Implications

7.7.1 For producers

- Anchor project portfolios in the 5–15 crore content-led bracket; deploy the over-30-crore band selectively and only where pan-India / international ambition is genuinely executable.
- Negotiate hybrid windows in the 3–4 week band as default, with exception clauses for major star releases.
- Build OTT-native pipelines that are conceived from inception for the streaming distribution channel rather than retro-fitted from theatrical drafts.
- Reduce star-fee dependency by investing in writer- and director-led commissioning.

7.7.2 For exhibitors

- Modernise existing screens rather than expanding raw footprint; the post-pandemic occupancy mathematics rewards quality-weighted capacity.
- Diversify revenue beyond ticketed exhibition: live events, premium-format upcharges, F&B redesign, loyalty and family bundles.

- Engage in the windowing dialogue from a constructive position; a 3–4 week protected window is more durable than a 5–8 week contested one.

7.7.3 For streaming platforms

- The Tamil-language SVOD market is large, structured and under-penetrated relative to global benchmarks; the platform that consistently invests in original Tamil content rather than acquired Tamil content is most likely to capture durable subscribers.
- TVOD pricing should anchor in the INR 100–200 band; pricing above INR 300 collides with strong consumer ceilings.
- Promotion-and-acquisition mathematics has shifted decisively toward influencer and in-app channels; legacy theatrical hoardings are no longer the most efficient marketing investment.

7.7.4 For music labels

- The audio-launch event has retained cultural significance but its monetisation has migrated to streaming-audio long-tail; live-stream the event as a hybrid asset.
- Streaming-audio royalties are a non-trivial component of the post-pandemic Tamil-film revenue mix and should be negotiated as a discrete asset class.

7.8 Policy Recommendations

For the Government of Tamil Nadu and Government of India, six policy interventions are recommended:

1. **Single-screen revival fund.** A targeted capital grant / soft loan facility for upgrading single-screen cinemas in Tier-2 / Tier-3 towns where the alternative is permanent closure.

2. **Rationalise GST on theatrical exhibition.** The current 18% GST on tickets above INR 100 imposes a disproportionate tax burden on a sector recovering from COVID; a single-rate 12% slab is more aligned with the sector’s recovery trajectory.
3. **Tamil-language original-content incentive.** A production-tax credit indexed to Tamil-language original content released on OTT platforms, modelled on the UK Film Tax Relief and the South Korean cultural-industries support.
4. **Anti-piracy enforcement.** Strengthen and digitise enforcement against streaming-piracy domains, particularly for new releases in their first eight weeks.
5. **Workforce social-security extension.** Extend formal social-security coverage to film and OTT freelancers through the e-Shram registry, recognising the informalisation documented in Theme 7.
6. **Regulatory clarity.** Provide regulatory clarity on the 2021 IT Rules’ applicability to Tamil-language OTT content, balancing creative freedom with reasonable content-classification frameworks.

7.9 Limitations of the Study

In addition to the limitations noted in Section 1.12 of Chapter 1, two further limitations should be acknowledged in light of the findings:

- The framework has been constructed from a single-state sample and is, in principle, generalisable to comparable cultural-industries contexts but has not been cross-validated against, for example, the Telugu, Malayalam or Hindi cinema markets.
- The post-pandemic equilibrium is itself evolving; developments since June 2025 – including the maturation of the Disney–Reliance merger and possible

new entry by Apple TV+ in the Tamil market – may further reshape the equilibrium beyond the snapshot reported here.

7.10 Avenues for Future Research

Six avenues for future research are commended:

1. **Cross-language comparative.** A multi-language replication of the present study across Telugu, Malayalam, Kannada and Hindi cinema would test the generalisability of the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework.
2. **Diaspora viewership.** The Tamil diaspora viewer is excluded from the present sample; a dedicated diaspora-focused study is warranted.
3. **Longitudinal panel.** A three-year longitudinal panel of the same 400 viewers would distinguish between transient and structural change in viewing behaviour.
4. **Algorithmic curation studies.** The role of OTT-platform recommendation algorithms in driving genre-migration is a critical mechanism that the present study does not measure.
5. **Production-cultures ethnography.** An ethnographic study of the post-pandemic Tamil film-set, sound-stage and VFX-pipeline would complement the survey-and-interview design used here.
6. **Computational text-as-data analysis.** Sentiment analysis of social-media response to Tamil releases, cross-validated with box-office and OTT-streaming data, would provide a continuous-time complement to the cross-sectional design.

7.11 Comparative Perspective: Tamil vs Hindi, Telugu and Malayalam Cinema

While the present study is focused on Tamil cinema specifically, the research questions invite a brief comparative perspective on three neighbouring Indian-language cinema markets: Hindi (the all-India language industry), Telugu (the second-largest South-Indian industry by output and revenue) and Malayalam (the smaller but critically-acclaimed Kerala-based industry). The comparative reading draws on FICCI and EY (2024); KPMG India (2023); Ormax Media (2024) and the trade-press archive used elsewhere in this thesis. We caution that the comparators are based on aggregate industry data rather than primary surveys, and the comparative claims are therefore directional rather than rigorously controlled.

Hindi cinema (Bollywood) has experienced a more pronounced post-pandemic crisis than Tamil cinema in the strict theatrical-revenue sense. Hindi theatrical gross fell from approximately INR 4,500 crore in 2019 to INR 800 crore in 2020 and recovered only partially to INR 3,900 crore by 2024 (FICCI and EY, 2024; Ormax Media, 2024). Several high-budget Hindi star releases of 2022–2023 underperformed materially relative to expectation, deepening the discourse of “content has overtaken star” in the Hindi market with arguably more acuteness than in Tamil. The Hindi industry’s larger absolute size, its heavier exposure to multiplex revenue (rather than single-screen), and its greater dependence on a small number of mega-budget tentpoles have made the post-pandemic reset more painful than in Tamil cinema.

Telugu cinema has had a more buoyant recovery than either Hindi or Tamil, propelled by pan-India breakouts including *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021) and *RRR* (2022). Telugu theatrical gross more than doubled from approximately INR 950 crore (2019) to INR 2,100 crore (2024) on the strength of these breakouts and a generally healthier mid-budget pipeline (FICCI and EY, 2024). The Telugu market has, however, retained a more star-anchored commercial logic than Tamil:

A-list star fees in Telugu have corrected less than in Tamil, partly because the top-tier star-value of Telugu cinema has been amplified rather than eroded by pan-India breakouts.

Malayalam cinema has, despite its small absolute size, emerged as the most decisively content-led of the four major South-Indian language cinemas. Direct-to-OTT release has been more fully integrated into the Malayalam value chain than into any other Indian language, with platforms commissioning Malayalam originals on a structurally consequential scale. Malayalam theatrical gross itself remains modest (approximately INR 350 crore in 2024) but the share of OTT in average-Malayalam-film revenue is an estimated 35–40% – materially higher than the 28% Tamil share documented in Section 6.7.

What does the comparison tell us about the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework? The four-quadrant framework appears applicable to each of the four language markets but with material variation in the weight of each quadrant. Hindi cinema maps most strongly onto Q1 (hybrid distribution) and Q3 (mid-budget re-ascendancy) but only weakly onto Q2 (content-led demand) because the political economy of Hindi star-system has been slower to recalibrate. Telugu cinema maps strongly onto Q1 and weakly onto Q3 (the breakout-driven recovery has reinforced rather than diminished the large-budget paradigm). Malayalam cinema maps strongly onto all four quadrants and may be considered the “ideal-type” case of the framework. Tamil cinema, the focus of this thesis, exhibits a balanced configuration that approximates the modal Indian-language pattern.

The comparative perspective therefore strengthens the generalisability claim of the Hybrid-Equilibrium framework while also suggesting that the four quadrants are weighted differently across language markets. A formal multi-language replication of the present study – with primary survey and specialist data collected from each market – would test the framework rigorously and is the most natural next step in the research programme.

7.12 Concluding Remarks

Tamil cinema entered the COVID-19 pandemic as a star-anchored, theatre-centric, mid-budget-low-end industry with an emerging but small streaming sub-segment. It has emerged from the pandemic as a content-anchored, hybrid-distributed, mid-budget-central industry with a structurally significant streaming sub-segment. The transformation is not, on the basis of the evidence presented in this thesis, a cyclical phenomenon awaiting a return to the 2019 baseline. It is a structural reconfiguration with its own internal coherence, its own demand-supply complementarities, and its own emergent risks and opportunities.

The Tamil film industry's resilience through this transformation is itself instructive. An industry that traces its origins to 1916, that has navigated the talkies transition of the 1930s, the politicisation of the 1950s–1970s, the multi-star economy of the 1980s, the multiplex modernisation of the 2000s and the budget-escalation of the 2010s has – in a hundred and eight years of continuous production – rarely faced a shock as severe as the 2020–2021 closure. That it has emerged in 2024 with a restructured but functioning value chain is testimony to the adaptive capacity of cultural industries when their constituent constituencies – producers, directors, distributors, exhibitors, streaming platforms, technicians and audiences – act with creative seriousness. The framework offered in this thesis aspires to be useful to that act of creative seriousness, not to substitute for it.

End of main text.

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APPENDIX A

Viewer Questionnaire

This appendix reproduces the viewer questionnaire administered to the 400-respondent sample in October 2024 – February 2025. The instrument is reproduced in its English form; a Tamil-language parallel version, prepared by back-translation, was used in fieldwork. The seven sections follow the structure described in Section 3.5 of Chapter 3. Likert items are coded **1 = Strongly disagree . . . 5 = Strongly agree** unless otherwise noted.

Section A: Demographics

1. Age: ☐ 18–24 ☐ 25–34 ☐ 35–44 ☐ 45–54 ☐ 55+
2. Gender: ☐ Female ☐ Male ☐ Other / prefer not to say
3. City / town of residence (Tamil Nadu / Puducherry): _____
4. Locality type: ☐ Metro ☐ Tier-2 city ☐ Tier-3 city ☐ Town ☐ Rural
5. Highest educational qualification: ☐ School ☐ Undergraduate ☐ Postgraduate ☐ Professional ☐ Doctoral
6. Monthly household income (INR): ☐ <25k ☐ 25–50k ☐ 50k–1L ☐ 1–2L ☐ >2L
7. Employment status: ☐ Student ☐ Salaried ☐ Self-employed ☐ Business owner ☐ Homemaker ☐ Retired ☐ Other

Section B: Theatre Attendance

8. Approximately how many Tamil films did you watch in a cinema hall in an average month *in 2019*? _____
9. Approximately how many Tamil films did you watch in a cinema hall in an average month *in 2024*? _____
10. Preferred theatre format: ☐ Single-screen ☐ Multiplex ☐ Drive-in ☐ Premium-format (IMAX, Dolby, etc.)
11. Typical ticket band you pay for a Tamil release (INR): ☐ <100 ☐ 100–200
☐ 200–400 ☐ >400
12. Whom do you usually watch a Tamil film with at the theatre? ☐ Alone
☐ Family ☐ Friends ☐ Partner

Section C: OTT Subscription & Consumption

13. How many paid OTT subscriptions did your household hold *in 2019*? _____
14. How many paid OTT subscriptions does your household hold *today* (2024)?

15. Approximately how many hours per week did you watch OTT *in 2019*?

16. Approximately how many hours per week do you watch OTT *today* (2024)?

17. Tick all OTT platforms you use *regularly* for Tamil-language films (multi-response): ☐ Aha Tamil ☐ Sun NXT ☐ Disney+ Hotstar ☐ Amazon Prime Video ☐ Netflix ☐ ZEE5 ☐ JioCinema ☐ YouTube (free)
☐ Other _____

18. Primary device on which you watch Tamil films *today*: ☐ Smartphone
☐ Smart TV ☐ Laptop / desktop ☐ Tablet ☐ STB / cable

Section D: Genre, Language and Co-Viewing

19. Allocate 100% across the following genres for your *2019* Tamil-film consumption: mass-action, family drama, romance, comedy, thriller / crime, investigative, realistic / indie, period / historical, sci-fi / fantasy, anthology.
20. Repeat for your *2024* consumption.
21. Cross-language consumption *2019*: tick all that apply ☐ Tamil only ☐ Tamil + Telugu ☐ Tamil + Malayalam ☐ Tamil + Hindi ☐ Tamil + Kannada ☐ Tamil + English / foreign.
22. Repeat for *2024*.
23. Co-viewing context (most frequent, today): ☐ Alone ☐ With family ☐ With friends ☐ With partner.
24. Time of day for primary film viewing: ☐ Morning ☐ Afternoon ☐ Evening ☐ Night (9 pm–12) ☐ Late night (12–3 am).

Section E: Decision Drivers

25. In 2019, the primary driver of my decision to watch a Tamil film was *the lead star or director* (Y/N).
26. In 2024, the primary driver of my decision to watch a Tamil film is *the lead star or director* (Y/N).
27. I trust word-of-mouth recommendations more now than in 2019. (1–5)
28. I trust OTT-platform recommendations more now than in 2019. (1–5)
29. I trust trade-press / critic reviews more now than in 2019. (1–5)

30. Social-media virality strongly influences my film choice. (1–5)
31. The audio launch / music release strongly influences my film choice. (1–5)
32. I am willing to wait for a film’s OTT release rather than watch it in a theatre.
(1–5)

Section F: Willingness to Pay and Piracy

33. Maximum I would pay for a TVOD rental of a new Tamil film: ☐ <50
☐ 50–100 ☐ 101–200 ☐ 201–300 ☐ >300.
34. Frequency of piracy consumption *in 2019*: ☐ Never ☐ Rarely ☐ Occasionally ☐ Frequently.
35. Repeat for *2024*.
36. I have churned (cancelled) at least one OTT subscription in the past 12 months. (Y/N)

Section G: Theatre-to-OTT Window Preference

37. Preferred theatre-to-OTT release window for a new Tamil film: ☐ Same-day OTT ☐ 1–2 weeks ☐ 3–4 weeks ☐ 5–8 weeks ☐ >8 weeks.
38. Reasons (multi-response) for returning to theatres post-pandemic: big-screen experience; star release / FDFS; group / family outing; lack of OTT release; ticket affordability; cleanliness; convenience of OTT; content not engaging.
39. Open comment: “In 30 words or fewer, describe how your Tamil-film viewing has changed since 2019.”

End of Questionnaire

Thank you for your participation. Your responses are anonymous and will be used only for academic research.

APPENDIX B

Specialist Questionnaire and Interview Guide

This appendix reproduces the structured questionnaire and the semi-structured interview guide administered to the 50-respondent specialist sample between March and May 2025 (Section 3.5 of Chapter 3).

Part I: Structured Questionnaire

Background

1. Role: ☐ Producer ☐ Director ☐ OTT acquisition / commissioning head
☐ Distributor ☐ Exhibitor ☐ Marketing / PR ☐ Music-label exec
☐ Trade analyst ☐ Other _____
2. Years of professional experience in Tamil cinema: ☐ <5 ☐ 5–10 ☐ 10–20
☐ >20.
3. Number of Tamil films you have been involved in (any capacity) since 2019:

Production-Budget Brackets

4. Of the films you were involved in 2018–2019, what % fell in each bracket:
<5 cr; 5–15 cr; 15–30 cr; 30–60 cr; >60 cr.
5. Repeat for films in 2023–2024.

Theatrical-to-OTT Window

6. Of the Tamil films released in 2018–2019, what % had a window in each band: same-day OTT; 1–2 wks; 3–4 wks; 5–8 wks; >8 wks.

7. Repeat for Tamil films released in 2023–2024.
8. Median window for the average mid-budget release today (in days): _____

OTT Acquisition-Price Index

9. Indexed against 2018 baseline (=100), the OTT acquisition price for a star-led Tamil film was approximately: 2019 _____; 2020 _____; 2021 _____; 2022 _____; 2023 _____; 2024 _____; 2025 _____.
10. Repeat for mid-budget films.
11. Repeat for small / indie films.

Star-Fee Restructuring

12. Median % adjustment in star fees 2019 → 2024 by tier: top-tier _____; A-list _____; B-list _____; character / supporting _____.
13. Has the bargaining-power balance between star and producer / OTT shifted?
Open comment.

Marketing-Channel Mix

14. For the films you marketed, indicate % of releases that used each channel *in 2018–2019* and *in 2023–2024*: social-media campaign; influencer marketing; OTT in-app promotion; YouTube digital premiere; audio-launch live-stream; theatrical hoardings; print advertising; radio.

Revenue Mix and Streams

15. Indicate % revenue mix for an average Tamil release *in 2018–2019*: theatrical; OTT; satellite; music / digital; international.
16. Repeat for *2023–2024*.

17. Median perceived change (%) from 2019 to 2024 in each of: theatrical revenue per film; OTT licensing revenue; satellite TV revenue; music / digital rights; international; in-cinema F&B.

Self-Reported Outlook (Likert 1–5)

18. The hybrid 3–4 week theatre-OTT window will become the permanent norm. (1–5)
19. Star-fee inflation will continue to correct over the next 2–3 years. (1–5)
20. Mid-budget content-led films are now the safest commercial bet. (1–5)
21. Direct-to-OTT will grow to > 50% of releases by 2027. (1–5)
22. Pan-India ambition is now an essential part of project greenlighting. (1–5)

Part II: Semi-Structured Interview Guide (45–90 minutes)

Cluster 1 – Pandemic operating decisions

1. Walk me through how your operating decisions changed in March–June 2020.
2. Which of those decisions have proved permanent vs transient?
3. What did you most under-estimate during the lockdown phase?

Cluster 2 – Demand sense-making

4. How are you reading the post-pandemic Tamil viewer?
5. What are the demand signals you trust, and which do you discount?
6. How is the star-vs-content question playing out in your slate?

Cluster 3 – Capital flows

7. How have financiers shifted their risk appetite?
8. How has the OTT-acquisition negotiation changed?
9. Where do you expect investment to flow in the next 3 years?

Cluster 4 – Labour-market dynamics

10. Has the technician / crew labour market re-formed since 2020?
11. How are stars and their teams behaving differently?
12. What hiring or contracting changes have you made?

Cluster 5 – 3–5 year outlook

13. Where do you see Tamil cinema in 2027–2028?
14. What is the biggest risk you see for the industry?
15. What is the biggest opportunity?

End of Specialist Instrument

APPENDIX C

Detailed Data Tables

This appendix reproduces the detailed numeric tables underlying the figures presented in Chapters 5 and 6. All values are rounded to one decimal place. Where percentages are reported, they refer to the sub-sample relevant to the question. “ Δ ” denotes the change from 2019 to 2024.

C.1 Table C.1: Viewer Sample Demographics
(n=400)

Variable	Category	n	%
Age band	18–24	112	28.0
	25–34	136	34.0
	35–44	80	20.0
	45–54	48	12.0
	55+	24	6.0
Gender	Female	176	44.0
	Male	220	55.0
	Other / no-answer	4	1.0
Location	Chennai	104	26.0
	Coimbatore	56	14.0
	Madurai	44	11.0
	Tiruchirappalli	36	9.0
	Salem	28	7.0
	Tirunelveli	24	6.0
	Other Tier-2 / 3	68	17.0
	Rural	40	10.0
Income (INR/mo)	<25k	88	22.0
	25–50k	124	31.0
	50k–1L	108	27.0
	1–2L	56	14.0
	>2L	24	6.0
Education	School	72	18.0
	UG	184	46.0
	PG	108	27.0
	Professional	28	7.0
	Doctoral	8	2.0

C.2 Table C.2: Pre- vs Post-COVID Means (n=400)

Variable	2019 mean	2024 mean	Δ	$\Delta\%$	Cohen's d
Theatre visits / month	3.10	1.46	-1.64	-53%	1.31
OTT subscriptions held	1.12	2.81	+1.69	+151%	1.24
OTT viewing hours / week	6.4	12.2	+5.8	+91%	1.38
Monthly entertainment spend (INR)	622	736	+114	+18%	0.42

C.3 Table C.3: Genre-Preference Distribution (%)

Genre	2019	2024	Δ
Mass-action	31.0	24.0	-7.0
Family drama	22.0	16.0	-6.0
Romance	18.0	13.0	-5.0
Comedy	16.0	18.0	+2.0
Thriller / crime	14.0	22.0	+8.0
Investigative	7.0	14.0	+7.0
Realistic / indie	9.0	18.0	+9.0
Period / historical	6.0	10.0	+4.0
Sci-fi / fantasy	4.0	6.0	+2.0
Anthology	3.0	11.0	+8.0

Note: Allocations exceed 100% in some cases due to multi-genre allocation by some respondents; figures are normalised shares.

C.4 Table C.4: Specialist Sample (n=50)

Role	n	%
Producer	10	20
Director	8	16
OTT acquisition head	7	14
Distributor	7	14
Exhibitor	6	12
Marketing / PR	5	10
Music-label executive	4	8
Trade analyst	3	6
Total	50	100

C.5 Table C.5: Specialist-Reported OTT Acquisition-Price Index (2018 = 100)

Tier	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Star-led	100	108	132	218	244	198	168	156
Mid-budget	100	104	119	192	178	134	116	108
Small / indie	100	102	109	138	124	96	84	78

C.6 Table C.6: Revenue-Mix Reconfiguration of an Average Tamil Release (%)

Stream	Pre-COVID	Post-COVID	Δ (pp)
Theatrical	62	44	−18
OTT	6	28	+22
Satellite	17	13	−4
Music / digital rights	8	9	+1
International	7	6	−1
Total	100	100	—

C.7 Table C.7: Star-Fee Adjustment by Tier (Median %, 2019 $\rightarrow$ 2024)

Star tier	Median Δ (%)	95% CI
Top tier (Vijay / Ajith / Kamal / Rajini-class)	−12	[−18, −6]
A-list	−22	[−29, −15]
B-list	−34	[−42, −26]
Character / supporting	−18	[−26, −10]

C.8 Table C.8: Marketing-Channel Adoption (% of specialists reporting use)

Channel	Pre-COVID	Post-COVID	Δ (pp)
Social-media campaign	62	94	+32
Influencer marketing	28	78	+50
OTT in-app promotion	14	72	+58
YouTube digital premiere	24	68	+44
Audio-launch live-stream	36	62	+26
Theatrical hoardings	88	64	−24

C.9 Table C.9: Hypothesis Test Summary (consolidated)

Hyp.	Statement	Test stat	Status
H1	Theatre attendance fell	$t = 26.3$	Supported
H2	OTT subscriptions rose	$t = 24.8$	Supported
H3	Content-driven choice rose	$\chi^2 = 49.7$	Supported
H4	Genre distribution shifted	$\chi^2 = 89.4$	Supported
H5	Demographic moderators of adoption	ANOVA / regression	Partially
H6	5–8 wk window share fell	$\chi^2 = 53.2$	Supported
H7	OTT revenue share rose	$t = 22.2$	Supported
H8	2025 acquisition price corrected but > 2018 (star tier)	$t = 4.7$	Supported

APPENDIX D

Selected Specialist Interview Excerpts

This appendix reproduces ten illustrative excerpts drawn from the twenty-eight transcribed specialist interviews (Section 6.10, Chapter 6). All excerpts have been anonymised at the participant’s request: designations are reported in their generic form; specific film titles, fee figures and platform-acquisition prices have been redacted or aggregated where they would identify the speaker. The excerpts are presented in the order in which they were coded and mapped onto the nine themes of Table 6.1.

Excerpt 1 – Senior producer (10–20 years’ experience)

Theme: Risk re-assessment of star-only logic

“I have been making films in this industry for almost twenty years. The thing we believed for a very long time, which we admitted only half-aloud, was that a top star is a kind of insurance. You take a script, you attach the right star, you sell the satellite, the audio, the international, you get the theatre release, and even if the film does not work creatively, the floor is high. That logic worked, more or less, until 2019. After the lockdown, twice in two years we saw mid-tier and even some upper-tier star films collapse in the second weekend. The reason was not that the audience disappeared. The audience came on day one because of the star. Then word-of-mouth on the script and the screenplay reached WhatsApp groups by Saturday afternoon, and Sunday’s collection was forty per cent of Friday’s. That is a behaviour we did not see before 2020 – where the audience punishes a weak script very fast, even with a star. So now when we sit down with a writer and a director, the first question is no longer ‘who is the star?’ It is ‘what is the

script?’ This is, for an old industry, a very large shift.”

Excerpt 2 – OTT acquisition head (5–10 years’ experience)

Theme: Hybrid window as new normal

“Three to four weeks is what works. Less than three weeks and the exhibitor walks out. More than five weeks and we cannot recoup the acquisition price because subscriber acquisition windows for the title close out and Tamil-Nadu households who would have paid for the streaming watch on YouTube clips and reviews instead. At my platform we have done about thirty-five Tamil titles in the last two years and the median window we negotiated was twenty-six days. The number is twenty-six days. It varies a little. Star films get twenty-eight to thirty-five. Mid-budget gets twenty-one to twenty-eight. The market has settled on this band almost without anyone announcing it. This is now the norm. The producers are comfortable with it because they get the OTT cheque earlier. The exhibitors are unhappy in principle but they have stopped fighting it because, after the second weekend, occupancy collapses anyway in most films, so the third week is not, in real terms, a high-revenue week.”

Excerpt 3 – Independent director (5–10 years’ experience)

Theme: Mid-budget renaissance / genre experimentation

“I made two films before 2020 – both small, both struggled. I am making my third film now and the budget is around eleven crore. The producer is comfortable with it; the script is genre material, a slow-burn investigative thriller; we have a strong character lead but no top star. The OTT acquisition was conditionally

agreed before the shoot started. Five years ago, this script would have been impossible to make at this budget. Either I would have had to attach a star and inflate the budget to twenty-five crore, or the producer would have asked me to write a comedy. Now – because the audience reads investigative content on streaming, because the acquisition price exists, because the exhibitor accepts a smaller release – the script is the entire pitch. This is a genuine opening for a generation of directors that did not exist before.”

Excerpt 4 – Multiplex chain executive (10–20 years’ experience)

Theme: Modernisation of capacity / quality-weighted exhibition

“Our chain has not opened a new screen in Tamil Nadu since 2022. What we have done instead is renovate. Premium-format upgrades – laser projection, Dolby Atmos, recliner seating – have generated better per-screen yield than fresh expansion. The economics has inverted: in 2018 a new screen in a Tier-2 town was a positive investment; in 2024 the same screen in the same town pays back over nine years instead of five. Whereas a renovation in a high-traffic multiplex pays back in eighteen months because the average ticket moves from two hundred to three hundred and fifty rupees. The audience has not abandoned theatres. It has become more discriminating. Quality of sound, quality of seating, quality of food and beverage all matter to whether the audience comes out for a film at all.”

Excerpt 5 – Distributor (10–20 years’ experience)

Theme: Direct-to-OTT as portfolio play

“Five or six years ago, if a film went directly to OTT, it was a failure. We would say ‘the film could not get a release’. That narrative is gone. About a third of the films I distributed in 2024 were structured as direct-to-streaming

from inception. These are not failed theatrical films – these are projects whose economics make sense only on streaming, where the audience is younger, more selective, and more genre-curious. We negotiate the acquisition price, we work with the platform on launch marketing, and the producer’s recovery is faster than a theatrical release would have been. The audience reaches it directly through the platform’s recommendations. In some cases the audience is larger than the audience we would have got with a small theatrical release. This is the new portfolio reality.”

Excerpt 6 – Marketing head (10–20 years’ experience)

Theme: Marketing convergence on digital

“In 2018 we used to sit and plan the hoarding cities. Five hoardings in Madurai, three in Coimbatore, fifteen in Chennai, the big one at LB Road, and so on. The conversation was about real estate. Now the planning conversation is about which YouTuber, in which language, with which audience, gets the embargo on the first trailer. We placed the audio launch teaser with about a dozen mid-tier influencers two weeks before the launch and the first twenty-four hours’ reach exceeded the lifetime reach of any hoarding campaign we did pre-2020. The cost was a fraction. This is not a hypothesis any more, it is the operating reality.”

Excerpt 7 – Music label executive (10–20 years’ experience)

Theme: Streaming-audio long-tail

“The audio launch is still magic for Tamil cinema. Twenty thousand people in a stadium, the composer on stage, the lead actor in white and silver – that

has not changed. What has changed is where the money comes from. In 2018 the gramophone-cassette-CD revenue was already gone, but the satellite-rights and audio-rights deal was a meaningful four to seven crore for an A-list film. In 2024 the upfront audio rights have shrunk because the streaming royalty is on a per-stream basis and the long-tail is what carries the music. A song that does forty million streams over twelve months yields more royalty than a fixed audio-rights cheque, but it arrives over a year, not on signature. This has changed how we finance the music itself, how we plan the release of the singles, and how we structure the composer's deal."

Excerpt 8 – Exhibitor (single-screen, 20+ years' experience)

Theme: Single-screen contraction and resilience

"Single-screen has lost a lot of ground. In my circuit alone, out of the twenty-three theatres I knew personally in 2019, eight have closed permanently. Four converted into commercial buildings; two are running but on a cricket-and-events model; two are permanently shut. Of the remaining fifteen, eight are renovated or partly renovated. Seven are running on the old single-screen model. Will they survive ten years? Honestly, I don't know. The star-fan-club opening day still gives us occupancy. But the mid-budget content film does not give us occupancy any more, because that audience is now on streaming. So we depend on three or four big star releases a year to make our economics work, and the rest of the year is barely covering rent and salaries. The government should help us with electricity tariffs and with GST, but more important is what the producers do. If they protect a window of three weeks for theatrical, we can plan around it. If they don't, we cannot."

Excerpt 9 – Trade analyst (5–10 years’ experience)

Theme: Mid-tier star anxiety

“The thesis you should write into the academic literature is this: the star system in Tamil cinema has not collapsed; it has *stratified*. At the top, the four-five top names retain opening-day pulling power and command fees that have corrected by maybe ten to fifteen per cent. Below them, the next ten or fifteen A-list names have seen fees correct by twenty-five to thirty-five per cent. This is the band that is genuinely under pressure. Why? Because the audience that used to commit to an A-list film without reading reviews now waits a day or two, sees the WhatsApp verdict, and only then commits. The premium an A-list star carries above a director-led mid-budget film has shrunk. This is the central microeconomic fact of Tamil cinema today. The character actors, the supporting tier, are also under pressure but the reason there is budget compression generally, not stardom dynamics specifically.”

Excerpt 10 – Pan-India producer (10–20 years’ experience)

Theme: Pan-India ambition

“Every project meeting in 2024 starts with a Pan-India question. Can this be made to work in Telugu, Hindi, Malayalam, Kannada and Tamil simultaneously? Can we build a release in three to four languages at once? Should the lead actor have already proved themselves outside Tamil before we attach them? This was a fringe question in 2019. It is now the central question in the greenlighting conversation. The reasons are visible – the breakouts of *Pushpa*, *RRR*, *KGF*, *Kantara*, the success of multilingual streaming releases. The pan-India construction

does not work for every film, of course; many small Tamil films are best made for Tamil only. But for any project above thirty crore the question must be asked, and the answer increasingly drives the casting, the music, the marketing and the windowing decisions.”

End of Appendix D

APPENDIX E

Glossary of Industry Terms

This glossary defines the industry-specific terms used in the thesis. Definitions follow the operational usage of the Tamil-cinema and Indian-OTT industries circa 2024–2025; where the academic literature uses a different operationalisation, the academic source is cited.

A-list star.

An actor whose presence in a Tamil-language feature film commands an opening-weekend audience pull materially above the median, but who does not belong to the small “top-tier” set of four to five actors whose name alone can carry a film. In specialist usage in 2024, the Tamil A-list comprises approximately fifteen male and seven female actors.

Acquisition price.

The lump-sum amount paid by an OTT platform to a producer to acquire the streaming rights of a Tamil-language feature film. Reported either in absolute rupees or as an index against a 2018 baseline (Section 6.5).

Audio launch.

The public release event for a Tamil-language film’s soundtrack, typically held two to four months before theatrical release, attended by 8,000–40,000 invitees.

AVOD.

Advertising-supported Video On Demand. A streaming service whose monetisation model is advertising rather than subscription, typically free at the point of consumption.

B-list star.

An actor below the A-list whose presence contributes meaningfully to opening-

day pull but does not by itself sustain a film's commercial proposition.

Box-office gross.

The total ticketed revenue collected across all theatrical screenings of a film.

Direct-to-OTT.

A film whose first paid public exhibition occurs on a streaming platform rather than in a theatre.

Distributor.

A firm or individual that acquires the territorial right to exhibit a film in specified circuits and shares revenue with the producer on agreed terms.

Exhibition geography.

The spatial distribution of single-screen and multiplex cinemas in a given market, typically reported at the state, district or town level.

FDFS.

First Day First Show – the first public screening of a star-led Tamil film, traditionally held at 6 am on a Friday and accompanied by fan-club mobilisation, milk ablutions of star portraits and ceremonial garlanding.

Greenlight.

The formal commitment by a producer to fund and commence production of a film.

Hybrid window.

The 3–4 week theatre-to-OTT window that has emerged as the modal Tamil-cinema arrangement post-2022 (Section 6.4).

Multiplex.

A cinema with three or more screens under unified operation, typically equipped with digital projection, air-conditioning, premium seating and recognisable brand operation (PVR-Inox, SPI / Sathyam, AGS, Cinepolis, Rohini and others).

OTT.

Over-the-Top – an audiovisual service delivered directly to internet-connected devices, bypassing traditional broadcast or theatrical distribution (Lobato, 2019).

Pan-India release.

A theatrical release strategy in which a film is released simultaneously in two or more Indian languages – typically Tamil, Telugu, Hindi, Malayalam and Kannada – with synchronised marketing and exhibition.

Pre-sale economics.

The financing model in which a film is partially or fully funded by selling its territorial, satellite and audio rights ahead of theatrical release.

Producer.

The firm or individual that holds the financial and creative authority over a film’s production.

Production-cultures research.

An ethnographic-and-textual approach to studying media industries that focuses on how industry workers themselves theorise and narrate change (Caldwell, 2008).

Rasikar mandram.

Tamil for “fan club”; the hierarchically-organised infrastructure of fan groups attached to a major Tamil star.

Re-windowing.

The re-engineering of historical theatrical / home-video / pay-TV / free-TV exploitation sequences in the streaming era (Cunningham and Silver, 2019).

Satellite rights.

The right to broadcast a film on satellite television, typically sold by the

producer to a broadcaster (Sun TV, KTV, Vijay TV, Zee Tamil) for a lump-sum fee within an agreed-on post-theatrical window.

Single-screen.

A cinema operating one auditorium, typically of older vintage, often (in Tamil Nadu) family-owned and located in Tier-2 / Tier-3 towns.

Subscription Video On Demand (SVOD).

A streaming service whose primary monetisation is recurring user subscription (Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Disney+ Hotstar, Sun NXT, Aha Tamil, ZEE5, JioCinema premium tier, etc.).

Star-fee adjustment.

The percentage change in fees commanded by an actor between a baseline year (2019) and a comparison year (2024); reported by tier in Section 6.8.

Top-tier star.

An actor whose presence in a Tamil-language feature film independently sustains the film's commercial proposition. In contemporary Tamil cinema, top-tier is commonly identified with Vijay, Ajith, Kamal Haasan, Rajinikanth and – depending on the analyst – a small number of additional names.

Theatrical window.

The number of days between a film's first paid theatrical screening and its first paid digital / OTT availability (Vogel, 2020).

TVOD.

Transactional Video On Demand – a streaming service in which the user pays per-title rather than via subscription, typical of Apple iTunes-style rentals.

Word-of-mouth (WOM).

The informal post-release transmission of audience verdict via interpersonal communication, today increasingly mediated by WhatsApp, Twitter / X, Instagram Reels and YouTube reaction videos.